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CITY: PG 3

Rain cools, chaos rules

NATION: PG 6

Govt can't stop me from raising students' voice: Rahul

FILM: PG 16

'Dance made me more expressive as an actor'

Rijiju calls Rahul again on delimitation Bill; LoP says hold all-party meet first

OPPN BLAMES GOVT FOR PARLIAMENT DISRUPTIONS; RIJIJU SAYS PM, HM AVAILABLE FOR DISCUSSION

VINAY KUMAR

NEW DELHI: In its ongoing efforts to reach out to the Opposition amid the Parliament deadlock, Parliamentary Affairs Minister Kiren Rijiju on Thursday held a telephonic conversation with Leader of Opposition Rahul Gandhi to seek the Congress' support for the proposed women's reservation and delimitation Bill. Gandhi, however, insisted that the government convene an all-party meeting on the legislation before moving ahead, sources said.

This was the second phone conversation between the two leaders in the past few days. Rijiju has also met Gandhi twice in the last 10 days as part of the government's efforts to ensure the smooth functioning of Parliament.

"I had a productive conversation with Rahul Gandhi. I have made a request on a few specific issues and also discussed other matters. We expect continuous communication and coordinated action with the Congress and other Opposition parties," Rijiju told reporters in the Parliament House complex.

Sources said the minister did not commit to convening an all-party meeting but conveyed that the government was working towards building a consensus on the proposed legislation.

The Centre is making a fresh push to pass the Constitution (131st Amendment) Continued on P4

CLOSER LOOK

- Govt seeks consensus on the proposed constitutional amendment
- This was Rijiju's second phone call to Rahul in recent days
- Rijiju also met Rahul twice in the past 10 days
- Govt aims to reintroduce the Bill next week
- Rajya Sabha Chairman asks Rijiju to convey Opposition's demand to Amit Shah
- Kharge criticises Shah for not making a statement in Parliament

Modi tells Rajya Sabha MPs to stay rooted, avoid power brokers

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: Amid the ongoing Parliament logjam, Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Thursday met 36 Rajya Sabha MPs over breakfast, including several who joined the BJP after quitting the Trinamool Congress (TMC), Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) and Biju Janata Dal (BJD).

During the interaction, Modi urged the lawmakers to remain connected to their roots, stay in regular touch with their constituencies and avoid lobbyists and power brokers seeking to exploit their position, sources said. Continued on P4

Govt slashes sensitive content removal time to two hours

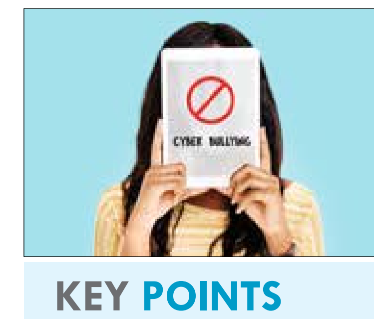
Unlawful AI-generated content must be removed within three hours of government or court order

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: The Centre has tightened the rules governing social media platforms to curb the spread of AI-generated deepfakes and other harmful synthetic content, cutting the time available for removing sensitive material to just two hours and significantly reducing the deadline for complying with government or court takedown orders.

According to an official statement issued on Thursday, amendments to the Information Technology (Intermediary Guidelines and Digital Media Ethics Code) Rules, 2021, made on February 10, 2026, are aimed at strengthening the regulatory framework for synthetically generated information, including AI-generated text, audio, images and videos. The government said the changes are intended to build "an open, safe, trusted and accountable cyberspace" while supporting the responsible development and use of artificial intelligence.

Under the revised rules, intermediaries must remove unlawful content within three hours of receiving a valid, reasoned notice from the appropriate government or a court, compared with the earlier 36-hour deadline. The grievance redressal timeline for general complaints has also been reduced from 72 hours to 36 hours. Complaints involving sensitive issues such as nudity, impersonation and similar categories must now be addressed within two hours instead of the earlier 24 hours. Continued on P4



KEY POINTS

- General grievance redress timeline reduced from 72 hours to 36 hours
- Platforms must label AI-generated content and attach traceable metadata
- Users to be informed of legal consequences of sharing unlawful AI content
- Large social media platforms must proactively detect child abuse and rape-related content

Modi, Netanyahu discuss West Asia situation, review ties

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Prime Minister Narendra Modi and his Israeli counterpart Benjamin Netanyahu spoke over the phone on Thursday, reviewing the progress of the India-Israel Special Strategic Partnership and exchanging views on the evolving situation in West Asia amid continuing regional tensions. According to the Prime Minister's Office (PMO), the two leaders reaffirmed their commitment to expanding cooperation across multiple sectors for the mutual benefit of both countries and agreed to remain in touch as developments unfold.

After the conversation, Modi said in a post on X, "Received a phone call from Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu. We reviewed progress on various aspects of the India-Israel Special Strategic Partnership which continues to grow from strength-to-strength. We also exchanged views on the current situation in West Asia."

The discussion came as the conflict in West Asia has continued for more than five months without a lasting solution. On Thursday, Iran said it was in the final stage of drafting an agreement with Oman on the Strait of Hormuz, while reports from Lebanon said two Israeli soldiers were killed in the fighting.

The Strait of Hormuz remains one of the world's most important shipping routes. Continued on P4

CLOSER LOOK

- Leaders agree to stay in touch amid continuing regional tensions
- Modi says India-Israel partnership continues to grow
- Call comes as West Asia conflict enters sixth month

TRANSACTIONS REMAIN FREE FOR NOW

LS passes Bill authorising govt to allow charges on UPI and digital payments

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Lok Sabha on Thursday passed a Bill to amend the Payment and Settlement Systems Act, 2007, giving the central government the power to allow banks and payment service providers to levy charges on Unified Payments Interface (UPI) and other notified electronic payment modes.

The amendment was cleared by voice vote without discussion amid disruptions after the House resumed at 2 pm following an earlier adjournment. Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman moved the Taxation and Other Laws (Amendment) Bill, 2026, which seeks to amend the Payment and Settlement Systems Act, 2007, the Income Tax Act, 2025, and the Finance Act, 2026.

The change removes the existing legal restriction under Section 10A of the Payment and Settlement Systems Act, which currently bars banks and payment system providers from imposing charges, directly or indirectly, on electronic payment modes prescribed under Section 269SU of the Income Tax Act, 1961. Continued on P4

HIGHLIGHTS

- Amendment removes legal bar on banks, PSPs levying MDR on notified electronic payments
- Govt says move aims to create sustainable revenue model for digital payments ecosystem
- Section 10A revised to let Centre notify electronic payment modes covered under law

Atiq Ahmed's youngest son killed in road accident

BISWAJEET BANERJEE

LUCKNOW: Aban Ahmed, the youngest son of slain gangster-politician and former MP Atiq Ahmed, was killed in a road accident in Uttar Pradesh's Jhansi district on Thursday while travelling to meet his elder brother Ali Ahmed, who is lodged in Jhansi jail. Another occupant of the vehicle also died, while three others sustained serious injuries.

The accident took place on the Jhansi-Kanpur National Highway in the Poonch police station area. According to police, all five occupants were travelling from Prayagraj to Jhansi to meet Ali Ahmed, who has been lodged in the high-security Jhansi jail since October 2025.

Police said the accident occurred around 10.30 am near Khilli village when a speeding Hyundai Creta allegedly went out of control after the driver attempted to avoid an animal that suddenly came onto the highway. The vehicle rammed into the road divider, leaving its front portion completely mangled.

Aban Ahmed and Sonu Khan, who were seated in the front, suffered severe head injuries and died on the spot. Continued on P4

Tehelka founder Tejpal convicted of rape, sentenced to ten years in prison

MPOST BUREAU

PANAJI: The Bombay High Court on Thursday convicted former Tehelka editor-in-chief Tarun Tejpal of rape in the 2013 sexual assault case involving a junior colleague, overturning his acquittal by a Goa trial court in 2021. Calling the earlier verdict "perverse", the court held that it was based on stereotypes about how a survivor of sexual assault should behave and sentenced the 62-year-old journalist to 10 years of rigorous imprisonment. It also imposed a fine of Rs 10.21 lakh, directing that the entire amount be paid to the survivor.

A division bench of Justices Neela Gokhale and Amit Jamsandekar convicted Tejpal under Section 376(2)(f) of the Indian Penal Code for rape by a person in a position of trust or authority, along with Sections 354(a) for sexual harassment and 354(b) for assault or use of criminal force with intent to disrobe. Besides the 10-year sentence under the rape charge, the court awarded one year and three years under the other two offences respectively, with all sentences to run concurrently. The bench directed Tejpal to surrender within four weeks after initially granting him two weeks.

The case stems from allegations that Tejpal sexually assaulted a junior colleague inside a hotel elevator during Tehelka's ThinkFest event at a luxury hotel in Bambolim, Goa, in November 2013. Continued on P4

KEY POINTS

- Tejpal convicted under IPC Sections 376(2)(f), 354(a) and 354(b)
- HC calls trial court's acquittal "perverse", says it relied on stereotypes
- Says survivor need not fit image of a "perfect victim" to be believed

Meta grilled over whether its platforms follow Indian laws

Faces govt scrutiny on day-2 over algorithms, platform compliance; co says working on issues

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: The Centre on Thursday questioned Meta on whether its platforms are operating in accordance with Indian laws and the Constitution, making it clear that global technology companies cannot apply legal standards followed in the United States or Europe while operating in India.

During the second consecutive day of meetings with Meta's global leadership, government officials sought detailed clarifications on the company's legal compliance framework, content moderation systems and safeguards to ensure adherence to Indian regulations. Officials said the discussions covered both policy and technical aspects of Meta's operations, including its recommendation algorithms and internal checks.

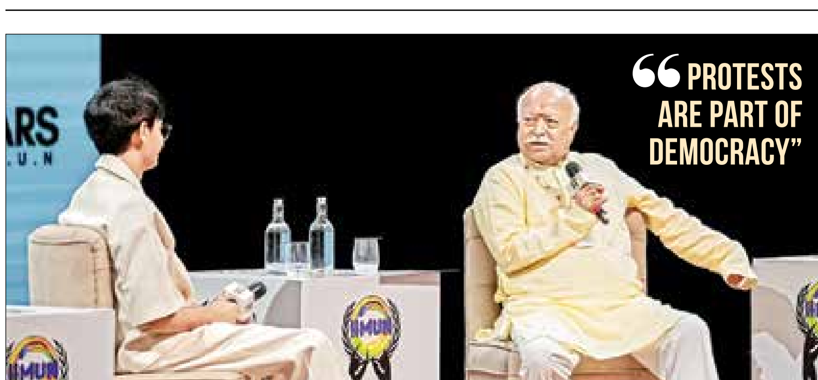
"The fundamental question is whether Meta is following India's laws. That has multiple dimensions; there is a technical dimension and a policy dimension. We want to know if their team understands the law," a government source said after the meeting.

According to officials, the government also questioned whether Meta has adequate guardrails and compliance mechanisms to meet constitutional and legal requirements in India. Sources said the Centre made it clear that the rule of law and the Constitution are supreme, and social media platforms cannot operate in the country based on legal principles applicable in other jurisdictions.

The meeting, which lasted about an hour, was attended by Information Technology Minister Ashwini Vaishnaw and Meta's global team led by Global Affairs Chief Joel Kaplan. It followed Wednesday's discussions with IT Secretary S Krishnan and the minister after the government summoned the company over the temporary restriction of Prime Minister Narendra Modi's Facebook post last month. Continued on P4

'GEN Z GRIEVANCES ARE GENUINE, PROTEST LAWFUL FORM OF DIALOGUE'

'Gen Z are our own, protesting doesn't make them anti-national': Bhagwat



"PROTESTS ARE PART OF DEMOCRACY"

KEY POINTS

- Backs 6% GDP for education
- Questions Jantar Mantar police action
- Seeks wider education reforms
- Says reservation must continue till inequality ends
- Favours dialogue after conflicts
- LGBTQIA+ needs social acceptance, legal framework
- Opposes social media ban
- WARNS AGAINST FAKE CONTENT ONLINE

SIMONTINI BHATTACHARJEE

MUMBAI: Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh (RSS) chief Mohan Bhagwat on Thursday said Gen Z protesters should not be branded "anti-national", describing them as "our own people" who seek logical answers and whose concerns deserve to be heard.

Speaking during an interaction with IIMUN founder Rishabh Shah in the presence of about 2,000 Gen Z and Gen Alpha participants at the Nita Mukesh Ambani Cultural Centre (NMACC) in Mumbai, Bhagwat said the younger generation was more questioning than previous generations.

The BJP government's handling of the protests, which turned violent during the July 20 march to Parliament in New Delhi called by the Cockroach Janta Party (CJP), has invited criticism from different quarters.

"When we were of their age, we would listen to our elders. We never used to question. Now, Gen Z wants logical answers," he said.

"If Gen Z is protesting, they are not anti-nationals. They are our own people, our next generation. I think the new generation, Gen Z and Gen Alpha, is more honest than Continued on P4

Centre denies plan to blend ethanol with ATF

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Centre on Thursday rejected claims that it is considering blending ethanol with Aviation Turbine Fuel (ATF), calling such reports "completely false and irresponsible" and stating that no such proposal is under consideration. The clarification came after Aam Aadmi Party chief Arvind Kejriwal alleged on X that the government planned to mix ethanol with ATF, citing unnamed experts who claimed it could affect flight safety.

Civil Aviation Minister K Rammohan Naidu said spreading misinformation about aviation safety creates needless anxiety among air travellers. "The claim that the government plans to blend ethanol with Aviation Turbine Fuel (ATF) is completely false and irresponsible. There is no such proposal," he said.

Naidu clarified that ethanol and Sustainable Aviation Fuel (SAF) are entirely different and should not be confused. He said SAF is an internationally certified aviation fuel recognised by the International Civil Aviation Organisation (ICAO), adopted globally, and approved for commercial use only after rigorous testing and compliance with strict international safety standards. Passenger safety, he added, remains the government's highest priority.

Separately, the Commerce and Industry Ministry dismissed reports Continued on P4

> "THE CLAIM THAT THE GOVERNMENT PLANS TO BLEND ETHANOL WITH AVIATION TURBINE FUEL (ATF) IS COMPLETELY FALSE AND IRRESPONSIBLE. THERE IS NO SUCH PROPOSAL"

Over 1.5K police personnel, CAPF units deployed

Kanwar Yatra: Key entry, exit routes secured

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: More than 1,500 police personnel, along with contingents of the Central Armed Police Force (CAPF), have been deployed across northeast Delhi as part of security measures in view of the ongoing Kanwar Yatra, an officer said on Thursday.

The annual pilgrimage, which began July 30 with the ushering in of the month of Shravan, will conclude August 11 on the occasion of Shravan Shivaratri, when devotees offer holy Ganga water at Shiva temples.

"A large number of Kanwariyas from Uttar Pradesh pass through northeast Delhi en route to Haryana and Rajasthan, making the district one of the key transit corridors for the yatra," a senior police officer said. The officer said comprehensive law and order, security and traffic measures have been put in place to ensure smooth and peaceful movement of devotees. The district, which shares a border with Uttar Pradesh, has six permanent border pickets and nine motorable entry points through which Kanwariyas enter Delhi.

Police said 78 Kanwar camps have been set up in the district, of which 31 are fully operational while the remaining are being prepared for devotees.

"Senior officers will monitor deployment and security measures throughout the pilgrimage period. Four sub-control rooms have also been established at Y-Point Dharampura, Maujpur Chowk, Khajuri Khas Chowk and near Gokalpuri T-Point to provide round-the-clock assistance and coordinate emergency response," the officer said.

According to police, a total of 1,533 personnel have been deployed, including four assistant commissioners, 40 inspectors, 262 sub-inspectors and assistant sub-inspectors, 1,145 constables and head constables, and 81 women personnel.

An additional 250 CAPF personnel have been deployed in two shifts to assist in maintaining security and law and order.

The police have also deployed 27 PCR vans, five Prakhar vehicles and 107 motorcycles for patrolling along Kanwar yatra routes. Authorities have directed Kanwar camp organisers to install CCTV cameras and erect 'machans' (watch towers) to strengthen surveillance.

The main entry points for Kanwariyas include Keshav Chowk, DLF Border, Bhopura Border, Gokalpuri, Lal Bagh Mandi, Sabhapur-Khajuri Pusta and Chauhan Patti, while the key exit routes are the Old Yamuna Bridge, Yudhister Setu, Signature Bridge and Wazirabad Bridge.

The police said interstate coordination meetings have been held with counterparts in neighbouring states, while senior officers also met representatives of civic agencies, peace committee members, priests and imams to ensure coordinated management and communal harmony during the yatra.

Traffic restrictions have been imposed for the Kanwar Yatra, with heavy commercial vehicles restricted or diverted on key roads till August 12. GT Road between Apsara Border and Yamuna Bridge will remain closed from August 9 to 12, while Kanwariya movement is barred on the Delhi-Dehradun Expressway.

FROM 'DR JHATKA' TO MURDER ACCUSED

Delhi Police catches fugitive after 28 years

OUR CORRESPONDENT

> "Rajinder Bairagi alias Rajinder Singh Yadav alias 'Dr Jhatka', a proclaimed offender in multiple cases in Delhi and Hry, had been absconding since escaping from UP Police custody in 1999 while being escorted in handcuffs from Gzb Jail to a court in Hry"

NEW DELHI: A man who allegedly reinvented himself as a small-town "doctor", married, raised a family and quietly ran a clinic in Madhya Pradesh while evading law for nearly 28 years over the murder of a cop has been finally arrested by the Delhi Police.

Rajinder Bairagi alias Rajinder Singh Yadav alias "Dr Jhatka" (53), a proclaimed offender in multiple cases in Delhi and Haryana, had been absconding since escaping from Uttar Pradesh Police custody in 1999 while being escorted in handcuffs from Ghaziabad Jail to a court in Haryana, an official said on Thursday.

"He was arrested from Mungaoli in Madhya Pradesh's Ashok Nagar district after a months-long multi-state operation by the Crime Branch," Deputy Commissioner of Police (Crime Branch) Chander Kumar Singh said.

The officer further said that the accused managed to remain beyond the reach of law enforcement by assuming a fresh identity, obtaining official documents, including an Aadhaar card, PAN card, voter identity card, driving licence and domicile certificate, and blending into the local community.

Police said he first stayed in Maharashtra, where he worked as a physical education teacher at a Kendriya Vidyalaya for about a year, before shifting to Mungaoli.

"In MP, he adopted the name Rajender Singh Yadav, married a government Auxiliary Nurse Midwife in 2003, started working as an unregistered medical practitioner -- earning the nickname 'Dr Jhatka' -- and simultaneously dealt in property and small contracts," the officer said.

The couple has two school-going children, and neighbours knew him only by his assumed identity, making it difficult for police to establish his real background.

The officer further said that the breakthrough came when the crime branch reopened efforts to trace long-absconding proclaimed offenders wanted in heinous crimes. Officers were initially pursuing two 1997 attempt-to-murder cases registered at Janakpuri police station in Delhi, in which Rajinder had been declared a proclaimed offender in 2008.

During the investigation, officers uncovered his alleged role in the sensational 1998 murder of Haryana Police personnel Jai Bhagwan.

According to the police, Rajinder and five armed associates allegedly opened indiscriminate fire during a wedding function at Saiyan Khera village in Sonipat on May 10, 1998, following an altercation with the bride's family.

"Jai Bhagwan, the bride's uncle and a serving Haryana Police personnel, was killed, while another person suffered critical injuries.

Rajinder was arrested in the case but allegedly escaped from police custody on February 14, 1999, at Gannaur railway station while being taken from Ghaziabad Jail to a Sonipat court, prompting another criminal case against him," the officer said.

The team of the crime branch said painstaking field intelligence, technical surveillance and digital analysis eventually exposed his false identity despite the official documents he had procured. After confirming his movements, a police team raided his residence in Mungaoli and apprehended him.

"The team procured his transit remand, and he was formally arrested in Delhi," the officer said, adding that Rajinder is wanted in at least eight criminal cases, including murder, attempt to murder, Arms Act violations, theft and escape from lawful custody.

Further interrogation is underway to ascertain whether he was involved in other offences during the nearly three decades he remained a fugitive.

L&T bags ₹2,970-crore contract for two Noida Metro extensions

DIPIKA KIROLA

NOIDA: The Noida Metro Rail Corporation (NMRC) has selected Larsen & Toubro (L&T) to undertake the civil construction of two extensions of the Aqua Line, awarding the company a contract worth Rs 2,970 crore.

The financial bids were opened on Thursday, with L&T emerging as the successful bidder among nine participants. The project, which had to be re-tendered twice, is expected to enter the construction phase within a month.

NMRC managing director Krishna Karunesh said both corridors will be entirely elevated. While L&T will execute the civil works, NMRC will oversee and supervise the project.

The larger extension will connect Botanical Garden, which is served by the Delhi Metro's Blue and Magenta lines, with Sector 142 on the Aqua Line. The 12.5-km corridor, estimated to cost Rs 2,254.35 crore, will have stations at Botanical Garden, Sector 44, Noida Office (Sector 94), Sectors 97, 105, 108 and 93, and Panchsheel Balak Inter College.

The second extension, from the Greater Noida depot to Bodaki, will cover 2.6 km at an estimated cost of Rs 416 crore. It will have stations at Junpat and Bodaki Railway Station, improving last-mile connectivity and providing a direct metro link to the railway station.

The Botanical Garden extension is expected to ease travel between Delhi and Greater Noida by eliminating the interchange at Sector 52 and the transfer to Sector 51, allowing commuters to travel directly to Sector 142.

Cops: Rohit Choudhary gang member arrested

NEW DELHI: The Delhi Police has arrested a member of the Rohit Choudhary gang, who had been evading arrest for over a year and was declared a proclaimed offender, an official said on Thursday.

The accused, identified as Azam (40), a resident of Chandan Hola in south Delhi and a Bad Character (BC) of Fatehpur Beri police station, was apprehended in Tapukara, Rajasthan during an overnight operation after police tracked his movements in Alwar, Tijara and Bhiwadi, he said.

Police said Azam was wanted in five criminal cases, including robbery, assault on police personnel, obstruction of public servants in the discharge of duty and theft.

"He has more than a dozen criminal cases registered against him in Delhi and was allegedly working for the Rohit Choudhary gang by facilitating the supply of illegal arms to gang members and other criminals," a senior police officer said.

The officer said Azam had been absconding since securing bail in a 2017 robbery case registered at the Fatehpur Beri police station.

Azam, a suspected Rohit Choudhary gang member, allegedly escaped custody in 2025 after attacking police. Arrested in Rajasthan, he has criminal cases dating to 2012 involving robbery, theft, assault and Arms Act violations. MPOST

News at a glance

AIIMS TREATS COMPLEX SUPER OBESITY CASE

NEW DELHI: A multi-disciplinary team at AIIMS Delhi successfully treated a 32-year-old man with super obesity, enabling him to undergo bariatric surgery after prolonged preoperative optimisation. Admitted at 209 kg with a BMI of 74 and severe sleep apnoea, he required a tracheostomy and CPAP support. A 32-day very low-calorie diet and multidisciplinary care reduced his weight to 172 kg, enabling surgery. He underwent laparoscopic one-anastomosis gastric bypass and was weaned off CPAP.

DU APPOINTS OFFICIALS FOR DUSU POLLS

NEW DELHI: DU has appointed the Chief Election Officer, Chief Returning Officer and Election Officers for the DUSU elections for 2026-27, marking the start of the formal electoral process. Prof Raj Kishore Sharma of the Department of Chemistry has been appointed Chief Election Officer, while University Librarian Prof Rajesh Singh will serve as Chief Returning Officer. College principals, heads of affiliated institutions have been named Election Officers.

'Breastfeeding is a baby's first vaccine': NDMC hosp official

ANAMTA FATIMA

> "The week, observed from Aug 1 to 7, saw hospital conduct counselling sessions, interactive programmes"

NEW DELHI: Breastfeeding provides newborns with essential nutrition and strengthens their immunity, said Dr. Sundeep Kaushik, Medical Superintendent, NDMC Palika Maternity Hospital, during an awareness programme organised to mark World Breastfeeding Week.

The week, observed from August 1 to 7, saw the hospital conduct counselling sessions and interactive programmes for expectant and new mothers, focusing on the importance of initiating breastfeeding within the first hour of birth and exclusively breastfeeding infants for the first six months.

"Breastfeeding is a baby's first vaccine and the most natural gift a mother can give her child," Dr. Kaushik said. He highlighted its role in providing complete nutrition, supporting brain development, strengthening immunity and fostering a bond between the mother and child.

Healthcare professionals at the hospital demonstrated appropriate breastfeeding techniques and addressed common myths and misconceptions surrounding breastfeeding. One-to-one counselling was also provided to mothers experiencing difficulties in breastfeeding.

The hospital also encouraged mothers to continue breastfeeding alongside appropriate complementary foods until the child is two years old or beyond, in line with established recommendations.

Dr. Kaushik said breastfeeding also aids mothers' recovery after childbirth and can help lower the risk of certain long-term health conditions. He stressed the need for breastfeeding-friendly homes, healthcare facilities and workplaces to ensure mothers receive adequate support.

The initiative witnessed participation from expectant and new mothers and was aimed at strengthening awareness and support for breastfeeding as part of maternal and child healthcare.

Two held after ₹2.8L job scam leads police to mule accounts

PRAJYOT DEOGHARE

> 'Dinesh was nabbed in Jodhpur on July 31, while Siyag was arrested based on his statement'

NEW DELHI: The Delhi Police Cyber Cell has arrested two men for allegedly providing mule bank accounts to cyber fraud gangs involved in defrauding job seekers, officials said. The accused, identified as Dinesh, 21, and Vikas Siyag, 20, both from Jodhpur, Rajasthan, were arrested during an investigation into a Telegram-based part-time job and investment scam in which a Delhi resident was allegedly cheated of Rs 2.84 lakh.

The victim approached the Cyber Police Station on July 9, alleging that he was initially lured through a Telegram channel to complete online reviews for food delivery aggregator Foodpanda. He was later persuaded by another channel administrator, using the name "Gaurika Ojas", to invest money in exchange for promised high returns.

The victim transferred Rs 2,84,100 through UPI and IMPS from his State Bank of India and Punjab National Bank accounts. An e-FIR was subsequently registered under relevant provisions of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita.

During the investigation, police traced Rs 1 lakh to a Central Bank of India account in Jodhpur. The money trail led to cash withdrawals and purchases at ATMs and a petrol pump. Dinesh was arrested in Jodhpur on July 31, while Siyag was arrested based on his statement. Four mobile phones and a SIM card were recovered. The account was also linked to five other cybercrime cases.

Further investigation is underway to identify other gang members and verify the accused's criminal records.

Youth stabbed after mistaken identity

NEW DELHI: An 18-year-old youth was allegedly stabbed outside a government school in northwest Delhi's Jahangir Puri on Thursday after a Class VIII student apparently mistook him for another boy following an earlier fight, police said. The incident took place outside Government Boys Senior Secondary School in D-Block. Police said the juvenile had allegedly fought with another minor two days earlier and returned to the school gate seeking revenge, but attacked Raahit, who was not involved in the earlier dispute.

Raahit was taken to BJRM Hospital with a stab injury below the abdomen, with the blade reportedly still lodged in the wound. He was later shifted to BSA Hospital and is in stable condition. The juvenile was apprehended. MPOST

DOOR-TO-DOOR TENANT VERIFICATION LAUNCHED

Ahead of I-Day, cops intensify checks at hotels, guest houses & parking lots

PRAJYOT DEOGHARE

> "Delhi Police is also conducting detailed inspections of second-hand car dealerships"

NEW DELHI: Ahead of the Independence Day celebrations, the Delhi Police has stepped up security checks across the national capital, conducting extensive verification of hotels, guest houses, tenant records, second-hand car dealerships and parking lots in the wake of the December 2025 blast near the Red Fort that left 13 people dead.

Senior police officials said personnel had been instructed to intensify surveillance amid heightened security concerns, particularly in areas such as Old Delhi, Jamia Nagar and Nizamuddin, following the terror attack near the Red Fort last year.

Intelligence agencies are also conducting door-to-door surveys in areas with large student and professional populations, including neighbourhoods around universities and colleges. The exercise is aimed at verifying whether tenants have submitted valid identity proofs and other mandatory documents.

The police have intensified verification at hotels, guest houses, lodges and other accommodation facilities across Delhi. Personnel have been instructed to check visitor registers, manual and computerised guest verification systems, and other records to ensure compliance with security procedures.

Hotel owners and operators have also been warned that maintaining incomplete visitor records or failing to verify guests' credentials could invite prosecution.

The Delhi Police is also conducting detailed inspections of second-hand car dealerships across the capital. Officials are examining purchase records and transactions that could involve forged documents or illegal dealings.

"Enhanced security measures also include checking abandoned vehicles and intensifying surveillance at parking lots. Bomb disposal squads and police personnel are conducting regular checks at crowded places, transport hubs and other densely populated areas," said Anil Shukla, Special Commissioner of Police (Special Cell).

He said the police remained on high alert ahead of the Independence Day celebrations following the December 2025 blast.

A thorough verification of documents, intensified intelligence gathering and increased police surveillance are being carried out to ensure the safety of Delhi residents during the celebrations. Police personnel will remain deployed round the clock until the national holiday concludes.

The cost of policing dissent

ANAMTA FATIMA

> Bora alleged that protesters returning with injuries were met with tear gas...

NEW DELHI: For some protesters, a police crackdown ends when the barricades come down. For others, its effects continue in hospital wards, injured bodies and courtrooms. At a Press Club of India panel on "Delhi Police and Citizenry" on Thursday, former police officer, Famous journalist, student activists and a pellet-gun victim offered sharply different but converging perspectives on one question: where should the State draw the line while controlling a crowd?

Former IPS officer and retired Special Director of the Intelligence Bureau Yashovardhan Azad argued that crowd control in a democracy should begin with negotiation rather than force.

"Crowd is not our enemy. We are not there to kill. We are supposed to manage the crowd and at best disperse," Azad said, stressing that police personnel must understand the "gradation of force".

Speaking about pellet guns, Azad said he and others had approached the Supreme Court seeking their ban, arguing that while an officer may control the trigger, there is no control over where pellets ultimately strike. He cited injuries reported during their use in Jammu and Kashmir and called the weapon "inhumane". For student leader Neha Bora, however, the debate over policing is not theoretical. Recalling her experiences during protests, including the recent mobilisation at Jantar Mantar, Bora alleged that protesters returning with injuries were met with tear gas and lathi charges.

She described a makeshift medical tent where doctors treated protesters with fractures, ligament injuries and wounds. Bora questioned the use of force inside Jantar Mantar when, according to her account, many people there were either on hunger strike or seeking medical assistance.

"Who are you dispersing inside Jantar Mantar?" she asked. Irshad Mansoor, a petitioner in the Supreme Court and a pellet-gun victim, brought the consequences of such force into sharper focus. He said he was protesting over education policy, corruption and paper leaks when he was injured. Mansoor said he spent several days in hospital, underwent multiple surgeries and suffered significant blood loss.

He said the petition seeks to prevent pellet guns, stun batons and excessive force from becoming normalised during protests.

The discussion at the Press Club ultimately moved beyond policing itself to a larger democratic question: can dissent be dispersed without the people expressing it being made to pay the price?

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HEAVY RAIN CAUSES TRAFFIC SNARLS, WATERLOGGING

Rain cools, chaos rules

Man feared dead after falling into drain; narrow escape for 3 children in S-W Delhi

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Heavy rain lashed several parts of Delhi on Thursday, inundating roads, triggering widespread traffic snarls and waterlogging, and bringing a sharp drop in temperatures across the national capital.

With heavy rainfall, Thursday became Delhi's wettest day of August so far this year, offering respite from the humidity.

According to the India Meteorological Department (IMD), Lodi Road recorded the highest rainfall between 8.30 am and 5.30 pm at 60.4 mm, followed by Safdarjung at 56.0 mm, Ridge at 54.4 mm, Ayanagar at 22.3 mm and Palam at 14.6 mm.

The cumulative rainfall recorded since 8.30 am stood at 43.8 mm at Lodi Road, 25.2 mm at Palam, 18.7 mm at Safdarjung, 17.2 mm at Ridge and 14.2 mm at Ayanagar, the IMD said.

The rainfall brought down the maximum temperature significantly across the city. Safdarjung recorded a maximum of 27.6 degrees Celsius, 6.6 notches below normal.

Lodi Road recorded 27.8 degrees Celsius, 5.2 notches below normal; Palam 27.3 degrees Celsius, 7.1 notches below normal; Ridge 27.6 degrees Celsius, 6.4 notches below normal and Ayanagar 27.2 degrees Celsius, 6.8 notches below normal. Minimum temperatures also remained below normal. Safdarjung recorded 25.6 degrees Celsius, 1.3 notches below normal; Lodi Road 25.4 degrees Celsius, 0.6 notch below normal; Ayanagar 25.2 degrees Celsius, 1.2 notches below normal; Palam 23.2 degrees Celsius, 3.6 notches below normal; and Ridge 22.5 degrees Celsius, 3.7 notches below normal. The weather office has forecast a generally cloudy sky with heavy rain on Friday and issued a yellow alert for the national capital.

Rain leaves commuters wading and traffic crawling, on Thursday PICS/PTI

Sangam Vihar was among the worst-hit areas, with roads submerged and traffic movement severely disrupted. Waterlogging was also reported from Sainik Farms, Shastri Park, Rohtak Road, Tughlaqabad, near the Red Fort and parts of ITO, where inundated roads brought vehicles to a crawl.

Heavy congestion was reported from several key arterial roads, including Aruna Asaf Ali Marg, Shaheed Jeet Singh Marg, Ber Sarai, the JNU Gate-Jia Sarai stretch, NH-48 between Dhaula Kuan and Rajokri flyover towards Gurugram, MB Road, Kalindi Kunj, Najafgarh, Rajdhani Park-Mundka, the ITO-Laxmi Nagar stretch, Akshardham, the CWG Village-Nizamuddin Bridge-Sarai Kale Khan corridor and the Delhi-Dehradun Expressway.

Mahesh Palawat, vice president (Meteorology and Climate Change) at Skymet Weather, said Delhi and adjoining areas are likely to receive moderate rain over the next two to three days under the influence of multiple weather systems.

The boundary wall of an old house collapsed following heavy rainfall in northwest Delhi's Vijay Nagar area on Thursday, damaging several parked vehicles, police said.

Delhi sees dengue and H1N1 spike

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Delhi has reported 1,349 confirmed H1N1 (swine flu) cases this year, with no deaths recorded due to the disease, Health Minister Pankaj Singh said on Thursday, asserting that government hospitals are "fully prepared" to handle patients.

The minister said the government was closely monitoring the H1N1 situation and had directed all government hospitals to ensure adequate treatment facilities and keep a close watch on affected and hotspot areas. Singh said the national capital has also reported 1,379 dengue cases so far, including around 200 patients from outside Delhi, and that hospitals were equipped to manage patients suffering from both diseases.

"Regular testing for H1N1 is being carried out, and around 1,349 people have tested positive so far this year, with the cases increasing this monsoon. All of them are undergoing treatment and many of them got treated and went home. I am happy to say that there has been no mishap due to either dengue or H1N1. The Delhi government, the Health Department and all our hospitals are fully prepared to deal with these diseases," he told reporters. He said anyone reporting symptoms of H1N1 or dengue was being provided timely treatment and urged people not to panic.

Soon: Spl Chhath buses to Bihar

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Delhi government plans to start special interstate buses to Bihar before the Chhath festival this year, transport minister Pankaj Singh said on Thursday.

The project is part of the next phase of the rollout of the inter-state buses, with Delhi and Bihar set to sign a Memorandum of Understanding (MoU) soon.

"We have a target to launch these buses before Chhath festival this year; these will be AC luxury buses and initially we plan to rollout around 50 plus buses to seven locations in Bihar. The buses will not (be) limited to just the festival but operate round the year," transport minister Pankaj Singh said.

As per the plan, the buses will connect Patna, Gaya, Muzaffarpur, Darbhanga, Purnia, and Bhagalpur in Bihar with Delhi.

Citing current choices — private buses or trains — as expensive, the minister said the ticket in the government-run buses would be "economical."

The government believes that this initiative will not only benefit passengers but also contribute to an increase in the Delhi Transport Corporation (DTC)'s revenue.

The MoU between Delhi and Bihar is likely to be signed in September, soon after which the services will commence and depending on the response, the number of buses could also be increased.

According to officials, Volvo buses would ply on these longer routes as electric buses would not be a feasible option for now.

"The long-route buses will be 12 metres long, air-conditioned, and equipped with luggage space. It is not feasible to ply electric buses to far-off locations because of the lack of charging infrastructure.

"We plan to take buses on a wet-lease model, wherein a concessionaire will come on board and operate the buses for us. These will be BS-VI compliant buses," the official added.

Earlier, the government had announced inter-state buses to Rishikesh, Haridwar and Dehradun in Uttarakhand; Panipat in Haryana; Ayodhya, Lucknow and Moradabad in Uttar Pradesh; and Amritsar, Chandigarh and Jammu.

Assembly fortified for Session

AIMAN FATIMA

NEW DELHI: Ahead of the Monsoon Session of the Delhi Assembly beginning on August 7, Speaker Vijender Gupta on Thursday chaired a high-level security review meeting and said all arrangements have been put in place to ensure the smooth and secure functioning of the House. The meeting was attended by senior officials of the Delhi Police, CRPF, Delhi Fire Services, Bomb Disposal Squad, Special Staff, SWAT, ambulance services and the Delhi Assembly Secretariat.

Earlier in the day, Delhi Police conducted a mock drill at the Assembly complex to assess emergency response capabilities and operational preparedness. During the meeting, Special Commissioner of Police (Law and Order) Devesh Shrivastava informed the Speaker that all necessary security measures had been completed for the session.

According to the Assembly Secretariat, around 130 Delhi Police and CRPF personnel will be deployed throughout the Monsoon Session to provide multi-layered security.

Security arrangements have also been enhanced with the installation of hydraulic road blockers at all entry gates, stricter access control and deployment of a CRPF Quick Response Team. Under the revised protocol, entry to the Assembly premises will be allowed only through Gate No. 1, while other gates will remain restricted.

Delhi Assembly Speaker Vijender Gupta chairs a meeting with Delhi Police officials, in New Delhi, on Thursday PTI

The meeting also decided to install view cutters around the Assembly complex to prevent unauthorised visual access. In addition, an Assistant Commissioner of Police (ACP)-rank officer will be permanently stationed at the Assembly, and a dedicated Delhi Police office will be set up inside the complex to improve coordination and enable quicker responses to security-related incidents.

The review covered surveillance systems, threat assessment, deployment plans, visitor management, frisking procedures, traffic regulation and emergency preparedness, including medical, fire and evacuation arrangements. "The House is fully prepared for the Monsoon Session," Speaker Vijender Gupta said, directing all agencies to maintain close coordination and ensure the proceedings are conducted safely and without disruption.

Govt mulls bus service to Noida Airport

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Delhi government is planning to launch public buses to the newly-opened Noida International Airport in Jewar, senior officials said on Thursday.

The Noida International Airport in the national capital region (NCR) began passenger flight operations almost a month ago.

"We plan to start the bus service right upto the Jewar airport, like private vehicles are allowed. A Reciprocal Transport Agreement will be signed soon between Delhi and Uttar Pradesh state transport authorities in this regard," an official said.

The government is planning is to operate several buses from the Anand Vihar and Kashmere Gate interstate bus terminals to Jewar airport, he added.

"A proposal is ready. After the two authorities finalise the details of the agreement, the services will start. This initiative is part of the broader effort by the state government to strengthen public transport infrastructure and expand interstate mobility," the official said.

Earlier this year, the Delhi Transport Corporation (DTC) had approved a plan to introduce 100 electric interstate buses on 17 routes.

The Delhi Transport Corporation has already commenced operations of electric buses on key routes including Delhi-Baraut (Uttar Pradesh), Delhi-Sonipat (Haryana), Delhi-Dharuhera (Haryana), and Delhi-Panipat (Haryana), improving connectivity between Delhi and neighbouring regions.

The Jewar airport, expected to strengthen connectivity and support economic activity in western Uttar Pradesh and NCR, was inaugurated on March 28 by Prime Minister Narendra Modi.

Yamuna nears warning mark

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Yamuna is expected to cross its warning level in Delhi over the next few days after the Hathnikund Barrage released the highest volume of water so far this monsoon, prompting authorities to closely monitor the River while maintaining that there is no immediate flood threat.

According to the Central Water Commission (CWC), the river's level at the Old Railway Bridge rose from 202.38 metres at 1 am to 203.50 metres by 8 pm on Wednesday, an increase of 1.12 metres in less than a day. The CWC has projected a further rise of around 1.5 metres, which could take the river above the warning level of 204.50 metres, though still below the danger mark of 205.33 metres.

Officials from the Irrigation and Flood Control Department attributed the increase to the release of 63,109 cusecs from the Hathnikund Barrage in Haryana, the highest discharge recorded this season.

A senior department official said the situation was being monitored round the clock and there was no cause for panic.

"The increased discharge from Hathnikund was anticipated, and the rise in the Yamuna is part of that expected cycle. We do not foresee flooding at this stage, and the river should stabilise once the current flow passes through Delhi. The higher flow will also help flush pollutants from the river," the official said.

Authorities explained that water from Hathnikund generally takes around two days to reach Delhi after being released upstream, although the travel time reduces once the river channel is already carrying substantial flow.

The rise has revived memories of the devastating 2023 floods, when the Yamuna reached a record 208.66 metres, inundating several low-lying areas and disrupting normal life across parts of the Capital. However, officials stressed that the current situation is nowhere near those levels.

CM opens STEM Innovation Lab at city school

AIMAN FATIMA

NEW DELHI: Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Thursday inaugurated a Science, Technology, Engineering and Mathematics (STEM) Innovation Lab at Sarvodaya Vidyalaya in Pitampura, saying the Delhi government is focusing on technology-enabled, innovation-driven education to prepare students for future careers and nation-building.

The STEM lab has been set up with support from the Shikhar Dhawan Foundation, HMD India and The One Group. Former India cricketer and Chairman of The One Group, Shikhar Dhawan, along with senior Education Department officials, teachers and students, attended the inauguration.

Addressing the gathering, Gupta said STEM education has become essential in a rapidly evolving world where science and technology are shaping the future economy.

"Science, technology, engineering and mathematics are not merely academic subjects but the foundation of the economy of the future and nation-building. Rather than limiting students to textbook learning, it is the need of the hour to equip them with hands-on, experiment-based education, creative thinking and problem-solving skills," she said. Calling the facility more than just a laboratory, the chief minister said the STEM Innovation Lab marked the beginning of a new phase of innovation and scientific learning in Delhi government schools.

"The STEM Innovation Lab is not just a laboratory but the beginning of a new era of innovation, scientific thinking and endless possibilities for Delhi's students. Our aim is to equip every government school with modern facilities, digital technology and innovation-driven learning resources so that every student is prepared to meet the challenges of the future," Gupta said. According to the chief minister, the lab will encourage students to develop innovative ideas, cultivate a scientific temperament and work on solutions to real-life challenges. She said quality, technology-enabled education would play a key role in achieving the vision of Viksit Bharat 2047.

Gupta also thanked the Shikhar Dhawan Foundation, HMD India and The One Group for supporting the initiative, saying collaborations between the government and private organisations can significantly strengthen public education.

TRIBUTE

CM Rekha Gupta pays tribute to the portrait of former external affairs minister and BJP leader Sushma Swaraj on the latter's death anniversary, during a tree plantation programme PTI

Over 4.25L women register for Laxmi

NEW DELHI: More than 4.25 lakh women have registered for the Delhi Laxmi Yojana, with nearly 1.5 lakh applications submitted on the online portal. An official said 4,25,631 registrations had been completed and 1,49,941 applications were submitted on the portal as of 4 pm on Thursday. On Tuesday, the portal had recorded more than 3 lakh registrations and 71,411 applications by 8 pm. CM Rekha Gupta on Thursday inspected a Delhi Laxmi Yojana camp in Shalimar Bagh, where she interacted with women beneficiaries and reviewed the registration process and arrangements at the camp. According to a statement, Gupta directed officials to ensure that applications of all eligible women are processed in a simple, transparent and time-bound manner so that beneficiaries do not face unnecessary difficulties. She said the objective was to ensure that the scheme's benefits reach every eligible woman with ease. MPOST

IFMS project fails to take off

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA

NEW DELHI: The Rs 261-crore IFMS project that aims to streamline financial management of the Delhi government has failed to find any takers despite being approved seven months back, leading to changes in its bidding conditions, officials said on Thursday.

The integrated financial management system (IFMS) project was approved by the expenditure finance committee (EFC) in December last year. It aims to serve as a unified platform enabling real-time financial information, improved resource utilisation and transparency in transactions.

The request for proposal document with tender was floated by the finance department in January this year but no bid was received even after extension of dates four times in following months, said an official document.

The issue was deliberated in a recent EFC meeting headed by Chief Minister Rekha Gupta.

Earlier, in stakeholder consultations and meetings with the Technical Advisory Committee (TAC), challenges including technical, operational and implementation-related issues that restricted bidders from participating in the bid process, were discussed by the officials.

Delhi fast-tracks key infra projects

AIMAN FATIMA

NEW DELHI: The Delhi government on Wednesday directed multiple agencies to remove bottlenecks delaying key infrastructure projects, with Public Works Department (PWD) Minister Parvesh Sahib Singh stressing that the focus is on "permanent engineering solutions" to chronic waterlogging, smoother traffic movement and faster execution of National Highway projects across the Capital.

Chairing the fifth meeting of the UT-Level Coordination Committee on NHAI and GNCTD issues, Singh reviewed the progress of several pending projects with officials from the PWD, National Highways Authority of India (NHAI), Delhi Police, MCD, Delhi Jal Board (DJB), DDA, DMRC, Revenue Department, BSES and other agencies.

"Effective coordination among all departments is essential for infrastructure development. Clear responsibilities and timelines have been assigned to every agency. Our priority is to eliminate inter-departmental bottlenecks and accelerate project execution so that Delhiites witness tangible improvements on the ground," Singh said.

The committee reviewed recurring waterlogging on NH-24, particularly at the Patparganj and Pandav Nagar underpasses, besides vulnerable locations including Nausena Bhawan, Thal Sena Bhawan, Mahipalpur T-Point and the R&R Hospital underpass. While the PWD has completed desilting of the drain along NH-24, NHAI has been directed to raise the road level to provide a permanent solution.

The meeting also assessed the progress of the Andheria Mor-NH-48 corridor, Rangpuri Bypass Tunnel utility shifting, Rohtak Road corridor, service roads and drainage infrastructure. BSES and other departments were instructed to complete pending technical formalities and approvals on priority.

"Our Government believes in delivering permanent engineering solutions rather than temporary arrangements. Whether it is NH-24, Mahipalpur or any other vulnerable location, our objective is to provide long-term relief through better planning, stronger coordination and time-bound execution," Singh said.

The committee further directed the Revenue Department to expedite land demarcation and mutation, while the DJB was asked to prioritise utility shifting and NOCs to avoid delays. It also reviewed congestion at Delhi's border toll plazas, encroachments and unauthorised parking on highways, and emergency response systems along the UER-II corridor, directing agencies to submit Action Taken Reports before the next review meeting. Concluding the meeting, Singh said, "Our objective is clear, faster execution, stronger coordination and outcome-oriented governance... citizens benefit from safer roads, improved drainage and seamless connectivity."

APP-BASED MONITORING FOR FIRST TIME

DDA launches real-time digital system to monitor 23 lakh sapling plantation drive

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Delhi Development Authority (DDA) has launched a first-of-its-kind digital monitoring system to track its ongoing plantation drive in real time, with geo-tagged data, photographs and a public dashboard aimed at ensuring the survival of saplings, officials said on Thursday.

The initiative, launched following directions from Delhi Lieutenant Governor Taranjit Singh Sandhu, will enable authorities to monitor plantation progress, identify delays and maintenance gaps, and record plant mortality for timely corrective action.

"For the first time, a plantation programme of this scale will be monitored through a dedicated mobile application integrated with a Plantation Monitoring Dashboard. Field officers, particularly Section Officers (Horticulture), will use the app to upload site-specific details, photographs and geo-tagged data," the DDA said in a statement. The information uploaded through the app will sync with a central dashboard, enabling real-time monitoring across divisions while flagging delays, maintenance gaps and plant mortality for prompt intervention.

"The initiative aims to ensure survival and sustained growth of saplings, rather than just meeting numerical targets," the statement said.

According to officials, plant mortality will be recorded in the system and replacement plantation will be carried out wherever required.

To enhance transparency, the DDA will also engage an independent third-party agency to verify and assess plantation survival. Its findings will help identify areas requiring additional maintenance or corrective measures.

Officials said more than 50 per cent of the target to plant 23 lakh indigenous saplings has already been achieved in less than a month.

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LALDUHOMA SAYS AFTER MEETING AMIT SHAH

FCRA Bill to be debated on Aug 12, no retrospective effect: Mizo CM

MPOST BUREAU

Highlights

» Lalduhoma and a delegation of church leaders from Mizoram conveyed their concerns to Shah over the Foreign Contribution (Regulation) Amendment Bill, 2026

» The Bill provides for a comprehensive framework for vesting, supervision, management and disposal of foreign contributions and assets in a 'designated authority'

NEW DELHI: The contentious FCRA amendment Bill will be taken up for discussion and passage in Parliament on August 12 but it will not come into effect retrospectively, Mizoram Chief Minister Lalduhoma said after meeting Union Home minister Amit Shah.

Lalduhoma and a delegation of church leaders from Mizoram conveyed their concerns to Shah over the Foreign Contribution (Regulation) Amendment Bill, 2026, which seeks to significantly tighten the oversight of foreign-funded organisations, proposing creation of a powerful new authority to seize and manage the assets of non-profits that lose their licence.

"We have conveyed our apprehensions on the new FCRA Bill to the home minister. He assured us that the Bill will not come into effect retrospectively," he told reporters at the Parliament House complex.

Asked whether the home minister indicated any date for discussion and passage of the FCRA amendment Bill in Parliament, Lalduhoma said Shah told him that the proposed legislation will be debated in the House on August 12.

The Bill was introduced in Lok Sabha on March 25.

The Bill provides for a comprehensive framework for vesting, supervision, management and disposal of foreign contributions and assets in a 'designated authority', including provisional and permanent vesting.

The foreign contribution and the assets created out of foreign contribution of any person--whose certificate has been cancelled under Section 14; or who has surrendered the certificate under section 14A; or whose certificate has ceased under section 14B or any rules made under this Act -- shall, from the date of such cancellation, surrender or cessation, vest provisionally in the Designated authority in such manner as may be prescribed, the proposed law said.

If an individual fails to obtain a fresh certificate or gets their certificate renewed or restored within the period referred in the law, the foreign contribution and the assets created out of foreign contributions shall thereupon stand permanently vested in the Designated authority, the Bill proposes.

In a memorandum submitted to Shah, Lalduhma, along with Mizoram Kohhran Hruaitu Committee (MKHC) chairman John Raldosanga and Council of Churches in Mizoram (CCM) general secretary Lalhmangaiha, said the Bill and its rules should operate prospectively as retrospective application of regulatory provisions may create uncertainty and expose bona fide organisations to penalties for past procedural variations.

The MKHC and CCM represent major church denominations in Mizoram.

"Prospective application, accompanied by saving clauses and transitional safeguards, would ensure that national regulatory objectives are achieved without disrupting schools, healthcare units, and social safety nets that have been built over decades of dedicated service," the memorandum said.

Lalduhoma and the church leaders said organisations which voluntarily choose to discontinue foreign funding or undergo restructuring should not be regarded as defaulting entities.

A delegation of the Joint Action Forum on Minorities, led by DMK MP P Wilson, also met the home minister and conveyed the concerns of various minority and church organisations on the Bill. WITH AGENCY INPUTS

India and Singapore review bilateral ties in key areas

OUR CORRESPONDENT

Foreign Secretary Vikram Misri, right, meets Singapore Ministry of Foreign Affairs Permanent Secretary Luke Goh, in New Delhi PTI

India-Singapore relations were elevated to a Comprehensive Strategic Partnership during the visit of PM Modi to Singapore in September 2024

NEW DELHI: India and Singapore on Thursday reviewed the progress of bilateral cooperation across the eight key areas outlined by the Roadmap for the Comprehensive Strategic Partnership (CSP) between the two countries.

The 19th round of India-Singapore Foreign Office Consultations (FOC) was held in New Delhi, the Ministry of External Affairs (MEA) said.

The Indian delegation was led by Rudrendra Tandon, Secretary (East), MEA and the Singapore delegation was led by Luke Goh, Permanent Secretary (Policy), Ministry of Foreign Affairs of Singapore.

"The two sides reviewed the progress of bilateral cooperation under the eight key areas outlined by the Roadmap for India-Singapore Comprehensive Strategic Partnership (CSP Roadmap) that will be taken up under India-Singapore Ministerial Roundtable (ISMR)," the MEA said in a statement.

The two sides also exchanged views on regional and global developments and reaffirmed the importance of close coordination at international and regional fora, including ASEAN, in addressing shared challenges.

India-Singapore relations were elevated to a Comprehensive Strategic Partnership during the visit of Prime Minister Narendra Modi to Singapore in September 2024.

The Roadmap for Comprehensive Strategic Partnership was launched during the visit of Lawrence Wong, Prime Minister of Singapore to India in September 2025, and covers cooperation in the areas of skills development, economic cooperation, digitalisation, sustainability, connectivity, healthcare and medicine, people-to-people and cultural exchanges, and defence and security cooperation," the MEA said.

During his visit to India, Permanent Secretary Luke Goh also called on External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar and met Foreign Secretary Vikram Misri, and Rajiv Mani, Secretary, Legislative Department, Ministry of Law and Justice.

From Page 1

Rijiju calls

Bill, which seeks to operationalise the 33 per cent reservation for women in the Lok Sabha and state assemblies before the 2029 general election through a delimitation exercise based on the 2011 Census. The proposed legislation also provides for increasing the strength of the Lok Sabha from the present 543 seats to 816.

The government is reaching out to the Congress, NDA allies and other Opposition parties, nearly four months after an earlier attempt to move the Bill failed because of inadequate numbers. Besides the Congress, the government is expected to consult Samajwadi Party chief Akhilesh Yadav and the DMK leadership to assess support for reintroducing the legislation. Rijiju has also sounded out NDA allies on the proposal, under which the enhanced strength of the Lok Sabha would enable implementation of the women's reservation law before the 2029 Lok Sabha elections. The government is aiming to reintroduce the Bill next week, with only four working days of the Monsoon session remaining before it concludes on August 13. Referring to his conversation with Gandhi, Rijiju said political opponents were not enemies and should work together in the national interest.

"The impression created outside is that they are determined not to let Parliament function at all. But who ultimately suffers from that?" he said.

Rejecting the Opposition's charge that the government was avoiding discussion, Rijiju said Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Union Home Minister Amit Shah were regularly attending Parliament and remained available for discussions.

He said legislative business was continuing despite the repeated disruptions, with several Bills being passed, particularly in the Rajya Sabha. The minister also claimed that the Congress stood to lose the most from the continuing stalemate as many of its first-time MPs were being deprived of opportunities to speak in Parliament. The remarks came as both Houses witnessed repeated adjournments amid Opposition protests over student-related issues and the alleged theft of donations at the Ram temple in Ayodhya. Rijiju also accused the Opposition of repeatedly raising examination paper leak issues despite the government having taken what he described as "revolutionary" steps to curb such incidents. Meanwhile, Congress president and Leader of Opposition in the Rajya Sabha Mallikarjun Kharge criticised Shah for not making a statement in Parliament on the alleged police action against students. Addressing a press conference, Kharge said Shah had failed to appear in the House despite Rajya Sabha Chairman C P Radhakrishnan asking Rijiju to convey the Opposition's demand to the Home Minister. During Question Hour, Radhakrishnan urged the Parliamentary Affairs Minister to "echo the sentiments" of the Opposition, which has been demanding Shah's presence in the House. "He requested the Home Minister to come to the House. As Parliamentary Affairs Minister, you can echo the sentiments of the Opposition to the Home Minister," the Chairman said. Kharge alleged that for the past 15 days the Opposition had been demanding that Shah explain who ordered the alleged lathi-charge, pellet firing and use of tear gas against students. He claimed that either Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Shah were "ignoring" Parliament or were unwilling to face the House.

The Congress chief also demanded that Modi and Shah apologise to the students. Rejecting the government's allegation that the Opposition was disrupting Parliament, Kharge said the Treasury benches created a ruckus whenever he rose to speak in the Rajya Sabha. "If the House is being disrupted, the reason for that is the government itself," he alleged, adding that normal functioning could resume once Shah addressed the House.

Modi tells

He also cautioned them against vested interests masquerading as well-wishers.

The Prime Minister reportedly warned that some people in Delhi would appear friendly and offer help only to latch on to MPs, likening such individuals to a spider's web. Modi also advised MPs to make greater use of Parliament's library, noting that only a handful of lawmakers regularly use the facility, according to sources. He cautioned against the misuse of technology and asked MPs to use it instead to improve communication with constituents, particularly the youth.

The Prime Minister also urged the lawmakers to remain aware of their surroundings, walk as much as possible and treat Parliament sessions with seriousness. Modi has been holding breakfast meetings with MPs in small batches during the ongoing Monsoon Session. A similar interaction on Wednesday was attended by BJP leader Nitin Nabin and a mix of senior and first-time Rajya Sabha members. Among those present on Thursday were Tarun Chugh, Vinod Tawde, Rajneesh Agrawal, A Sharda Devi, Swati Maliwal, Raghav Chadha, Ashok Mittal, Sandeep Pathak, Vikramjit Singh Sahney, Sushmita Dev and Debasish Samantray.

Govt slashes

The amendments require social media platforms to clearly label permissible AI-generated content and ensure it carries traceable metadata so users can identify synthetically generated material. Platforms must also inform users about the legal consequences of creating or sharing unlawful AI-generated content.

The rules cover deepfakes, AI-enabled impersonation, child sexual abuse material, non-consensual intimate images and other unlawful synthetic content. Intermediaries are required to deploy reasonable technical measures, including automated tools where appropriate, to prevent the creation and spread of such material. Significant social media intermediaries, defined as platforms with more than 50 lakh users in India, must proactively identify content depicting rape, child sexual abuse or similar illegal material. They are also required to make reasonable efforts to detect content that is identical or substantially similar to material that has already been removed.

The government said intermediaries that fail to comply with their legal obligations under the IT Rules will lose the safe harbour protection available under Section 79 of the Information Technology Act. Without this protection, platforms can face liability and prosecution under applicable laws for third-party content hosted on their services.

LS passes Bill

The Bill proposes replacing the reference to electronic payment modes listed under Section 269SU with "one or more electronic modes of payment as the central government may, by notification, specify", with the amendment taking effect from the date of its publication in the Official Gazette. Section 269SU requires businesses with an annual turnover of more than Rs 50 crore to provide specified electronic payment options, including RuPay debit cards and BHIM-UPI QR codes.

The proposed amendment is part of broader taxation legislation introduced in the Lok Sabha on Tuesday. The government's approach is aimed at creating a sustainable revenue model for banks, payment service providers and payment infrastructure firms, while allowing for small charges on digital payment services used by consumers and businesses.

Unlike UPI transactions, which have so far remained free, real-time payment systems such as RTGS and NEFT already attract service charges. A day before the Bill was passed, RBI Governor Sanjay Malhotra described discussions on Merchant Discount Rate (MDR) for digital payments as "premature". He said investment in payment infrastructure has to be funded either through taxes or by following the "user pays" model through MDR.

"The choices before us are simple: either the general public has to pay for it through taxes, or we have to levy the merchant discount rate (MDR)," Malhotra said, adding, "Costs have to be paid by someone." He said the priority remains strengthening the country's payment infrastructure and added, "What is important is that we continue to invest and continue to find the means, whether it is MDR or others. Let us wait and see how the situation evolves."

The issue of MDR has remained contentious, with banks and payment industry stakeholders seeking its introduction even as digital payments, particularly UPI, continue to witness rapid growth. Market observers have suggested that any future MDR, if introduced, may apply only to higher-value merchant transactions rather than peer-to-peer payments.

Atiq Ahmed

The three injured have been identified as Ahjam of Badshahi Mandi, Mohammad Zaid of Kotwali and Umar Ahmed of Pura Mufti, all residents of Prayagraj. They were rushed to the Jhansi Medical College for treatment.

Senior Superintendent of Police B B G T S Murthy said the preliminary investigation identified one of the deceased as Aban Ahmed, son of Atiq Ahmed. He said further legal proceedings were underway.

Police said they recovered a wedding invitation card from the damaged vehicle. The card carried the name of Mohammad Zaid, which helped officers contact family members and establish the identities of the occupants. Three mobile phones were also recovered from the car and taken into police custody. Eyewitnesses told police that the injured passengers repeatedly asked, "Bhai kaise hain?" apparently referring to one of their companions, but were not in a condition to provide any further details. Ali Ahmed, another son of Atiq Ahmed, was shifted from Naini Central Jail in Prayagraj to the high-security Jhansi jail on October 1, 2025. The transfer followed the recovery of Rs 1,100 from his barrack during a jail search. At the time of his transfer, Ali had claimed that his life was under threat and sought protection from the Uttar Pradesh government.

The latest accident comes more than three years after the death of Atiq Ahmed's son Asad Ahmed, who was killed in an encounter with the Uttar Pradesh Special Task Force near Jhansi on April 13, 2023. Asad, wanted in the Umesh Pal murder case, carried a reward of Rs 5 lakh. He and his associate Ghulam were killed after allegedly opening fire on the STF during the operation.

Atiq Ahmed and his brother Ashraf were shot dead by three assailants while in police custody in Prayagraj on April 15, 2023, in one of the state's most high-profile criminal cases.

Meta grilled

Officials said Meta informed the government that it has mechanisms and parameters in place to address concerns around the fairness of its algorithms. The company also assured the Centre that it is taking continuous steps to deal with deepfakes, child sexual abuse material (CSAM), bot accounts and AI-generated synthetic content. Sources said Meta acknowledged there were "serious issues" and assured the government that it would continue improving its systems.

The Centre, however, indicated that the discussions are far from over. Government sources said the meetings will continue for another three to four days, with Meta's technical executives expected to engage with the government's technical team under the leadership of IT Secretary S Krishnan. "We will push them hard, and technical discussions will continue," a source said.

The latest round of scrutiny stems from the temporary restriction of Prime Minister Modi's July 23 Facebook post on examination paper leaks, which remained unavailable for around five hours before being restored. Meta later attributed the removal to an error by its AI-powered automated content filters and apologised.

Officials also reiterated concerns over deepfakes and AI-generated content, describing them as an increasing challenge to public trust. While authorities will continue monitoring platforms such as Meta, they said the government is not considering a separate social media regulator at present and will address compliance issues within the existing constitutional and legal framework.

Bhagwat

our existing generation, and the honest appeal of patriotism and service works with them," he added. Bhagwat said concerns over India's education system were genuine and backed raising expenditure on education to 6 per cent of the GDP. "Protest is also a way of dialogue. In a democracy, protest is a way of building consensus. Different views come together and consensus evolves after discussion," he said.

"If, for various reasons, concerns are not heard through dialogue, people may turn to agitation. But the purpose of all this is to build consensus, not to create divisions. The grievances of Gen Z are genuine and I believe in their honesty," he added.

Referring to the police action during the July 20 protest at Delhi's Jantar Mantar, Bhagwat questioned the use of force.

"Why did the lathi charge happen? Why were pellet guns used? We need to study the reasons," he said.

He also backed comprehensive reforms in the education sector, saying isolated changes would not be sufficient.

"Education is not a business, and we need to provide education to all. We need to work on fee structures," he said.

Bhagwat stressed greater public participation in education and called for improving teacher training. "Public participation is important in education, from school development to quality education. Focus on teachers' training. We are imparting education to educate people, not for business," he said. On caste-based reservation, Bhagwat said quotas were introduced to achieve social equality and should continue as long as social discrimination exists.

However, he said those who had benefited from reservation should voluntarily consider giving up the benefit, adding that such views were emerging from within sections of quota beneficiaries.

Responding to a question on reservation in education and employment, the RSS chief said the issue should be viewed through the perspective of Dr B R Ambedkar and maintained that reservation would remain necessary until social inequality ends.

On India-Pakistan and India-China relations, Bhagwat said people-to-people dialogue should resume after conflicts are resolved. "In times of conflict, we have to go with whatever the government or military does. But that should not sever the ties which are already there," he said.

India's approach, he said, was not to "conquer or obliterate others" but to pursue a harmonious process through dialogue.

"During conflicts, dialogue can be halted, but conflict should not sever dialogue. After a conflict is resolved, we have to take it forward from where we left it. Permanent animosity or hatred is not the solution," Bhagwat said.

"When there is trouble, we have to deal with it in the proper way, and during conflict we are with our government and military. But it is a temporary situation arising out of politics. It is not that Pakistanis are wholehearted enemies of Indians or vice versa. The state, politics and international borders are facts of life," he added. On the LGBTQIA+ community and same-sex marriage, Bhagwat said members of the community were part of Indian society and had historically found social accommodation. "LGBTQIA+ people are part of our society. There were systems to accommodate them. Marriage is not merely a convenience for two people to live together. The family is a unit of society where the next generation is trained to become good citizens. If we disturb the existing system without creating a new one, it could lead to conflict," he said.

Bhagwat said laws should reflect social acceptance rather than dictate it.

"We have to prepare society first. Laws don't dictate society; society dictates the laws. At this stage, if we tamper with the marriage system, it may create side effects. We need to prepare a system that accommodates all such people. Our approach has to change and special measures have to be taken," he said. He added that an appropriate social and legal framework would have to be evolved for same-sex couples.

On social media, Bhagwat said banning platforms was not the answer and called for greater self-discipline and verification of information. "Today, technology can create fake videos using our faces and voices. Knowing this, people should never believe anything on social media without verifying it from authentic sources," he said. He also said social media influencers had a responsibility towards their followers. "If I am a social media icon and 10 lakh people follow me, it becomes my responsibility to ensure they do not end up in a problem by following me. That much wisdom is necessary," he said. Responding to a question on whether India should ban social media for children, as some countries have done, Bhagwat said restrictions alone were not the solution. Society, he said, must develop the discipline to use technology responsibly.

Centre denies

suggesting India had agreed to import ethanol from the US for fuel blending under the proposed India-US trade pact. It said no such commitments or concessions have been made, adding that ethanol used under the Ethanol Blended with Petrol Programme continues to be sourced entirely from domestic producers.

Modi, Netanyahu

Before the war, which began with US and Israeli strikes on Iran in February, nearly one-fifth of global oil and natural gas supplies passed through the waterway. India has maintained that dialogue and diplomacy remain the best path to resolving regional tensions while safeguarding its economic interests and the large Indian diaspora in the region.

Tehelka founder Tejpal convicted...

Continued from Page 1

The complainant later detailed the incident in an email to the magazine's then managing editor, Shoma Chaudhury, which became a key piece of evidence during the investigation.

After the allegations surfaced, Tejpal stepped down as editor-in-chief for six months, describing the episode in an email as an "untoward incident" and "a bad lapse of judgment". Acting on media reports and the complaint, Goa Police registered an FIR on November 22, 2013. Tejpal surrendered before the Goa Crime Branch after the Supreme Court refused him anticipatory bail and was arrested on November 30 that year.

Police later filed a chargesheet of more than 2,800 pages based on witness statements, CCTV footage, electronic records and forensic evidence. Trial proceedings began in 2017, during which the prosecution examined 71 witnesses while the defence examined four. In May 2021, the Mapusa sessions court acquitted Tejpal, holding that the prosecution had failed to establish the charges beyond reasonable doubt. The Goa government challenged the verdict before the Bombay High Court, arguing that the trial court had misread evidence and relied on stereotypes regarding the conduct of sexual assault survivors.

Allowing the state's appeal, the high court said the prosecution had proved its case beyond reasonable doubt and found the complainant's testimony reliable and consistent. In its 81-page judgment, the bench said the trial court wrongly expected the complainant to behave like a "perfect victim".

"The 'perfect victim' concept, more formally known as an 'ideal victim', described an unspoken cultural archetype where a person is fully believed, sympathised with and granted legitimacy only if they exhibit absolute vulnerability, complete innocence and total passivity," the court observed, adding that trauma cannot be judged through a fixed standard of behaviour.

The bench said every person processes trauma differently and that neither the court nor the accused could decide how a survivor should react after a sexual assault. It also held that Tejpal was in a position of control and dominance over the complainant because he was the editor-in-chief and owner of Tehelka while she was a principal correspondent with the magazine.

The judges also criticised the manner in which the defence questioned the complainant during the trial, saying the focus on her personal life and character was unwarranted. The judgment noted that even a woman alleged to be of "easy virtue" was entitled to equal protection under the law and that every woman had the right to refuse sexual intercourse.

The court also relied on an apology email sent by Tejpal after the incident, saying it showed that he acknowledged the sexual assault, though he described it as a "sexual liaison". It further remarked that a criminal court has the responsibility not only to ensure that innocent persons are not punished but also that guilty persons do not escape.

During the sentencing hearing, Solicitor General Tushar Mehta, appearing for the Goa government, sought life imprisonment, arguing that Tejpal had abused his position of authority and shown no remorse. Tejpal, however, appealed for leniency, telling the court, "I am 62 years old today. I am a father of two daughters. I have a wife. I am a political victim." His lawyers sought the minimum punishment, pointing out that he had complied with all bail conditions.

After the verdict, Tejpal announced that he would challenge the conviction before the Supreme Court. "We will be appealing against this order. We feel the order is wrong. We will be moving the Supreme Court against the order," he told reporters. He also alleged that he had been targeted because of his journalism, while maintaining that the truth would eventually prevail.

ITC: Partnering India in its Defining Decade

Excerpts from the Address by
Shri Sanjiv Puri, Chairman & Managing Director, ITC Limited

115th Annual General Meeting, ITC Limited | 23 July 2026

Enduring Value

We meet today at a time of deep significance — for the world, for India, and for enterprises that aspire to create enduring value. The prolonged uncertainty arising from the West Asia crisis has severely impacted the global economy, threatening energy security and trade. Indeed, the multitude of events in the recent past only reinforce the fact that **global volatility is no more sporadic; it is now systemic.** Last year, in my address, I had described this as an era of **TURN** — a world constantly confronted by **Turbulence, Uncertainty** and **Rapid change**, calling for **Novel strategies** to reimagine our tomorrows. Today, that reality stands even more pronounced, as a deeper structural shift reshapes the future of nations, societies and enterprises.

What makes this juncture a perfect storm of exceptional complexity and consequence is the confluence of multiple forces at scale. On the one hand, global progress is challenged by the catastrophic climate emergency, widening inequality and advances in disruptive technologies like AI. On the other hand, decades of hyper-globalisation have given way to fragmented multi-polarisation — creating a world that is still deeply connected, but less trusting; still trading yet marred by weaponisation of supply chains; still global, but increasingly nationalistic. These tectonic shifts are being felt across everyday lives — through volatile commodity prices, inflationary pressures, disruptions in trade and the rising vulnerability of food, energy and supply chains.

> **"India's resolute fortitude in accelerating the journey to a competitive, resilient and inclusive nation has earned it widespread trust, respect and admiration."**

It is said that crisis challenges the status quo like no other and spurs innovation to forge new pathways for growth, competitiveness and resilience. We stand today at such an inflection point with an unparalleled opportunity to make a meaningful difference to all our shared tomorrows.

It gives us immense pride, therefore, that India's resolute fortitude in accelerating the journey to a competitive, resilient and inclusive nation has earned it widespread trust, respect and admiration.

India's Ascent: A Beacon of Hope and Progress

Against this backdrop, the Hon'ble Prime Minister's powerful clarion call for an **Aatmanirbhar** and a **Viksit Bharat** assumes even greater significance. It has inspired multidimensional interventions enabling India to emerge as the fastest-growing major economy in the world. The far-reaching measures announced in successive Budgets have provided strong foundations to unleash growth. India's ascent is not merely about outpacing other large economies. **It has demonstrated that a nation of continental scale, democratic depth and extraordinary diversity can drive momentum with stability, pursue reform with inclusion, and convert aspiration into resilient growth.**

The India story is indeed an inspiring example of how the Government is creating an all-pervasive Bharat Capability Stack through exemplary foresight and foundational action to reinforce competitiveness for today, resilience for tomorrow and strategic readiness for the decades ahead.

Role of Business: Responsible Competitiveness

It is my deep conviction that businesses, as a crucial organ of society, serve a larger transformational purpose by contributing meaningfully to **national competitiveness, sustainable and inclusive development.**

This philosophy is reflected in your Company's ethos of **Responsible Competitiveness**, which has guided our thought, strategy and action over the years and inspires our commitment to be **a national value multiplier.** To my mind, businesses make a lasting contribution to the nation when they frame their growth agenda around three imperatives.

First, as engines of national competitiveness, it is mission critical for Indian enterprises to be **future-ready and globally competitive.** This calls for trusted Indian brands that anchor domestic ecosystems and retain value in the country; investments in state-of-the-art national assets that support India's ambition to become a global hub for manufacturing, services and exports; a deeper focus on cutting-edge innovation and R&D as well as capabilities for AI-led transformation. **The Hon'ble Prime Minister's vision of Build More, Produce More and Export More raises our collective aspirations to even bolder heights to craft products and services of world-class quality and trust, that earn their rightful place in households and markets across the world.**

> **"When enterprises embed resilience and embrace anti-fragility, they fortify the nation's foundation and position it to rise stronger with every adversity."**

Taking this tenet further, the **second imperative** is for businesses to evolve as architects of **national resilience and anti-fragility.** While resilience sharpens the capacity to bounce back amidst adversity, anti-fragility goes beyond, to convert adversity into future opportunities. Strengthening resilience calls for locally anchored value chains, stronger MSME partnerships, diversified and trusted sourcing, import substitution, climate stewardship and robust digital adoption. However, the winners of tomorrow must also thrive amidst adversity, nurture new competencies, accelerate innovation and spur new engines of growth. Resilience is no longer the dividend of efficiency nor is anti-fragility a distant objective, they are the very foundation of our right to grow. **When enterprises embed resilience and embrace anti-fragility, they fortify the nation's foundation and position it to rise stronger with every adversity.**

Third, businesses must advance a paradigm of Compassionate Capitalism. Competitiveness gives enterprises the power to win, anti-fragility the right to win the future and purpose the legitimacy to win. Businesses exist to serve both an economic and social purpose. The enormous climate risks, livelihood challenges, inequality and regulations **make it a crucial responsibility of businesses to embed sustainability and inclusion as an integral component of strategy.** This belief lies at the core of your Company's approach.

A few years ago, your Company laid the foundations of the **ITC Next strategy** to drive scale, accelerated growth and profitability and make the enterprise even more future-ready. Guided by the Company's credo of **"Nation First, *Sab Saath Badhein*", our north-star is to create growing value for all our stakeholders — by building national competitiveness that is globally benchmarked, resilience that is locally anchored, and growth that is anti-fragile, inclusive and sustainable.**

ITC: Ushering in NextGen Agri, Strengthening Rural India

I begin with agriculture — the lifeline of our economy and the foundation of rural India. India possesses vast arable land, diverse agro-climatic zones and leadership in several commodities. Yet, low productivity, fragmented holdings, limited value addition, climate vulnerability and inefficient market access continue to constrain its potential. This points to a defining opportunity to **transform Indian agriculture from volume-led production to value-led competitiveness,** not only to fortify food security but to raise farmer incomes, deepen rural capability and enhance exports.

The Government has spearheaded several commendable measures to support growth of the agri-food sector. Higher farmer incomes can trigger a virtuous cycle of consumption, investment, employment and rural prosperity. This requires a structural shift to shape **NextGeneration Agriculture** — from fragmented productivity to integrated competitiveness, from undifferentiated commodities to high-value agriculture, and from vulnerable farming systems to climate-smart, technology-enabled rural ecosystems.

With over a century of engagement with agriculture, 94% of your Company's businesses are linked to agri-crops or plantations, generating substantial livelihoods. ITC nurtures **21 value chains across 23 States to source nearly 6 million tonnes of agri-produce.** In this address, I will focus on ITC's Agri Business, which is now the country's largest private sector agri-enterprise, **doubling segment revenue in just over 5 years to nearly ₹20,300 crore** in FY26. The **ITC Next strategy** is today transforming the Agri Business, while ushering in NextGeneration farming and rural empowerment.

At the core of this transformation is the **ITCMAARS** phygital ecosystem, designed to empower FPOs with digital technologies, hyper-personalised advisories, quality inputs, market linkages, scientific agronomy and climate-smart practices to improve farm competitiveness and resilience. In a short span, ITCMAARS has onboarded **over 2.6 million farmers** across 11 States, with the ambition to benefit 10 million farmers by 2030. Initial estimates indicate **crop yield gains of 15-20% and improvement in net returns by 25-30%.**

Building on a recent horticulture pilot, anchored by FPOs, for the supply of high-quality fruits and vegetables, ITC plans to develop 4 additional hybrid Open-to-Sky and Controlled Environment Agriculture clusters to create a reliable, traceable supply chain for fresh produce. Progressively, **ITCMAARS is introducing precision-led agriculture and advanced agri-tech solutions, like IoT-enabled weather tracking, remote-sensing, drone-based services, to promote smart farming.**

A vital component of your Company's agri strategy is to promote **Value-Added Agriculture** to enable farmers scale the next horizon of profitable growth. This portfolio, which has grown at a CAGR of 33% over five years, today encompasses **certified organic crops, processed agri-products, such as food-safe spices, horticulture, premium coffee, aquaculture and attribute-specific commodities, like high-starch maize and high-gluten wheat.**

Taking this further, ITCMAARS will drive a Farming as a Service (FaaS) ecosystem to 'Grow the Buy', where crop value chains are customised to meet specific buyer needs. Certifications, traceability and responsible sourcing establish **trust systems at scale,** linking Indian farmers to domestic and global export markets. ITC's Spices Business, for example, is today the country's leading exporter of organic spices, supported by certified cultivation, backward integration and **one of Asia's largest spices processing facilities at Guntur.**

> **"There is a defining opportunity to transform Indian agriculture from volume-led production to value-led competitiveness.... ITCMAARS has onboarded over 2.6 million farmers across 11 States, with the ambition to benefit 10 million farmers by 2030."**

In an era of climate stress and rising food security imperatives, production of **high-quality, resilient seeds and hybrids** is vital to enhancing productivity, improving quality, increasing climate resilience, strengthening nutritional security and raising farmer incomes. Your Company's wholly owned subsidiary **Technico, a global leader in pre-basic potato seeds, is investing in the world's largest state-of-the-art aeroponic facility** with 60 hi-tech controlled-environment greenhouses, taking the combined capacity to 100 million TECHNITUBER®s.

Fostering an effective **science-to-farm ecosystem,** ITC's LSTC is leveraging advanced breeding technologies, molecular genetics and digital tools to develop higher-yielding, climate-resilient, hybrid and disease-resistant varieties across crops such as tobacco, wheat, potato, eucalyptus and subabul. **These have led to yields improving by 15-50%.**

Your Company is making appreciable progress in high-value, future-facing categories, such as **Biological Extracts,** with the commencement of a US FDA-compliant, export-oriented, pharmacopoeia-standard **nicotine derivative** processing facility, serving customers in Europe, USA and South Korea. In addition, ITC's **medicinal and aromatic plant ecosystem** is developing high-active varieties and proprietary formulations, besides manufacturing high-purity extracts for domestic and global markets together with farmer training in best practices.

As we look ahead, ITC will continue to work towards shaping a more competitive, resilient and inclusive Agri Business, which is not only **creating new growth drivers but also contributing to enriching rural India, raising farmer incomes, fortifying food and livelihood security, and establishing globally trusted value chains.**

ITC: Proudly Indian Brands — Creating and Retaining Value in India

In a growing consumption-led economy, strong domestic brands assume strategic importance because they channel consumer aspiration into national value. Brands are vital **repositories of trust, quality, innovation and intellectual property.** When successful Indian brands win consumer preference at scale, they **retain larger value within the country.**

That is why **'Vocal for Local'** is not merely a sentiment; **it is a strategy to reinforce domestic capability, create and nurture brands that are born in India but made for the world** with impeccable quality and trust that can delight consumers globally.

Your Company's aspiration to be India's No. 1 FMCG player is anchored on this larger vision. Today, ITC's portfolio of over 30 world-class FMCG brands represents annual consumer spends of **nearly ₹37,000 crore** and reaches around **280 million households** while being exported to over **70 countries.** It is indeed difficult to find parallels globally of an enterprise that has launched so many large, successful and trusted home-grown brands in a relatively short period.

ITC's brands enrich everyday moments in Indian homes — from **Sunfeast** biscuits in the morning, to breakfast choices of **Aashirvaad Besan** *chillas* and **Yoga Bar** cereals, to **Fiama** bathing experiences, **Mangaldeep** devotional moments and **Classmate's** joy of learning, from baby and pet-safe clean homes with **Nimyle** to meals with **24 Mantra Organic, Aashirvaad** staples and **Sunrise** spices, to fun times with **Bingo!, ITC Master Chef** and **Prasuma** snacks, mini meals with **YiPPee!** and ending the day with **Fabelle** for luxurious indulgence and **Pranah** for relaxation.

> **"ITC's portfolio of over 30 world-class FMCG brands represents annual consumer spends of nearly ₹37,000 crore and reaches around 280 million households while being exported to over 70 countries."**

The Indian FMCG market is poised for significant expansion, with your Company's addressable market estimated at around ₹8 trillion by 2035, pointing to the immense headroom to grow. The consumer landscape in India is also evolving rapidly. The rise of Aspirational Bharat, premiumisation, Gen Z and Gen Alpha consumers, expanding digital access and the growth of quick commerce are reshaping categories, channels and expectations. Today's **'maximiser consumer'** simultaneously seeks taste and nutrition, convenience and trust, indulgence and wellness, value as well as premium experiences.

In line with the **ITC Next strategy,** your Company is making rapid progress in not only scaling its core power brands but developing a future-ready portfolio that is constantly alive to evolving consumer needs. A critical foundation is ITC's **AI-led consumer insight ecosystem,** that drives **targeted micro-segmentation** to help craft a pipeline of differentiated offerings — be it by life stages, lifestyle, channel, occasion, shelf-life requirement and health need, among others. This vibrant portfolio has been enriched with new acquisitions in areas of promise that are already clocking an ARR of around ₹1,350 crore, effectively synergising the entrepreneurial energy of start-ups with ITC's scale and institutional strengths. These differentiated products reach millions of homes through your Company's smart omni-channel network with unique multidimensional capabilities across ambient, chilled, frozen and perishable supply chains.

India today faces the twin challenges of adequate nutrition and rising lifestyle-related health concerns. Aligned to ITC's **'Help India Eat Better'** Mission, a **Good-for-You** portfolio is being built to address **deficiencies in protein, fibre, micronutrients and gut health.** These include the **Yoga Bar protein range** for Gen Z, **Sunfeast Breakfast protein-rich shakes** for early jobbers and **Aashirvaad Protein Atta** for the entire family. The **Right Shift** range for the **40-plus cohort** is fortified with fibre, protein and micronutrients. **24 Mantra Organic** provides trusted organic products, while **Aashirvaad Millet Flour, Multigrain Flour, Sunfeast Farmlite biscuits,** and **Yoga Bar** high-fibre breakfast cereals serve the growing need for better fibre intake and gut health.

> **"In the true spirit of Make in India, nearly 90% of ITC's value addition takes place within the country.... ITC's Bharat Built Manufacturing endeavour is to build globally competitive domestic manufacturing assets, substitute imports, enrich the environment and support sustainable livelihoods."**

Leveraging emerging spaces such as wellness and naturals, your Company's Personal Care portfolio reflects the convergence of nature, and science. **Nimyle** brings the goodness of Neem into homecare, while **Savlon** continues to expand its trusted hygiene equity across personal wash, germ protection, surface disinfection and medicated skincare. The acquisition of **Mother Sparsh** marks ITC's strategic presence in premium natural baby care, rooted in traditional Indian knowledge for new-age mothers seeking specialised solutions. Building on **Fiama's industry-first gel bar technology, the new Japanese Hokkaido Milk range,** which is being patented, reflects sensorial innovation that promises non-sticky moisturised skin.

Innovation is at the heart of your Company's future-ready portfolio, which is powered by **ITC's Life Sciences and Technology Centre,** with over 400 world-class scientists. **What sets the Centre apart is not just its deep research capabilities and future-ready platforms, but its focus on end-to-end value chains, from seed to fork and tree to paper, enabling your Company to craft winning products of impeccable quality.**

We recognise that **business innovation is as crucial as product innovation.** Consumers increasingly seek fresh cooked food solutions where freshness, speed, quality and trust converge. Responding to this, your Company launched the **Fresh Food Business,** leveraging ITC's institutional strengths in trusted brands, food sciences, cuisine expertise and digital capabilities. With over 70 cloud kitchens across five cities, the business has grown over 100% in the last three years through a delectable portfolio comprising **Aashirvaad Soul Creations, ITC Master Chef Creations, Sunfeast Baked Creations and Sansho from ITC Master Chef,** which have consistently received top consumer rankings.

Your Company's growing standing in FMCG, powered by the trust of millions of consumers, gives us the confidence to dream boldly — of a future where an ITC product adorns every household in India and makes its mark across continents. ITC's world-class Indian brands will continue to be a significant enduring strength, creating larger value for the enterprise and its stakeholders.

ITC: Powering Make in India for a Viksit Bharat

Your Company's **Bharat Built Manufacturing architecture** has created world-class national assets across **FMCG, Paperboards & Packaging and export-oriented value-added Agri Processing.** Today, ITC's manufacturing ecosystem spans **over 300 factories,** including 45 owned plants, engaging with more than **9,500 MSMEs.** These large investments in modern facilities provide strong levers of competitiveness, resilience and local value-chain development.

In the true spirit of Make in India, nearly 90% of ITC's value addition takes place within the country. The agri and food processing industry has high employment-to-capital intensity. Therefore, your Company's 170 factories in this sector **are a powerful economic multiplier, deepening inclusive farm-to-consumer value chains and linking farmers to domestic and global markets.**

Your Company's confidence in the India story is reflected in its proposed medium-term capex of ₹20,000 crore for the Group in areas that have a multiplier impact. Close on the heels of 8 recently commissioned facilities, 6 new projects are in the pipeline. Your Company's leadership as **India's largest integrated paperboards and paper business** will be reinforced by the forthcoming acquisition of Century Pulp & Paper, raising capacity by over 50% to 1.5 million metric tonnes. The newly established **state-of-the-art Moulded Fibre Products** facility is pioneering complex engineered compostable solutions for single-use plastic substitution for both domestic and global markets. As each of your Company's businesses scales up in line with the ITC Next strategy, its manufacturing ecosystem is poised to expand further, contributing to India's aspiration to be a global manufacturing powerhouse.

> **"What differentiates ITC's sustainability journey is a triad of achievements. First, Longevity, that is reflected in decades of sustained environmental impact. Second, Scale, which is demonstrated through the massive creation of ecological capital and support to millions of livelihoods. Third, Integration, through a distinctive model where sustainability and inclusivity are core pillars of strategy, governance and programmes."**

Your Company's distributed manufacturing network is also a **vibrant hub of innovation, quality, sustainability and safety besides providing structural competitiveness.** An AI-first digital backbone in ITC's manufacturing facilities enhances efficiency, cost optimisation and responsiveness. Several units now meet nearly 100% of their electricity needs from renewable sources, are Platinum-rated green buildings or have achieved global AWS standards.

In line with ITC's deep commitment to an **Aatmanirbhar Bharat,** your Company is also placing sharper thrust on indigenisation and import substitution **to build structural competitiveness.** Your Company pioneered the **Bharat Fibre chain for its Paperboards business through massive afforestation, substituting imports and saving foreign exchange while creating a green cover, substantial rural livelihoods and larger value in India.** Today, this initiative has greened **nearly 1.5 million acres, generating over 270 million person-days of employment.**

ITC also established the **first-of-its-kind Bleached Chemi-Thermo Mechanical Pulp** Plant at Bhadrachalam, creating domestic capability in specialised pulp, and is now investing in a second BCTMP mill. Additionally, investments have also been made in domestic capsule manufacturing capacity and a Décor Paper plant to substitute imports. These interventions will significantly enhance cost competitiveness while also enabling foreign exchange savings exceeding **₹17,500 crore over the next decade.**

For us at ITC, this is the larger meaning of **Bharat Built Manufacturing** in action — **to build globally competitive domestic manufacturing assets,** substitute imports, enrich the environment and support sustainable livelihoods.

ITC: Supporting Climate Action & Inclusive Growth

I now turn to two defining imperatives of our times — **climate resilience and livelihood generation** — both vital for a sustainable, inclusive and competitive future. For India, climate risks are acute, severely impacting agri-food security, livelihoods, productivity and infrastructure.

While the Government has spearheaded world-leading efforts, the consequences of the climate crisis demand far more urgent, collective and sustained action at scale — globally, nationally and locally.

To my mind, enterprises can take transformational measures to combat climate change and also foster inclusive development. ITC's comprehensive approach addresses climate risks through large-scale programmes aimed at decarbonisation, adaptation, nature-based solutions and circularity, while also implementing a mosaic of solutions for rural empowerment.

What differentiates ITC's sustainability journey is a triad of achievements. First, **Longevity,** that is reflected in decades of sustained environmental impact. Second, **Scale,** which is demonstrated through the massive creation of ecological capital and support to millions of livelihoods. Third, **Integration,** through a distinctive model where sustainability and inclusivity are core pillars of strategy, governance and programmes.

ITC is the only company in the world to be carbon positive, water positive and solid waste recycling positive for around 2 decades now. ITC's businesses support nearly 9 million sustainable livelihoods.

Decarbonisation remains an important element of our climate action. Over the years, your Company has made significant investments in areas like renewable energy, green infrastructure and mobility. It is a matter of immense satisfaction that ITC has **surpassed several of its ambitious 2030 Sustainability 2.0 targets,** even as our businesses have expanded considerably. We are now committed to achieving **Net Zero Operations by 2050,** entailing a reduction in GHG by over 85% in the next 25 years.

While Decarbonisation has gained significant traction globally, **Adaptation** measures have not drawn the attention they deserve. The world, after breaching the 1.5°C threshold last year, is headed towards 2.8°C warming in this century if stronger pathways are not pursued. This is clearly alarming and calls for decisive and urgent action.

Recognising this, ITC has implemented impactful **Adaptation** and **Nature-based Solutions** for ecosystem restoration that strengthens climate resilience, enhances farm productivity, water availability, green cover and biodiversity while supporting rural livelihoods. ITC's **Climate Smart Agriculture,** which now spans nearly **32 lakh acres** across 17 States, benefits over **12 lakh farmers.** It is premised on focused programmes that **build strong capabilities through skilling, technology adoption and development of institutional linkages.** We propose to cover **40 lakh acres under this initiative by 2030.** Impact studies have shown that CSA practices in rice and wheat have reduced costs **by over 20%, improved yields by around 10% and enhanced net returns by over 23%** compared to conventional practices.

Your Company has built deep capabilities in water stewardship, afforestation and biodiversity conservation. ITC's **large-scale water management interventions** follow a three-pronged approach — community-led watershed programmes, demand-side agricultural water management and revival of river sub-basins. Demand-side initiatives, focussing on **"more crop per drop",** cover over 20 lakh acres, creating annual water-saving potential of **up to 50% across 15 crops, aggregating to 1.5 billion cubic metres.**

Supply-side watershed projects cumulatively span nearly **20 lakh acres,** helping around **90% of farmers** in catchments to cultivate through the year. Four river sub-basins have been made water positive, with work under way on the fifth. Such water stewardship interventions have improved gross cropped area by as much as 12%, cropping intensity and groundwater levels by up to 14 and 15% whilst delivering larger benefits for communities.

Biodiversity conservation is a key priority area for sustaining natural ecosystems, strengthening agri-food security, supporting rural livelihoods and building long-term resilience. Your Company's programme focuses on restoring ecosystem services that support agriculture. This is expected to cover **nearly 10 lakh acres by 2030.**

Your Company's **Social Investments Programme spans 275 districts in 20 States,** cumulatively benefiting over **10 million people,** including **6 million women** while amplifying impact with 98 public-private-people partnerships. While the scale and outcomes are deeply satisfying, what inspires us to do more are the human stories behind the numbers.

It is heartening to **witness farmers with better incomes, women with greater economic agency, children with stronger learning foundations and youth with improved employability.** This larger purpose to make a meaningful difference defines the core of our social endeavours.

India's ancient wisdom enshrined in ***Vasudhaiva Kutumbakam*** reminds us that the world is one family, and the responsibility to protect our only home — the planet as well as its people — rests on all of us. We believe that our **'dharma' of Responsible Competitiveness** and the spirit of **'Aparigraha' to mindfully use resources** as well as **'Abhyudaya' which is premised on simultaneous economic and societal progress,** are timeless principles that will continue to inspire us in creating enduring value for all stakeholders.

In Conclusion

As India advances towards becoming a developed nation, ITC will remain steadfast in its commitment to serve with purpose, innovate with responsibility, grow with the nation and multiply value for our country. **Our heart and soul have always belonged to India. This has been our legacy. It will remain our promise.**

It is a privilege for ITC to be part of this momentous journey — powered by an inspiring Vision, guided by unshakeable Values, and energised by renewed Vitality.

As I conclude, I would like to reaffirm my belief that your Company's greatest and most enduring asset is its people. It is their dedication, ingenuity and unwavering commitment that give wings to our ambition, resilience to our efforts and purpose to our progress. Their dedication gives us the courage to dream boldly and shape ITC as an exemplary institution of a new India with **passion, performance and purpose.**

On behalf of the Board and myself, I thank all our stakeholders for their continued trust, support and encouragement.

Together, let us partner India and help build a future worthy of the aspirations of this great nation.

Govt to SC: Creamy layer principle not applicable to quotas for SCs, STs

Govt says PILs do not disclose any infringement of fundamental rights under Constitution

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Centre has told the Supreme Court that the principle of creamy layer was not applicable to reservation for Scheduled Castes (SCs) and Scheduled Tribes (STs).

The government has opposed PILs seeking implementation of the "creamy layer" principle in reservation for SCs and STs, and also the direction to the Centre to frame policies for a more equitable system of reservation in government employment.

The government said the PILs do not disclose any infringement of the fundamental rights under the Constitution.

"It has nowhere specifically been held that the principle of creamy layer is applicable to SCs and STs. The reference made to the concept of creamy layer…appears to be the general observation with regard to reservation in respect of OBCs (Other Backward Classes)/ SEBCs (Socially and Educationally Backward Classes).

"This has been clarified by a Constitution bench of this court in the case of Ashoka Kumar Thakur versus Union of India… that for the purpose of reservation, the principles of creamy layer are not applicable to SCs and STs," the government said in its affidavit to the Supreme Court.

The creamy layer principle was first devised by the Supreme Court in its famous Mandal case verdict of 1992 by which certain affluent people belonging to the Backward Classes were excluded from reservation in government jobs and admissions in educational institutions.

The government in its affidavit said, "That modification of reservation policy, particularly to introduce income-based preferences within reserved categories, should be preceded by a holistic review and thorough empirical study, including socio-economic data of reserved category beneficiaries."

It added that no direction can be issued to the executive to frame policy in a particular manner, which is beyond the judicial domain.

The Centre's affidavit sought dismissal of PILs filed by petitioners Ramashankar Prajapati and others, and advocate Ashwini Upadhyay, saying they were not maintainable under the law.

It said these petitions neither raise any question of law pertaining to the Constitution and which need interpretation of this court nor disclose the infringement of the fundamental rights under the Constitution and, therefore, were not maintainable under Article 32 and hence, deserve to be dismissed with exemplary cost.

The affidavit emphasised that fundamental rights guaranteed to the subject or subjects under Part III of the Constitution were negative in character and positive in sanction.

"In other words, the subject/s cannot enforce his fundamental right by way of filing a writ petition under Article 32 of the Constitution, unless and until it is infringed by the state," it said.

The affidavit filed by the social justice and empowerment ministry said the present petition has been filed in ignorance of the law laid down by this court in a catena of judgments in which this court has elaborately dealt with the scope and ambit of Articles 341 and 342 of the Constitution.

Highlights

» The creamy layer principle was first devised by the Supreme Court in its famous Mandal case verdict of 1992

» The Centre's affidavit sought dismissal of PILs filed by petitioners Ramashankar Prajapati and others, and advocate Ashwini Upadhyay, saying they were not maintainable under the law

» The affidavit emphasised that fundamental rights guaranteed to the subject or subjects under Part III of the Constitution were negative in character and positive in sanction

VIOLENCE IN STUDENTS' BIHAR BANDH

Oppn discusses sending MPs' delegation to meet injured

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The INDIA Bloc on Thursday discussed a proposal to send a delegation of Opposition MPs to Bihar's Siwan, where three youths suffered bullet injuries during the student protests last month, sources said.

The proposal came up during the Opposition alliance's meeting this morning, where it was suggested that MPs visit Siwan to meet the injured students and assess the situation on the ground, they said.

Leader of Opposition in Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi proposed that Opposition MPs travel to Siwan to meet the injured students and ascertain the facts surrounding the police firing, according to the sources.

While no final decision has been taken, the proposal found broad support during the meeting and the modalities are being worked out, the sources said.

This comes as Opposition parties have alleged that excessive police force was used on students during last month's protests. They have also been seeking a response from Union Home minister Amit Shah regarding the use of pellet guns on protesters during the Cockroach Janta Party-led march to Parliament on July 20 in Delhi.

Opposition leaders have also raised the issue of AK-47 guns being fired on protesting students in Bihar.

The Siwan incident occurred on July 25 during a Bihar bandh called by the All India Students' Association (AISA) and other organisations protesting the alleged irregularities in the NEET-UG examination and demanding action against those responsible.

Violence broke out after clashes between protesters and police, following which security personnel resorted to lathi-charge, tear gas and firing.

Three youths -- Mohammad Arif, Akash Kumar and Bullet Kumar Gond -- sustained bullet injuries. One suffered a gunshot wound in the thigh, while the other two sustained injuries in the shoulder and neck. They were shifted to Patna for treatment and are reported to be out of danger.

The Bihar Police has maintained that force was used after protesters allegedly turned violent and attacked security personnel, and has said investigations are underway into the circumstances in which the three sustained bullet injuries.

An AISA fact-finding team subsequently visited Siwan, met the injured students and their families, and alleged that the police had resorted to unprovoked firing on peaceful demonstrators.

Closer Look

» 'Rahul Gandhi proposed that MPs travel to Siwan to meet injured students and ascertain facts surrounding police firing'

» Opposition leaders have also raised the issue of AK-47 guns being fired on protesting students in Bihar

PM SVANidhi: 76.95L street vendors avail Rs 18,475 cr collateral-free loans

NEW DELHI: Nearly 77 lakh street vendors have availed 1.15 crore collateral-free working capital loans worth more than Rs 18,475 crore under the PM SVANidhi scheme till July 12 this year, the government informed the Rajya Sabha on Thursday.

In a written reply to a question, Union Housing and Urban Affairs minister Manohar Lal said the Prime Minister Street Vendor's AtmaNirbhar Nidhi (PM SVANidhi) scheme was launched on June 1, 2020 with the objective of facilitating collateral-free working capital term loans to urban street vendors.

He said that under the restructured scheme, approved by the Union Cabinet in August last year, working capital term loans are provided to the street vendors in three tranches of up to Rs 15,000, Rs 25,000, and Rs 50,000 for repayment in 12 months, 18 months, and 36 months respectively through monthly instalments.

"As on 12th July, 2026, 76.95 lakh street vendors have availed 1.15 crore collateral-free loans amounting to Rs 18,475.06 crore under the Scheme," the minister said in the written reply.

Impact assessment studies of the PM SVANidhi scheme were undertaken by Indian School of Business (ISB), Hyderabad in 2023 and 2025.

According to the minister's reply, the 2023 study was conducted in 100 Urban Local Bodies (ULBs) across the country covering more than 5,000 beneficiaries and it found that PM SVANidhi was the first loan from a bank for 95 per cent of the beneficiaries.

The 2025 study was conducted in 99 ULBs across the country covering more than 5,000 beneficiaries (with around 60 per cent of the respondents being part of the 2023 study sample) and it found that the average annualised business income among SVANidhi borrowers grew by around 20 per cent, between 2023 and 2025.

Impact assessment studies of the PM SVANidhi scheme were undertaken by Indian School of Business, Hyderabad in 2023 and 2025

Govt can't stop me from raising students' voice: Rahul

Prayagraj venue provider revokes permission for 'Chhatron Ki Goonj' event

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: With the venue provider in Prayagraj revoking permission for his 'Chhatron Ki Goonj' event, Congress leader Rahul Gandhi on Thursday said no matter how hard the BJP government tries, it cannot stop him from raising the voice of students.

The Leader of Opposition's remarks came after the Kayastha Pathshala Trust revoked permission for his 'Chhatron Ki Goonj' programme, scheduled to be held at KP Ground in Prayagraj on August 8, citing an Allahabad High Court order.

The trust also cited waterlogging at the venue for the cancellation.

In a post in Hindi on X, Gandhi said the students of Allahabad University are fighting for their future against fee hikes and seat cuts.

Congress MPs Rahul Gandhi and Priyanka Gandhi Vadra during a protest march, during the Monsoon session of Parliament, in New Delhi, Wednesday PTI

"But instead of listening to the students, the administration is filing FIRs against them," he alleged.

The policy of the Modi government is to suppress the voice of the youth, Gandhi claimed.

"Ask a question and you get a lathi charge, protest and you face cases, and raise your voice and you get pellet guns," Gandhi said.

"Ever since I decided to come to Prayagraj to hear the students' issues, the administration has been trying every possible way to stop my programme," Gandhi said.

It's clear that they are even afraid of 'Chhatron ki Goonj', he said.

"I stand with the students. No matter how hard the government tries, it cannot stop me from raising their voice," Gandhi asserted.

Gandhi's remarks came after the Kayastha Pathshala Trust's acting president, Jitendra Nath Chaudhary, told news agency that the Allahabad High Court, in an order dated August 14, 2025, had directed that the KP College ground should not be used for purposes other than sports and educational activities.

Meanwhile, in a fresh outreach to the GenZ, Congress leader Rahul Gandhi on Thursday launched an "Ask Me Anything" session on Instagram during which he answered questions, including one on the student protest in Jharkhand, and asserted that every government should listen to what students are saying.

Kejriwal says his Instagram account restricted in India

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: AAP national convener Arvind Kejriwal said on Thursday his Instagram account has been restricted in India and urged others facing a similar issue to get in touch with him.

In a post on X, Kejriwal said enquiries at Meta's India office revealed that his Instagram account had been restricted and was unavailable in India.

Kejriwal said in a video post on X, "I have got to know that whoever is speaking against ethanol or paper leak, their social media accounts are being suppressed. If anyone else is also facing the same issue, please message me."

Meta did not immediately respond to the matter.

Kejriwal also shared a screenshot of his account status page showing the message, "Unavailable in some locations".

Calling the company's lack of clarity and response "pretty bad service", former Delhi chief minister said in his post, "Don't bow down to the prime minister, else he will allow you to run only his own account in India."

TN CM urges PM to implement Godavari-Cauvery-Gundar river linking project

CHENNAI: Tamil Nadu Chief Minister C Joseph Vijay on Thursday urged Prime Minister Narendra Modi to expedite the implementation of the Godavari-Cauvery-Gundar river linking project and declare it a "project of national importance."

Emphasising Tamil Nadu's inherent surface water deficit and its dependence on neighbouring states for over 30 per cent of its water requirements, the chief minister sought the prime minister's direct intervention to ensure long-term drinking water and irrigation security for southern India.

"Groundwater resources have also been exploited to critical levels, with several regions continuing to experience over-exploitation despite the sustained regulatory and conservation measures undertaken by the state government," he said in a letter to the PM.

"The Godavari-Cauvery-Gundar Link represents the most significant long term opportunity for augmenting Tamil Nadu's surface water resources. It is of vital importance to redress the growing needs of drinking water and irrigation for the population in Tamil Nadu," he said, adding, "The southern districts of Tamil Nadu, particularly Pudukkottai, Sivagangai, Ramanathapuram and Virudhunagar, are chronically water-scarce and highly drought-prone".

Stating that most sustainable means of addressing their growing water requirements, therefore, would be the implementation of the Godavari-Cauvery-Vaigai-Gundar link project, which would facilitate the transfer of surplus floodwaters from water-surplus basins to water-deficit regions, the chief minister said, "The National Water Development Agency has prepared the Detailed Project Report (DPR) for the Godavari-Pennar-Palar-Vellar Link as phase one of the larger project". MPOST

Govt data: Over Rs 180 cr incurred on PM's foreign visits to various countries

Including US, UK, France, China and Japan in 2025

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Over Rs 180 crore was incurred on Prime Minister Narendra Modi's visit to 23 countries including the US, the UK, France, China and Japan in 2025, according to data shared by the government.

According to the country-wise and year-wise data shared in a written response to a query in the Rajya Sabha on Thursday, the figure for the year 2026 so far stood at nearly Rs 74.58 crore. This includes the visit undertaken to Indonesia, Australia and New Zealand from July 6 to July 11.

In their query, MPs Sanjay Singh and V Sivadasan asked the Ministry of External Affairs (MEA) for country-wise details of the foreign visits undertaken by the prime minister since 2021; and the total expenditure incurred on such visits since 2021, year-wise and visit-wise.

Minister of State for External Affairs Pabitra Margherita shared the data in an annexure attached with his response.

"The details of foreign visits undertaken by the Prime Minister since 2021 and total expenditure incurred on each foreign visit, year-wise and visit-wise are placed at Annexure-I. For reference purposes, expenditure on Prime Minister's foreign visits earlier was INR 10,74,27,363 (USA, 2011), INR 9,95,76,890 (Russia, 2013), INR 8,33,49,463 (France, 2011) and INR 6,02,23,484 (Germany, 2013). These figures show actual expenditure without adjusting for inflation or currency fluctuations," he said.

According to the data, nearly Rs 187 crore was incurred on Prime Minister Modi's visit to various countries in 2025.

UP elections: Why Akhilesh Yadav recalibrating his Brahmin outreach?

BISWAJEET BANERJEE

LUCKNOW: Samajwadi Party president Akhilesh Yadav has begun recasting one of his party's most successful political slogans.

The 'P' in the PDA formula, which originally stood for Pichchra (Backward), is now increasingly being projected as Pandit, signalling a strategic attempt to bring Brahmins back into the SP fold ahead of the 2027 Uttar Pradesh Assembly elections.

The shift marks one of the most significant ideological and electoral recalibrations by the SP since it coined the PDA, or Pichchra, Dalit, Alpsankhyak, narrative before the 2024 Lok Sabha elections. That formula helped the INDIA bloc win 43 of Uttar Pradesh's 80 Lok Sabha seats and reduced the BJP's tally sharply.

With the Assembly election now less than a year away, the party appears to believe that expanding the social coalition is more important than preserving the original slogan.

The new messaging became evident on Wednesday when Akhilesh Yadav celebrated the birth anniversary of Janeshwar Mishra at the party headquarters and repeatedly referred to the 'P' in PDA as 'Pandit'.

He paid floral tributes to Mishra's statue and launched a sharp political attack on the BJP over the alleged theft of donations at the Ram Temple in Ayodhya. He also accused the BJP of failing to give adequate representation to Brahmins and claimed the community's self-respect had been undermined.

The symbolism was deliberate. Janeshwar Mishra, popularly known as 'Chhote Lohia', remains one of the tallest Brahmin socialist leaders and continues to command respect across ideological lines.

By placing Mishra at the centre of its latest campaign, the SP is attempting to reassure Brahmins that the party values both their political contribution and leadership.

DMK TOPS LIST

Regional parties' declared donations more than triple to over Rs 1,050 crore, says ADR

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Declared donations above Rs 20,000 received by regional political parties increased more than threefold in 2024-25 compared to the previous year, with DMK emerging as the biggest recipient, according to a report by the Association for Democratic Reforms released on Thursday.

The amount received in donations by the regional parties was Rs 1,051.56 crore in 2024-25, up from Rs 347.69 crore in 2023-24, while the total number of donations received for the two years were 5,297 and 2,861, respectively -- denoting an 85 per cent increase.

Corporate and business houses continued to dominate political funding, contributing Rs 644.93 crore in 2024-25, nearly three times the Rs 227.61 crore amount donated in the previous year, though their share in the total value of donations declined marginally.

Across the two financial years, corporate and business houses contributed Rs 872.54 crore through 650 donations, adding up to over 62 per cent of the total value of contributions.

Individual donors accounted for the largest number of donations, making 5,647 contributions across two years. However, they contributed only Rs 193.95 crore, or about 14 per cent of the total value of donations.

While the number of individual donations increased in 2024-25, their overall value declined, resulting in a sharp fall in their share of total donations.

The report also flagged a sharp increase in donations from undeclared donors, which rose from Rs 6.62 crore in 2023-24 to Rs 302.67 crore in 2024-25, taking their share in the total value of donations to nearly 29 per cent.

The Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (DMK) received the highest amount from undeclared donors at Rs 300.64 crore, accounting for over 82 per cent of its total declared donations during the year.

The Tamil Nadu-based party also topped the list of recipients in 2024-25 with declared donations of Rs 365.78 crore, followed by the All India Trinamool Congress (AITC) at Rs 184.96 crore and the YSR Congress at Rs 140.04 crore.

Notably, the Telugu Desam Party (TDP) had been the highest recipient in 2023-24 with Rs 100.19 crore.

The report pointed out that AITC, YSR Congress, TDP, All India Anna Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (AIADMK) and Biju Janata Dal (BJD) relied almost entirely on corporate and business house donations, with negligible or no contributions from other donor categories.

Prudent Electoral Trust emerged as the largest donor across the two financial years, contributing Rs 434 crore through 38 donations, followed by Tiger Associates with Rs 160 crore.

Progressive Electoral Trust, Vedanta Limited and AB General Electoral Trust also featured among the top five donors.

Electoral trusts continued to dominate political funding, with Prudent Electoral Trust, Progressive Electoral Trust and AB General Electoral Trust together contributing Rs 536 crore, or about 64 per cent of the total donations made by the top 10 donors during the two-year period.

The report further found that donations without PAN details increased sharply in value from Rs 7.69 crore in FY2023-24 to Rs 329.58 crore in FY2024-25, accounting for over 31 per cent of the total donations received during the year. The number of donations without PAN details also rose to 2,463 from 529 in the previous year.

It also noted that cash donations increased sharply in value to Rs 301.44 crore in FY2024-25 from Rs 6.54 crore in the previous year, while 1,978 donations worth Rs 13.39 crore were reported without disclosing the mode of payment.

Key Points

» The amount received in donations by the regional parties was Rs 1,051.56 crore in 2024-25, up from Rs 347.69 crore in 2023-24

» The report also flagged a sharp increase in donations from undeclared donors, which rose from Rs 6.62 crore in 2023-24 to Rs 302.67 crore in 2024-25, taking their share in the total value of donations to nearly 29 per cent

» Notably, the Telugu Desam Party (TDP) had been the highest recipient in 2023-24 with Rs 100.19 crore

Nation Briefs

TN COURT ORDERS NON-BAILABLE WARRANT AGAINST EX-MINISTER PONMUDY

CHENNAI: A metropolitan magistrate court on Thursday issued a non-bailable warrant against senior DMK leader, former minister K Ponmudy for his alleged derogatory remarks against Saivaites, Vaishnavites and women. After Ponmudy made the alleged remarks last year at an event, BJP Chennai corporation councillor Uma Anandan lodged a private complaint and the III metropolitan magistrate's court at George Town here had taken cognisance of it. Last month, Madras High Court Judge, Justice GK Ilanthiraiyan had dismissed a petition filed by Ponmudy seeking to set aside the BJP leader's complaint. Against this background, when the matter came up in George Town court, the counsel for the complainant submitted that the High Court had directed the trial court to complete the trial within six months.

INDIA, US SPECIAL FORCES HOLD JOINT COUNTER-TERRORISM EXERCISE

NEW DELHI: Special Forces of India and the US are undertaking a joint exercise in the country to strengthen counter-terrorism cooperation, officials said on Thursday. Commandos from India's National Security Guard (NSG) and the United States Special Operations Forces (US SOF) are taking part in the eighth edition of the bilateral exercise -- Tarkash -- being held from July 13 to August 7. "Throughout the exercise, personnel from both forces demonstrated exceptional professionalism, adaptability and commitment to excellence," the NSG said in a social media post.

EDITORIAL

PRICE OF CONVENIENCE?

India's Unified Payments Interface (UPI) is arguably the country's most successful digital public infrastructure project. In less than a decade, it has transformed how Indians pay, making cashless transactions instantaneous, free and nearly universal. From roadside tea stalls to luxury malls, QR codes have replaced card-swiping machines and cash counters. Yet the very success of UPI has exposed an uncomfortable economic reality: a payment system handling nearly ₹30 lakh crore worth of transactions every month cannot remain entirely free forever. The debate over reintroducing Merchant Discount Rate (MDR) on UPI payments made to large retailers is therefore not merely about charging a fee. It is about determining who should bear the cost of sustaining India's digital payments revolution. Parliament's recent amendment to the Payment and Settlement Systems Act has created the legal framework for the government to permit such charges, although no final decision has yet been taken. Discussions have centred on applying MDR only to large merchants and higher-value transactions rather than to ordinary users or small businesses.

The economics behind the proposal are difficult to ignore. Every UPI transaction may appear free to consumers, but it is far from costless. Banks maintain payment infrastructure, payment service providers process millions of requests every second, fintech companies invest heavily in cybersecurity, fraud detection, customer support and technological upgrades, while the National Payments Corporation of India (NPCI) continuously expands capacity to handle record transaction volumes. Since MDR on UPI was abolished in 2020 to accelerate digital adoption, these institutions have largely depended on government incentives and indirect revenue streams to recover costs. Those subsidies have helped India build the world's largest real-time payment ecosystem, but they cannot continue indefinitely as transaction volumes multiply. RBI Governor Sanjay Malhotra recently summed up the dilemma by observing that while users do not directly pay for UPI, someone ultimately bears the cost because digital payment infrastructure is a public good requiring sustainable funding. The question is no longer whether UPI costs money to operate—it clearly does—but whether the present financing model is economically viable over the long term.

This is where the distinction between small merchants and organised retail becomes crucial. A neighbourhood kirana store, street vendor or vegetable seller embraced UPI because it eliminated the transaction costs associated with cards. Imposing MDR on such businesses would risk reversing financial inclusion and encourage a return to cash. Large retailers, however, operate under an entirely different economic model. Supermarket chains, e-commerce giants, branded retail outlets and organised businesses already absorb card-processing charges as part of their operating expenses. Their scale, bargaining power and profit margins enable them to negotiate payment costs more effectively than small traders. Industry discussions therefore focus on applying MDR only to merchants above a specified turnover threshold and possibly only on transactions exceeding ₹2,000. Such payments constitute a small fraction of transaction volume but account for a disproportionately large share of the total value flowing through UPI. If designed carefully, this approach could generate substantial revenue for banks and payment companies without burdening the millions of small businesses that rely on zero-cost digital payments for survival. It would also preserve UPI's core objective of financial inclusion while recognising that organised retail has both the capacity and incentive to contribute to maintaining the ecosystem from which it benefits immensely.

The proposal nevertheless carries genuine risks that policymakers must anticipate. Merchants rarely absorb additional costs indefinitely; they often pass them on to consumers through higher prices or subtle pricing adjustments. While MDR is technically a merchant fee, its economic incidence can eventually fall on customers. There is also the possibility that retailers may begin steering consumers towards cash or specific payment methods that minimise costs, undermining the seamless experience that has driven UPI's extraordinary adoption. Another concern is policy consistency. For years, successive governments promoted UPI as a completely free public utility. Any shift towards paid transactions, even if limited to large retailers, could create confusion and generate fears that universal charges are inevitable. Public trust remains one of UPI's greatest strengths. The government must therefore communicate clearly that peer-to-peer transfers, small-value transactions and payments made to small merchants will continue to remain free. Equally important, any MDR introduced should remain modest, transparent and subject to periodic review rather than becoming an open-ended revenue mechanism.

Ultimately, the debate is not about dismantling India's digital payments success story but about ensuring that it remains sustainable. Public infrastructure cannot rely indefinitely on government subsidies when it has matured into the backbone of the country's economy. Roads collect tolls, stock exchanges levy transaction fees, telecom operators recover network costs and card networks operate through MDR. UPI cannot remain the lone exception if its scale continues to expand exponentially. However, sustainability must not come at the expense of inclusivity. A calibrated policy that exempts consumers, protects small merchants and asks only large organised retailers to share a modest portion of the infrastructure cost offers the most balanced path forward. The government's challenge lies in preserving the simplicity and affordability that made UPI a global model while ensuring that banks, fintech firms and payment networks have sufficient incentives to keep investing in resilience, innovation and security. If India succeeds in striking that balance, the introduction of carefully targeted merchant fees will not represent a retreat from digital payments but rather the next stage in the maturation of one of the country's greatest technological achievements.

CLEAN COAL

Mining the Net Zero Path

India's Net Zero journey by 2070 hinges on renewable energy, cleaner coal technologies, methane capture, carbon markets and sustainable mining reforms

SUTIRTHA BHATTACHARYA & DN PRASAD

S BHATTACHARYA IS A RETIRED IAS OFFICER AND A FORMER CHAIRMAN OF COAL INDIA LIMITED; DN PRASAD IS A FORMER ADVISER, MINISTRY OF COAL

Coal will remain central to India's energy mix for years, but the industry now faces an urgent challenge — reducing emissions while supporting economic growth

Climate change is the existential buzzword today. Discussions on GHGs (greenhouse gases) like carbon dioxide, methane, etc., are now drawing-room topics. Global warming is heating up many debates as El Niño shows the mirror to our model of progress. Greenhouse gases retain infrared radiation within the Earth, causing global warming. Rapid industrialisation has driven these emissions, causing global warming.

The world adopted the Kyoto Protocol in 1997 to legally bind developed countries to reduce greenhouse gas emissions. Market-based mechanisms for emissions trading and the Clean Development Mechanism emerged as viable routes to achieving the Protocol's objectives, albeit with limited success.

The United Nations Framework Convention on Climate Change (UNFCCC) adopted the Paris Agreement in 2015, broadening participation to all countries. The objective was to limit the global temperature rise to well below 2 degrees Celsius above the pre-industrial era benchmark, while making proactive efforts to achieve 1.5 degrees Celsius. Nationally Determined Contributions (NDCs), transparency, periodic reviews, climate financing, and technology transfer were the pathways envisaged. The Glasgow Climate Pact of 2021, for the first time, recognised the unabated use of coal as a prime cause of GHG emissions and declared the phasing down of coal as a collective goal.

The race towards Net Zero demands cleaner coal, smarter mining and stronger carbon accountability across the sector

Net Zero Emissions, meaning achieving a balance between GHG emissions and removals, implying that all carbon emissions must be reduced to a level that leaves no residual emissions in the atmosphere, became the focal point, with developed countries, China, and India committing to attain net zero by 2050, 2060, and 2070, respectively.

India, with its experience of schemes like Perform, Achieve and Trade (PAT), Renewable Energy Certificates, and Clean Development Mechanism (CDM) projects, moved fast. The Energy Conservation (Amendment) Act, 2022, was legislated, and the Carbon Credit Trading Scheme, 2023, was notified with the clear goal of promoting low-carbon technology to mitigate GHG emissions. The carbon trading system brought in the required transparency, and the national electricity regulator (CERC) framed the enabling regulations, with the Bureau of Energy Efficiency (BEE) remaining the nodal agency.

India outpaced almost all other economies in the capacity addition of non-fossil fuel-based energy. The share of non-fossil fuel capacity rose from about 36% in March 2010 to about 53% in March 2026. The share of renewable energy (RE) capacity rose from about 10% to 42% during this period.

However, coal continues to remain an essential fuel for electricity generation in India and many other countries. Disruptive changes have indeed phased down coal in terms of its growth potential, but not its existential usage.

Now, the coal sector needs to rise to the occasion towards mitigating GHG emissions. Technical ways to mitigate these emissions include methane capture and utilisation, carbon capture, utilisation and storage (CCUS), wherever techno-economically feasible, energy-efficient mining operations, electrification of mining equipment, renewable energy adoption, mine reclamation, and intensive afforestation.

Indian coal production is predominantly from opencast, or strip, mining, which limits the scope for the economic capture and utilisation of methane from mining operations. In some parts of the country, deep underground mines with the presence of methane provide scope for methane capture, thereby directly reducing GHG emissions. These areas should receive focused attention to secure the best opportunities in carbon credit markets.

By using electric vehicles for all possible mining activities, adopting a much higher level of plantation coverage with species suitable to local communities, and concentrating on the development of renewable energy with stable transmission as the most pressing business development initiative, coal companies in the country can open a rich financing route for themselves by trading carbon credits achieved transparently in the emerging markets. Some international coal companies are already actively pursuing this path. The time has come for India to have a task force to guide the phasing down of coal in the least disruptive and most efficacious way. Efforts should be integrated with similar initiatives in the thermal power sector. Activity-wise ballpark estimates of emissions and ready-to-implement project reports for securing carbon credits, representing one metric tonne of carbon dioxide reduced, avoided, or removed from the atmosphere, should be prepared to facilitate expeditious adoption. Carbon credit verification organisations like Verra, Gold Standard, and the like could be associated with the process on a non-commercial basis. Limits may tighten, and carbon credit revenue opportunities for the coal sector will diminish as time passes. The need of the sector is to act now. The coal sector, which has been extraordinarily responsive in meeting India's energy needs, will have to show the same kind of alacrity in traversing the carbon mitigation path and facilitating the achievement of India's commitment to Net Zero by 2070.

Views expressed are personal

CITIZEN FILES

Identity Conundrum

As identity verification expands, citizens increasingly wonder whether decades of official documents are still enough to prove identity

MITALI MADHUSMITA

THE WRITER IS A RETIRED IRS OFFICER WHO SERVED AS THE PRINCIPAL CHIEF COMMISSIONER OF INCOME TAX IN ANDHRA PRADESH AND TELANGANA

From passwords and Aadhaar to voter verification, India's growing dependence on identity proofs has exposed the fragile relationship between citizens, technology and the State

Of late, as I move on in years, I find myself scratching my head over some utterly inexplicable phenomena that have become the bane of a peaceful, retired life. It is true that I am technologically challenged vis-à-vis my counterparts and certainly face a tech chasm in contrast to my kids and their peers, but it is not just technology but also the logic and common sense behind some recent developments that are baffling.

I am talking about identity, about which there is currently a big fuss in our country, and it is getting crazier by the day. Once upon a time, you needed a user ID and password for any financial activity, small or big, that you wished to perform online. It made sense for protecting sensitive personal data such as internet banking, income tax filing, e-commerce, email, etc., or your workplace-specific requirements. Public digital infrastructure such as Aadhaar requires it too, as a unique ID footprint ensures public subsidies and benefits reach genuine users. Up until this point, it was okay, but thereafter all the other wannabe actors thought, "Sounds good, why not have it for ourselves too?"

Having proved your identity multiple times over decades, you are suddenly left struggling to prove you even exist

Thus, now social media platforms (YouTube, Instagram, X, Facebook), matrimonial sites, dating apps—you name it—they have all jumped into the act. They all require you to prove your identity. Unfortunately, as users are not very aware of online safety and hygiene, they are vulnerable to identity theft. The other extreme vulnerability is the army of trolls, where any individual can single-handedly manufacture thousands of fake online identities, which can then be manipulated to suit the individual's preferences. There is an increased risk of child abusers and paedophiles misusing children's profiles for nefarious reasons. Resultantly, before every online financial transaction, one does a small prayer that everything goes well. As for social media platforms, this is a calculated risk for famous personalities or politicians. For faceless bureaucrats like me, it was always a no-no.

There is also the bigger issue of proving your citizenship for the civic duty of casting your vote and choosing your public representative, and it is here that the head swims! The ECI has embarked upon the Special Intensive Drive, an exercise it is mandated to perform from time to time. But this time, it places a question mark on one's identity as a citizen. Having lived in India for decades and proven your identity multiple times, you are left struggling to prove you were born and lived all your life in the country of your birth, or that you even exist. Suddenly, state-issued documents such as EPIC (Electoral Photo Identity Card), Aadhaar, passport, driving licence, ration card, etc., are no longer material in proving citizenship. Apparently, in a sudden switch of the goalposts, it turns out these documents were proof only of voting, identity, residence or travel thus far. It is all very well for the state to discredit its own issued documents, but where does that leave the common man or woman?

Our BLO, a very earnest and hard-working young man, informs us that our names do not figure in the electoral rolls of 2002, but we can still catch the bus (read, vote) if our parents' names appear in those lists. Excuse me, but our parents, born in pre-Independence India, where no proof of date of birth existed (save for what was recorded from memory in their school or college certificates), are legitimate voters while we, struggling to keep our date with the State for driving licences, Aadhaar and passports, have no papers? Not logical, right?

Now, therefore, many of us have no identity, though we went through the process of procuring these documents, updating addresses in them from time to time, and using all, or at least some, of them frequently. Life goes on as usual; no one in our circle, or those we interact with outside, raises any eyebrows at a non-citizen, but it is too early to say. Therefore, fingers crossed and optimistic as always, we go about our roles in life, trying to lead our normal lives, at least until the next inexplicable phenomenon strikes!

Views expressed are personal

DEAR EDITOR

STRENGTHENING DEMOCRACY

The emergence of the Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) as a self-described pressure group deserves attention beyond the politics surrounding it. Democracies function best when governments are held accountable not only by the Opposition but also by organised citizen movements. The recent student protests over the alleged NEET paper leak highlighted widespread frustration with examination integrity, unemployment and declining public trust in institutions. However, pressure groups must remain peaceful, transparent and issue-based. Violence during protests and the filing of criminal cases against students have deepened public anxiety rather than resolving it. At the same time, governments should distinguish between unlawful acts and legitimate democratic dissent. Whether one agrees with the CJP's methods or not, the issues it has raised—education reforms, youth employment and institutional credibility—cannot be ignored. India needs stronger institutions, fair investigations and meaningful dialogue instead of confrontation. Constructive engagement, rather than political polarisation, will ultimately serve both democracy and the aspirations of the country's young citizens.

AYUSH RAWAT,
BANGALORE

millenniumpost.in

Send your letters to **letter2editor.mp@gmail.com**. You can also send your comments to The Editor, *Millennium Post*, Pratap Bhawan, 5 Bahadur Shah Zafar Marg, New Delhi 110 002

11-MEMBER TEAM FORMED TO HOLD TALKS WITH GOVT

J'khand exam stir enters 13th day, six on fast

MPOST BUREAU

RANCHI: The protest against the alleged irregularities in recruitment exams in Jharkhand entered its 13th day on Thursday with six demonstrators on a hunger strike, while agitating students and job aspirants formed an 11-member delegation to hold talks with the government to resolve the impasse.

The ripples of their demonstration reached the state Assembly during the day with Opposition MLAs raising slogans on its premises on the first day of the Monsoon Session.

The protest, which began on July 25 under the banner of the JPSC-JSSC Reforms Manch at Jaipal Singh Munda Stadium here, emerged as one of the biggest student-led movements in the state in recent years.

"We have formed an 11-member delegation, comprising eight students, two experts (journalists) and an advocate, in response to the government's offer to hold talks in connection with the stir," said an office bearer of the JPSC-JSSC Reforms Manch.

The decision to hold talks was taken a day after Chief Minister Hemant Soren said the doors of his government were open to agitators.

A five-member government panel is likely to hold talks with the protesters in the evening, an official said.

The demonstrators have been demanding cancellation of the 14th Jharkhand PSC Civil Services Examination and an independent probe into the alleged irregularities in the recruitment test either by the Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) or by a panel of retired high court judges from outside the state.

They also stressed comprehensive reforms in the Jharkhand Public Service Commission (JPSC) and the Jharkhand Staff Selection Commission (JSSC).

The opposition MLAs held a protest on the assembly premises with many of them seen wearing masks displaying a message, 'Jago Sarkar Hosh Me Aao' (Govt, come out of the slumber), during the first day of the Monsoon Session.

MLAs of the opposition NDA demanded a CBI probe into the alleged irregularities in recruitment examinations.

They raised slogans against the state government, with BJP chief whip Naveen Jaiswal alleging that the government was "selling" the future of Jharkhand's youths.

"The government has set up a committee. But it should know that nobody trusts the CID and the government's committee. The probe should be conducted by the CBI," he said.

Referring to the Delhi protest against the NEET exam paper leak, which ultimately led to Dharmendra Pradhan quitting as Union education minister, the BJP's Koderma MLA Neera Yadav said,

"The Congress puts up one mask when the stir is in Delhi and a different one for Jharkhand."

The Congress is an ally of the Hemant Soren government in Jharkhand. Congress leader K Raju said the party has extended support to the students protesting at the Jaipal Singh Munda Stadium.

Chief Minister Hemant Soren had on Wednesday said the question paper leak issues are a national problem and offered talks to resolve the impasse.

Reacting to BJP's allegations, Jharkhand Minister Sudivya Kumar said on Thursday that the government was serious about the issue raised by the students.

A protester gets medical attention during an indefinite protest against the Jharkhand government regarding the irregularities of exams at Jaipal Singh Stadium, in Ranchi, Thursday PTI

HIGHLIGHTS

- » The ripples of the protest reached the Assembly during the day with Oppn raising slogans on its premises
- » The protest, which began on July 25, emerged as one of the biggest student-led movements in the state in recent years

SC denies bail to Asaram for now

Court allows caretaker of his choice

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court on Thursday denied interim bail as of now to self-styled godman Asaram, who is serving life sentence in a 2013 case of sexually assaulting a minor, but allowed him to engage a trained caretaker of his choice for round-the-clock assistance.

A bench of Justices M M Sundresh and P B Varale kept the plea filed by Asaram, seeking interim bail on health grounds, pending while granting him liberty to mention his case if his health deteriorates.

During the hearing, Solicitor General Tushar Mehta submitted that Asaram has suppressed from the court that his counsel moved an application for parole.

The counsel for Asaram said the parole was filed much earlier and that it was not granted on health grounds.

The Rajasthan High Court had earlier granted 20-day parole to Asaram, saying the state government failed to justify its decision to reject his parole application.

The HC had granted relief to the 85-year-old Asaram, lodged in Jodhpur Central Jail, taking note of the duration of his incarceration and his conduct during earlier periods of interim release.

The top court was earlier informed that experts from AIIMS have suggested that Asaram does not require hospitalisation but needs round-the-clock medical assistance.

On July 21, the apex court had asked AIIMS to constitute a medical board to assess Asaram's condition.

The Rajasthan High Court on May 27 upheld the conviction and life sentence awarded to Asaram in a case of rape of a minor in 2013.

On June 30, the apex court sought response from the Rajasthan government on Asaram's plea challenging the high court order.

The high court had upheld Asaram's conviction in the case, but acquitted him of charges related to gangrape and penetrative sexual assault on a child under the erstwhile Indian Penal Code and the Protection of Children from Sexual Offences (POCSO) Act.

However, the high court upheld his conviction under IPC Section 376(2)(F) pertaining to rape of the minor, thereby retaining the sentence of life imprisonment awarded by the trial court.

The high court had also upheld convictions under several other provisions, including Sections 342 (wrongful confinement), 370(4) (trafficking), 506 (criminal intimidation), 509 (insulting the modesty of a woman), 354(A) (sexual harassment) of the IPC, along with Sections 7/8 of the POCSO Act and Section 23 of the Juvenile Justice Act.

Earlier, Asaram was convicted on April 25, 2018, for sexually assaulting a minor student at his ashram and was sentenced to life imprisonment under multiple provisions of the IPC, the POCSO Act, and the Juvenile Justice Act.

FILE PIC

He is serving life sentence in a 2013 case of sexually assaulting a minor

'Eco-tourism': Ladakh to launch India's 1st 'high-altitude' safari

LEH/JAMMU: Ladakh is set to launch India's first high-altitude wildlife safari, with Lieutenant Governor Vinai Kumar Saxena approving guided jeep safaris on snow leopard and birdwatching trails to promote sustainable eco-tourism while making local communities equal partners in wildlife conservation and economic development.

The decision was taken at the first governing body meeting of the newly constituted snow leopard and high-altitude nature (SHAN) conservation society, chaired by the LG, officials said.

Under the initiative, the Forest department has been directed to introduce guided jeep safaris, modelled on those operated in national parks such as Kaziranga and Ranthambore, using specially designed open-back vehicles driven by trained local drivers and guides, they said.

The move aims to curb illegal off-roading and minimise disturbance to wildlife while enhancing visitors' experience through regulated and eco-friendly tourism, they added.

The Forest department has also been asked to identify potential safari routes across Hemis national park, Changthang and Karakoram wildlife sanctuaries, besides wildlife-rich areas such as Nubra, Zanskar, Sham, Kargil and Drass, known for snow leopard sightings and rich birdlife.

As part of the initiative, 20 local youths will be selected and trained in birdwatching, bird identification and bird-spotting skills and equipped with binoculars. Ten birdwatching hides will also be established at major hotspots, they said.

Officials said Ladakh is home to India's largest snow leopard population, with 477 of the country's estimated 718 snow leopards.

The Union Territory also supports over 38 mammal species, around 340 bird species and nearly 1,800 vascular plant species, making it one of the country's most significant biodiversity hotspots. MPOST

L-G Saxena approves guided jeep safaris on snow leopard and birdwatching trails

HSSC calendar coming soon: CM Nayab Saini at 'Chhatra Samvad'

CHANDIGARH: Haryana Chief Minister Nayab Singh Saini on Thursday said the Haryana Staff Selection Commission (HSSC) Annual Recruitment Calendar will be released shortly, reaffirming the government's commitment to making recruitment more transparent, time-bound and candidate-friendly.

Interacting with aspirants during the 'Chhatra Samvad Mukhyamantri Ke Saath' programme in Sonipat, Saini said the calendar would provide advance information on examination schedules, results and other key dates. He added that since some recruitments depend on the retirement of serving employees, these factors are being considered while preparing the calendar.

Addressing concerns over paper leaks and technical glitches in online examinations, the chief minister said both the Centre and the Haryana government have enacted stringent laws to curb such malpractices. He warned that strict action would be taken against anyone attempting to compromise the integrity of the recruitment process.

Responding to queries on the Common Eligibility Test (CET), Saini said it was introduced to spare candidates from appearing in multiple preliminary examinations and to simplify the recruitment process. He added that the government has strengthened transport, security and other logistical arrangements to ensure smooth conduct of examinations. MPOST

Haryana CM Nayab Saini interacts with students in Sonipat

SHIVA project reshaping agri landscape in Himachal

ASHWANI SHARMA

SHIMLA: The Asian Development Bank (ADB)-funded Rs 1,300-crore Himachal Pradesh Subtropical Horticulture, Irrigation and Value Addition (HP SHIVA) project is making steady progress in transforming agriculture across seven mid-Himalayan districts by promoting high-value fruit cultivation, assured irrigation and value addition, Horticulture Minister Jagat Singh Negi said on Thursday.

Reviewing the project's progress, Negi said the initiative is emerging as one of the state's most ambitious rural transformation programmes, aimed at enhancing farmers' incomes by shifting them from low-value crops to subtropical horticulture.

The project covers Bilaspur, Hamirpur, Kangra, Mandi, Solan, Sirmaur and Una districts. Of the 3,000-hectare target under Phase I, around 2,612 hectares have already been developed, while plantations have been completed on 1,543 hectares. Negi said plantations on about 1,000 hectares would be taken up during the ongoing monsoon season, while the remaining area would be covered in January-February 2027 as it involves winter crops such as plum and persimmon. He added that 331 clusters have been finalised under the project, benefiting nearly 10,646 farmer families.

The minister said preparations for Phase II are also underway. Around 2,500 hectares have been identified, with surveys currently in progress over 2,153 hectares. Detailed Project Reports (DPRs) for about 1,200 hectares have already been prepared and submitted to the ADB for technical clearance. The tendering process is expected to begin in the last week of August after the clearance is received.

Negi also reviewed the progress of key civil works, including solar fencing, field preparation, drip irrigation and lift irrigation schemes.

Fans used to dry expressway in UP as monsoon exposes defects

BISWAJEET BANERJEE

LUCKNOW: Barely three weeks after its inauguration, the Rs 4,200-crore Lucknow-Kanpur Expressway has come under scrutiny after heavy monsoon rains exposed potholes, cracks and surface subsidence at several locations, prompting emergency repairs, action against officials and a political row in Uttar Pradesh.

The controversy intensified after videos showing workers using industrial and pedestal fans to dry a waterlogged stretch of the expressway near Begumkheda village in Unnao district went viral on social media. The fans were reportedly used to speed up repair work on the rain-soaked pavement before fresh material was laid, triggering criticism and a flood of memes online.

Samajwadi Party president Akhilesh Yadav attacked the Yogi Adityanath government over the incident, questioning the quality of construction of the newly inaugurated highway. Sharing the viral video on social media, Yadav remarked that an expressway inaugurated with much fanfare was already being repaired and dried with fans. "This is the new wind of BJP's development," he said, alleging poor workmanship and raising concerns over commuter safety.

The 63-km access-controlled expressway was inaugurated on July 13 to reduce travel time between Lucknow and Kanpur. However, the first signs of damage appeared on July 26, when heavy rains led to sinking, surface slippage and erosion on stretches passing through Unnao district.

Repair work has since been underway at multiple locations, with damaged sections being removed and reconstructed using heavy machinery.

The NHAI has initiated action against the contractor, PNC Infratech, over the defects. Three engineers associated with the project have been removed and some site officials replaced.

NHAI has also suspended toll collection on the expressway until repairs are completed and the road is certified fit for traffic. It has decided to seek a technical assessment from IIT Kharagpur to ascertain the reasons behind the damage.

'MOSQUE SURVEY TEAM FACED ATTACK BID'

Mob tried to stop Sambhal survey: Court comm'r

SAMBHAL (UP): A day after the Uttar Pradesh Assembly tabled the judicial commission's report on the November 2024 Sambhal violence, Court Commissioner Ramesh Raghav alleged that the mob had intended to attack the survey team and prevent the court-ordered survey of the Shahi Jama Masjid, while the Hindu side sought a detailed debate on the panel's findings in the Assembly.

The judicial commission, constituted by the Uttar Pradesh government after the violence, concluded that the clashes during the court-ordered survey were the result of a pre-planned conspiracy. It also praised the police and civil administration for preventing the unrest from escalating into wider communal riots across the state and the country.

Raghav, appointed by the civil court as advocate commissioner to conduct the survey, said the first phase on November 19, 2024 lasted around two hours before it was halted because of prayer time and a large gathering. The second phase resumed on November 24 and continued for about two-and-a-half hours.

"I was inside the mosque along with advocates Vishnu Shankar Jain and Vishnu Sharma. During the survey, sounds of firing could be heard from outside," Raghav said. He added that the administration escorted the survey team out through the main gate via the Hindu locality after the exercise. "In my view, the crowd wanted to disrupt the survey and attack the survey team so that the court-ordered exercise could not be completed," he alleged.

Advocate Gopal Sharma, appearing for the Hindu side in the mosque-temple dispute, said the commission's report should be discussed in detail in the Assembly. He said the three-member panel, headed by retired Justice Devendra Kumar Arora, conducted a thorough probe after inspecting the site and recording statements of all stakeholders.

The violence erupted on November 24, 2024, during the second phase of the survey following a petition claiming that the mosque had been built over the site of an ancient Harihar temple. Four people were killed and 28 policemen were injured in the clashes. AGENCIES

FILE PIC

'FOCUS REMAINS ON PUBLIC MOBILISATION, NOT ELECTIONS'

CJP to launch 'Kya Bolti Public' campaign

AIMAN FATIMA

NEW DELHI: The Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) has announced a nationwide public outreach campaign titled 'Kya Bolti Public', aiming to engage citizens directly on issues such as unemployment, education and governance while reiterating that it will continue functioning as a pressure group instead of entering electoral politics.

Addressing a press conference after the party's two-day core committee meeting in Chhatrapati Sambhajinagar, Maharashtra, founder Abhijeet Dipke said the campaign, scheduled to begin next month, will involve interactions with people across the country to understand their concerns and build a broader citizens' movement. "We want to hear directly from people about the issues affecting their lives and their assessment of the current situation in the country. The campaign is meant to bring public concerns to the centre of national discussions,"

Dipke said. Reflecting on the recent student agitation over alleged examination irregularities, Dipke described the resignation of former Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan as a significant outcome of the movement.

"The recent protests have shown people that collective action can lead to accountability. More citizens are now willing to raise their voices on issues that affect them," he said.

Dipke said unemployment and the rising cost of education would remain key priorities for the organisation. He argued that education had become increasingly commercialised and called for reforms to make it more accessible.

"Employment and affordable education are concerns shared by millions of young Indians. These will be among the central issues of our nationwide campaign," he added.

The CJP founder also said the organisation draws inspiration from the ideals of Dr B.R. Ambedkar, Mahatma Gandhi and Jawaharlal Nehru, asserting that its guiding philosophy is rooted in the Constitution.

Reiterating the group's stand on electoral politics, Dipke said the country currently needs "a strong pressure group rather than another political party." He claimed that public trust in several democratic institutions had weakened and said sustained public engagement was necessary to strengthen accountability.

Chief spokesperson Saurav Das dismissed speculation that CJP would register as a political party or contest elections. "We are not forming a political party. At this stage, our role is to function as a pressure group and build public participation on issues that matter," Das said.

The CJP also unveiled its first national leadership structure. Dipke will serve as National Convener, while Saurav Das and Ashutosh Ranka have been appointed Co-Conveners. Ajinkya Shinde was named National Organisation In-charge, Deepak Baliyan Organisation Co-Incharge, and Aafreen Nawaz National Secretary, besides others.

CJP founder Abhijeet Dipke, spokespersons Saurav Das & Ashutosh Ranka, team member Ratna Singh and others during their core team meeting, in Chhatrapati Sambhajinagar on Wednesday PTI

KEY POINTS

- » CJP founder Abhijeet Dipke said the campaign, scheduled to begin next month, will involve interactions with people across the country to understand their concerns
- » Dipke said unemployment and the rising cost of education would remain key priorities

CBI busts tech support scam racket

NARESH BISWANI

NEW DELHI: The Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) has busted an international tech-support fraud and extortion racket operating fake call centres in Punjab and Delhi that allegedly targeted US citizens through online scams and cryptocurrency fraud.

The agency conducted overnight raids at 10 locations in Punjab and Delhi on August 5-6, including the Mohali residence of the alleged kingpin, and arrested four accused -- Sourabh Rana, Indermohan Singh, Harneet Singh and Jappandeep Singh.

According to the CBI, the accused impersonated Microsoft, banks and law enforcement agencies, luring victims through fake pop-up alerts and toll-free numbers. Victims were coerced into paying large sums in cryptocurrency after being falsely warned of computer hacks and child pornography cases.

Searches led to the seizure of cash, crypto-wallets, over 20 mobile phones, 15 laptops/tablets and other digital evidence.

AAP's school reforms put Punjab at 'top spot': Edu Min Bains

MPOST BUREAU

CHANDIGARH: Punjab Education minister Harjot Singh Bains on Thursday said the state has emerged as the top performer in the NITI Aayog School Education Quality Index 2026, overtaking Kerala, attributing the achievement to sweeping reforms introduced by the AAP government.

Participating in a discussion in the Punjab Assembly, Bains said government schools have undergone a major transformation over the past four years. He recalled that when he assumed office in July 2022, over 8,000 schools lacked boundary walls, 3,200 had no functional toilets, and nearly four lakh students sat on the floor. Textbooks, he said, often reached schools only in October or November.

Today, textbooks are distributed before the academic session begins, while infrastructure works worth Rs 2,638 crore have been completed across 19,125 government schools. He added that the state has also secured Rs 1,000 crore in World Bank assistance for further upgrades.

Highlighting improvements in academic performance, Bains said 882 students from government schools qualified NEET-UG 2026, compared to just 80 in 2021, crediting the Punjab Academic Coaching for Excellence (PACE) initiative. He also said Punjab has become the first state to introduce Artificial Intelligence as a core subject from Classes I to XII.

The minister said the government's Mission Samarth programme now covers nearly 12 lakh students with the support of over 70,000 teachers, using level-based teaching to strengthen foundational learning.

HOUTHIS HAVE DECLARED A NAVAL BLOCKADE IN RED SEA

Houthi rebel attacks kill at least 30 Yemeni govt forces: Officials

CAIRO: Attacks by the Iran-backed Houthi rebels Thursday in central and eastern Yemen killed at least 30 government troops and wounded at least 50 others, Yemeni government officials said.

A Houthi leader said Saudi-backed troops were targeted in the attacks and that "hundreds" were either killed or injured.

The assaults hit camps for forces of the internationally recognized government in the provinces of Marib and Hadramout, the Yemeni officials said. They spoke on condition of anonymity because they were not authorised to speak to the media. The attacks were a major escalation since a de facto truce in Yemen in April 2022 that halted major fighting between the Houthis and a Saudi-led coalition, which backs the internationally recognised government. Yemen's army reported publicly only that the Houthi attacks on its camps had left dead and wounded among its troops, but it didn't give a death toll.

REPRESENTATIONAL IMAGE

Houthi Brig Gen Yahya Saree said the attacks on camps in Marib and Hadramout provinces were carried out with ballistic missiles and drones and that they were in response to a build-up of Saudi-backed forces in eastern Yemen.

The strikes killed and injured "hundreds of Saudi enemy mercenaries" and destroyed and burned camps, depots, military vehicles and weapons, the Houthi leader said.

"We call upon all our people to remain vigilant and confront any Saudi aggression, and to strike Saudi troop concentrations wherever they may be," Saree said in his address.

The US mission to Yemen expressed condolences to the families of the killed Yemeni soldiers in Hadramout and Marib, adding in a statement on X that the attacks by the Houthis "represent yet another example of their terrorism against the Yemeni people". Yemen has been embroiled in a civil war since 2014, when the Houthis seized the capital of Sanaa, forcing the internationally recognised government into exile in Saudi Arabia. AGENCIES

Highlights

» A Houthi leader said Saudi-backed troops were targeted in attacks

» The assaults hit camps for forces of the internationally recognized government in the provinces of Marib and Hadramout

» The attacks were a major escalation since a de facto truce in Yemen in April 2022

Ukraine strikes more oil facilities deep inside Russia: Zelenskyy

Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy

KYIV: Ukraine hit more oil facilities deep inside Russia in overnight attacks, President Volodymyr Zelenskyy said Thursday, as Kyiv kept up its campaign to undermine Moscow's wartime economy and embarrass the Kremlin.

The repeated strikes have caused fuel shortages and rattled Russians. Ukrainians, meanwhile, are enduring regular barrages that Kyiv's depleted air defences are struggling to counter amid Moscow's 4-year-old full-scale invasion.

The Kyiv region observed an official day of mourning Thursday after a Russian missile and drone blitz killed 17 people the previous day, prompting an increasingly urgent scramble by Ukraine and its partner countries to find new air defense supplies.

In the first six months of this year, 1,396 civilians were killed and 7,978 injured in Ukraine, the United Nations office in Kyiv said Wednesday. That was a 37 per cent increase from the same period last year and a 114 per cent jump over 2024, it said, attributing the rise to more long-range aerial attacks by Russia.

Zelenskyy said he met with senior officials on how to accelerate the development of Ukraine's own ballistic weaponry, similar to its swift wartime innovation in drone technology.

"Developing one's own ballistic capabilities and creating a new anti-ballistic system is a task that only a tiny minority of countries worldwide have managed to accomplish," he said in a social media post. "Ukraine has this capability."

Zelenskyy said he expects the programme to produce results this year and next after it overcomes "key challenges," including procuring critical components, technological cooperation with partner countries, and choosing where to build the armaments. AGENCIES

Pak PM, Munir to visit Saudi amid Gulf tension

LAHORE: Pakistan Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif and Chief of Defence Forces Field Marshal Asim Munir will undertake a three-day official visit to Saudi Arabia from Thursday as Islamabad seeks to reinforce its strategic partnership with Riyadh against the backdrop of escalating tensions in West Asia.

Pakistan last week said it is "doing its utmost" to bring the US and Iran back to the negotiating table under the Islamabad Memorandum of Understanding signed on June 18.

Sharif, who last visited Saudi Arabia, is leading a high-level delegation for the August 6-8 visit. Apart from Munir, the high-level delegation includes Deputy Prime Minister Ishaq Dar and other federal ministers, the Foreign Office (FO) said in a statement posted on X.

Dar, who is also the Foreign Minister, concluded a visit to Jordan after attending a ministerial meeting on Jerusalem and is already in Saudi Arabia. He will directly join the prime minister's delegation there, the FO said.

"During the visit, the prime minister will meet Crown Prince and Prime Minister of Saudi Arabia Mohammed bin Salman.

Discussions would focus on consolidating the Pakistan-Saudi bilateral relationship and exchange views on areas of regional and international developments of mutual interests," the statement said.

The visit, it said, reflected Pakistan's long-standing partnership with Saudi Arabia, rooted in decades of mutual trust, cooperation and brotherhood. AGENCIES

> 'Apart from Munir, the high-level delegation includes Deputy Prime Minister Ishaq Dar and other federal ministers'

Israeli prosecutors charge settler in West Bank

The rare indictment comes over killing of Palestinian leader Awdah Hathaleen

JERUSALEM: Israeli prosecutors Thursday charged a settler for the killing of a Palestinian community leader last year in the occupied West Bank, according to an indictment filed in district court.

In the document, prosecutors accuse Yinon Levi, who lives in the south of the West Bank, of reckless manslaughter in the death of prominent Palestinian activist Awdah Hathaleen in July 2025. The charge holds a lesser punishment than murder under Israeli law. The indictment also charges Levi with armed trespassing and malicious property damage.

It is extremely rare for Israel to charge settlers with violence against Palestinians. Israeli rights group B'Tselem said that the charges against Levi mark the first time since October 7, 2023 that an Israeli has been indicted for the death of a Palestinian in the West Bank.

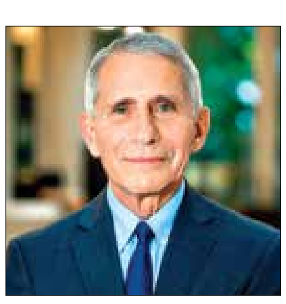
In that time, the group said, Israeli settlers and soldiers have killed at least 1,100 Palestinians in the territory. A lawyer for Levi, Avichay Hajbi, did not confirm whether an indictment was handed down, but told The Associated Press that the prosecution had made a "mistaken decision."

He said the defence would respond to the accusations in court. Levi was shown in video footage shooting at crowds of Palestinians in Hathaleen's village, Umm al-Khair, on the day the activist was killed. Witnesses said one of the shots Levi fired struck Hathaleen, who was standing metres away.

One video showed Levi firing two shots, while another, which family members say was taken by Hathaleen himself, showed Levi firing toward the person holding the camera. AGENCIES

OVER COVID QUESTIONS

Senate committee votes to hold Fauci in contempt



Dr Anthony Fauci

WASHINGTON: A Senate committee on Thursday voted to hold Dr Anthony Fauci in contempt of Congress and refer him to the Justice Department for potential prosecution over his refusal to answer questions at a hearing last week focused on his handling of the COVID-19 pandemic.

The party-line vote approving the contempt resolution came a week after Fauci invoked his Fifth Amendment right against self-incrimination more than 100 times when he appeared before the Senate Committee on Homeland Security and Governmental Affairs. Republican Senator Rand Paul of Kentucky, the committee chairman, said that constitutional protection did not apply since Fauci last year received a pardon from Democratic President Joe Biden and thus did not have to worry about the threat of prosecution.

Fauci and Democrats who opposed the contempt resolution said he had a well-founded fear of self-incrimination given a public desire by Republicans to seek his prosecution.

"Dr Fauci faced no risk of federal prosecution," Paul said at the outset of a hearing. "All he had to do was tell the truth."

Paul noted that the vote had nothing to do with Fauci's policies, opinions or anything he has said in previous congressional appearances.

Instead, the senator said, "We are voting on whether a witness who has received the benefit of a sweeping pardon can be ordered by this committee to answer questions and then defy that order without consequence."

Fauci, in a statement explaining his decision to invoke his Fifth Amendment rights, said he had good reason to fear the possibility of criminal charges given what he said was Paul's determination "to get me to say something, anything, that could vindicate his repeated public pledges that I end up, in his words, quote, behind bars, unquote."

The pardon from Biden covered acts from 2014 through the January 2025 day it was issued.

It does not shield Fauci from state-level prosecutions or from investigations into any testimony that he did give that lawmakers thought was false. AGENCIES

Fire burns 60 hectares in Indonesia's national park

JAKARTA: A fire destroyed 60 hectares (148 acres) of land in the Mount Bromo area in a national park in Java, Indonesia's most populous island, since Monday, officials said on Thursday.

The burning area, equivalent to more than 80 soccer fields, is located within the Bromo Tengger Semeru National Park, one of the most popular tourist destinations in East Java Province.

The National Disaster Management Agency in a written statement said that the terrain has posed a significant challenge to firefighting efforts.

Local authorities have not yet determined the cause of the fire. AGENCIES

B'desh sets presidential election for August 20

DHAKA: Bangladesh's presidential election will be held on August 20, the Election Commission announced on Thursday, two weeks after President Mohammed Shahabuddin resigned on health grounds before completing his five-year term. Shahabuddin, 76, was a longtime ally of deposed prime minister Sheikh Hasina.

"Chief Election Commissioner AMM Nasir Uddin has finalised the dates in consultation with (acting parliamentary) Speaker Kayser Kamal," the Election Commission's senior secretary Akhtar Ahmed told reporters. In line with the Constitution, the parliament members elect the president, but the EC conducts the procedure to elect the head of state.

Announcing the election schedule, Election Commission Secretariat Senior Secretary Akhtar Ahmed said that voting will be held on August 20 from 2:00 pm to 5:00 pm at the Jatiya Sangsad (National Parliament) session hall.

Nomination papers will be accepted at the office of the Chief Election Commissioner on August 13. The scrutiny of nomination papers will be held on August 16. The last date for withdrawal of candidature is August 18.

The lawmakers would cast votes to elect the new president inside Parliament on August 20. However, no voting will be held in case of a consensus candidate. According to the state-run BSS news agency, Ahmed told journalists that the announcement of the presidential election schedule was made after discussions with Parliament Speaker Hafiz Uddin Ahmed, who is serving as Acting President for 90 days in accordance with the Constitution. AGENCIES

Amid din, LS passes Taxation Bill to boost domestic electronic mfg

Through the Taxation & other Laws (Amendment) Bill the govt seeks to attract more foreign capital, promote domestic electronics mfg

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Lok Sabha on Thursday passed the Taxation and other Laws (Amendment) Bill without a debate due to persistent sloganeering by the Opposition over various issues.

After the passage of the bill, through which the government also amended the Payment and Settlement Systems Act, 2007, the House was adjourned for the day.

Through the Bill the government seeks to attract more foreign capital, promote domestic electronics manufacturing and make it easier for foreign cloud companies to use Indian data centres by providing "process certainty".

The Bill also proposes to remove the linkage between the Payment and Settlement Systems Act and the Income Tax Act, and give a legal backing to the government to modify the zero-MDR framework on UPI and RuPay card transactions.

At present, banks and payment-system providers cannot directly or indirectly charge users for payment made through UPI and RuPay debit cards.

The Bill proposes allowing the Central government to decide, through notification, which electronic payment modes or transactions must remain free.

The Taxation and other Laws (Amendment) Bill, 2026, replaces the June 5 ordinance that provided I-T exemption to income from interest income and capital gains made by FPIs from investments in G-Secs.

The Bill proposes to make it easier for fund managers to relocate to India but cutting down on the list of conditions that these funds will have to satisfy to ensure that their global income does not get taxed in India.

To encourage domestic manufacturing by giving policy certainty, the Bill extends till 2040-41 the income tax exemption currently available to foreign companies that engage a contract manufacturer in India for producing electronics goods here.

Specified electronic items mentioned in the bill include mobile phones, laptops, personal computers, tablets, servers and their key parts and accessories.

To support component supply for electronics factories, the Bill proposes I-T exemption for 15 years till 2040-41 to foreign companies that store components in customs warehouses to further supply them to a contract manufacturer in India.

The Bill also removes the approval and notification requirements for foreign cloud companies that use Indian data centres.

It also proposes that Indian data centres be run on a leased basis rather than only under direct ownership.

The proposals in the Bill share a single purpose of making India a more attractive and predictable place for global capital, manufacturing and business to come and stay, Finance Ministry sources said.

When the Chair called RSP Member N K Premachandran to move a statutory resolution disapproving the ordinance, he did not speak.

The Bill was then put to vote and passed by a voice vote without a debate.

This is the seventh bill to be passed by the Lok Sabha in the ongoing Monsoon Session and the fifth one to be passed without a debate.

The House had discussed a bill to amend anti-paper leak law for 10 hours. A bill to make insult to national song 'Vande Mataram' a punishable offence was discussed briefly with two members participating in the debate.

Earlier in the day, Speaker Om Birla had adjourned the House till 2 PM soon after it met due to persistent sloganeering by opposition members.

To encourage domestic manufacturing, the Bill extends till 2040-41 the I-T exemption currently available to foreign companies that engage a contract manufacturer in India for producing electronics goods here

HIGHLIGHTS

- Specified electronic items mentioned in the bill include mobile phones, laptops, PCs, tablets, servers & their key parts, accessories
- To support component supply for electronics factories, the Bill proposes I-T exemption for 15 years till 2040-41 to foreign companies
- The Bill also removes approval & notification requirements for foreign cloud companies that use Indian data centres

Sensex rises 374 pts on buying in Reliance Industries, ICICI Bank

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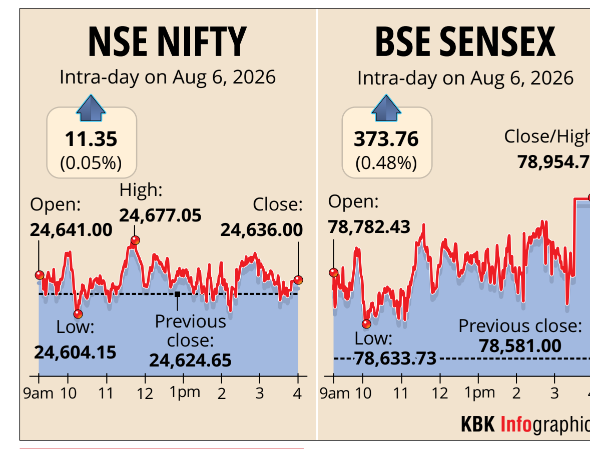


MUMBAI: Benchmark BSE Sensex climbed 374 points on Thursday, drawing support from moderation in crude oil prices and buying in heavyweights Reliance Industries and ICICI Bank.

After trading in the positive territory throughout the day, the 30-share Sensex closed higher by 373.76 points, or 0.48 per cent, at 78,954.76. As many as 11 Sensex components closed higher, 16 with losses and three remained unchanged.

The broader NSE Nifty traded in a narrow range during the day and closed marginally higher by 11.35 points, or 0.05 per cent, at 24,636. During the day, the benchmark hit a high of 24,677.05 and a low of 24,604.15.

Since Monday, both the benchmark indices have been facing divergence after stock exchanges introduced a new auction mechanism for shares having futures and options (F&O) contracts.

From the Sensex pack, Reliance Industries climbed 3.43 per cent, the most among the blue-chip firms. State Bank of India, Bharat Electronics, ICICI Bank, Eternal and Titan were also among the major winners.

Power Grid, Tata Consultancy Services, InterGlobe Aviation and Mahindra & Mahindra were among the laggards.

The Closing Auction Session (CAS) in the equity cash segment became operational on Monday, introducing a new auction-based mechanism for determining the closing prices of eligible stocks in a move aimed at making the price discovery process more transparent and robust.

Broader markets also closed with gains as the BSE SmallCap Select index climbed 0.89 per cent and MidCap Select index edged higher by 0.14 per cent.

Among sectoral indices, PSU Bank jumped 2.13 per cent, followed by Capital Goods (1.29 per cent), Energy (1.14 per cent), MidSmall Private Banks Quality Tilt (0.97 per cent), Bankex (0.86 per cent), Industrials (0.83 per cent) and Top 10 Banks (0.73 per cent). Realty dropped 1.42 per cent, while Services (1.13 per cent), Metal (0.79 per cent), Insurance (0.74 per cent) and Power (0.69 per cent) also closed lower.

In Asian markets, South Korea's KOSPI tanked 4.58 per cent, Hong Kong's Hang Seng index declined 1.49 per cent and Japan's Nikkei 225 ended 0.93 per cent lower. Shanghai's SSE Composite index ended marginally higher.

Markets in Europe were trading higher. US markets ended mostly lower on Wednesday.

Foreign Institutional Investors (FIIs) offloaded equities worth Rs 943.42 crore on Wednesday, according to exchange data.

On Wednesday, the Sensex rose by 152.05 points, or 0.19 per cent, to settle at 78,581. The Nifty edged up 9.75 points, or 0.04 per cent, to end at 24,624.65.

Broader markets also closed with gains as the BSE SmallCap Select index climbed 0.89% and MidCap Select index edged higher by 0.14%

Gold jumps to 7-week high of ₹1.53 lakh/10g

NEW DELHI: Gold prices rallied for the third straight session, soaring by Rs 3,800 to a seven-week high of Rs 1.53 lakh per 10 grams in the national capital on Thursday, aided by rupee depreciation and firm global trends.

The yellow metal of 99.9 per cent purity climbed Rs 3,800 to Rs 1,53,800 per 10 grams (inclusive of all taxes) from Wednesday's closing level of Rs 1,50,000 per 10 grams.

Gold had last settled near these levels at Rs 1,53,440 per 10 grams on June 18.

Silver also advanced Rs 2,100 to Rs 2,34,800 per kilogram (inclusive of all taxes) from Rs 2,32,700 per kg in the preceding session.

Traders said a weaker rupee made imported bullion costlier in the domestic market, while gains in overseas gold prices amid a softer US dollar and easing Treasury yields lent further support to the precious metals.

Gold extended its rally for a third consecutive session, climbing to a seven-week high as a weaker dollar, softer US Treasury bond yields and expectations of a diplomatic breakthrough in West Asia conflict have boosted demand for precious metal, Gaurav Garg, Head of Research at Lemonn Markets Desk, said.

In the overseas markets, spot gold edged higher to USD 4,264.24 per ounce, while silver traded lower at 61.80 per ounce. PTI

RS clears Appropriation (No.3) Bill for excess spending in fiscal 2023

NEW DELHI: The Rajya Sabha on Thursday cleared the Appropriation (No.3) Bill, 2026, which seeks to provide for the authorisation of appropriation of moneys out of the Consolidated Fund of India to meet the amounts spent on certain services during the financial year ended on March 31, 2023, in excess of the amounts granted.

Replying to the debate on the Bill, Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman said, "This is the demand for excess grant for expenditures undertaken in the year 2023 on just two accounts. These two accounts were a part of what the Public Accounts Committee in its 39th report presented to the Lok Sabha this year in April".

Explaining further, she said one excess demand arises from a particular court order that was on the Railway Ministry for Rs 196.44 crore. The second demand pertains to a larger amount of Rs 53,871 crore pertaining to the repayment of debt.

However, Sitharaman said the nature of debt receipts is against the issuance of securities and therefore has no fiscal impact.

The Bill was returned to the Lok Sabha after the Upper House gave its nod to the legislation with a voice vote, thus completing the Parliamentary process for the Money Bill. PTI

Cabinet clears ₹23,731 crore national biogas scheme to boost clean fuel production

NEW DELHI: The Union cabinet on Thursday approved a Rs 23,731-crore national scheme to accelerate production of compressed biogas (CBG), betting on agricultural and municipal waste to reduce dependence on imported fossil fuels and strengthen the country's clean energy transition.

The GOBARdhan (Galvanising Organic Bio-Agro Resources Dhan) scheme, to be implemented between fiscal years 2027 and 2036, seeks to increase domestic compressed biogas production nearly tenfold through assured offtake, administered pricing, capital subsidies, pipeline infrastructure and easier access to finance, the government said.

The programme, with a total outlay of Rs 23,731 crore, will involve the use of agricultural residue, cattle dung, sugar industry waste such as press mud, municipal organic waste and other biomass to produce compressed biogas, which can be blended into CNG used in automobiles.

The scheme builds on existing initiatives, including the Sustainable Alternative Towards Affordable Transportation (SATAT) programme, under which more than 200 compressed biogas plants have already been commissioned, according to the government.

As part of the new framework, city gas distribution companies will procure compressed biogas to meet mandatory blending obligations of 3 per cent in fiscal 2027, 4 per cent in fiscal 2028 and 5 per cent from fiscal 2029 onwards for compressed natural gas used in transport and piped natural gas supplied to households.

The government has also introduced an administered price of Rs 2,110 per million British thermal units (MMBTU) for compressed biogas under a framework designed to provide producers with long-term revenue certainty while keeping consumer prices affordable.

Eligible greenfield projects will receive capital assistance of up to Rs 2 crore per tonne per day of installed compressed biogas capacity, while brownfield expansion projects will also qualify for support.

The scheme also provides funding for pipeline infrastructure linking compressed biogas plants with trunk pipelines and city gas distribution networks, a credit guarantee mechanism for eligible micro, small and medium enterprises, and a dedicated challenge fund to support feedstock aggregation, technology adoption and district-level project development.

The government said the programme is expected to spur private investment, create additional income opportunities for farmers and rural entrepreneurs, improve management of agricultural and municipal waste, expand production of organic manure and lower greenhouse gas emissions.

India has been expanding the use of natural gas as part of its energy transition strategy while seeking to reduce its reliance on imported liquefied natural gas through greater domestic production of renewable gaseous fuels such as compressed biogas. PTI

Rupee falls 14 paise to 95.22 against dollar

MUMBAI: The rupee depreciated 14 paise to close at 95.22 against the US dollar on Thursday, on slight gains in the US Dollar Index and a modest increase in US Treasury yields.

Forex traders said the rupee was pressured by a slight recovery in the US Dollar Index and foreign fund outflows, even as lower crude oil prices provided some underlying support.

At the interbank foreign exchange, the rupee opened at 95.13 against the greenback and traded in a range of 95.12-95.24 during the session.

It eventually settled at 95.22, lower by 14 paise from its previous close.

On Wednesday, the rupee gained 20 paise to settle at 95.08 against the US dollar.

"Indian Rupee declined today on a slight bounce in the US Dollar index and modest gains in the US treasury yields. However, weak crude oil prices and hopes of a deal between the US and Iran prevented a sharp fall," said Anuj Choudhary, Research Analyst, Mirae Asset ShareKhan.

Choudhary further said that the rupee is likely to trade with a slight positive bias on a rise in risk appetite in global markets amid hopes of a deal between the US and Iran.

Meanwhile, the dollar index, which gauges the greenback's strength against a basket of six currencies, was trading at 99.78, down 0.11 per cent. PTI

POWERGRID posts Q1 net profit of ₹3,598 cr, total income of ₹11,697 cr

NEW DELHI: State-owned Power Grid Corporation of India (POWERGRID) has reported consolidated net profit of Rs 3,598.42 crore in Q1 FY27.

The consolidated net profit was at Rs 3,630.58 crore in Q1 FY26, the company said in a regulatory filing.

The company's total income, however, rose to Rs 11,696.72 crore in the quarter from Rs 11,444.42 crore in the same period a year ago.

In another exchange filing on Wednesday, Power Grid Corporation of India said it has approved a Rs 856.94 crore project on August 5, 2026, to upgrade the Tirunelveli – Udumalpet and Pugalur–Madurai 400kV double-circuit lines with high-temperature low-sag (HTLS) conductors.

The project is set for completion within 24 months by February 11, 2028.

In the April-June quarter, the company incurred a capital expenditure of Rs 7,765 crore and capitalized assets worth Rs 5,277 crore (excluding FERV and including assets capitalized as finance lease) on consolidated basis during Q1FY27.

Power Grid's gross fixed assets on consolidated basis stood at Rs 3,25,671 crore (including Gross Lease Receivables) as on June 30, 2026.

At the end of Q1FY27, the total transmission assets of the company and its subsidiaries stood at 1,86,595 ckm of transmission lines, 291 substations and 6,34,516 MVA of transformation capacity. It maintained average transmission system availability of 99.80 per cent during Q1FY27.

During Q1FY27, the company secured a JPY 80 billion loan from the Japan Bank for International Cooperation (JBIC) to finance the landmark Khavda-Nagpur HVDC Transmission Project. MPOST

POWERGRID Chairman & MD Vamsi Rama Mohan Burra

GOBARdhan package can unlock CBG sector growth, says IFGE DG

NEW DELHI: Sanjay Ganjoo, Director General of the Indian Federation of Green Energy (IFGE), on Thursday said the government's Rs 23,731 crore GOBARdhan package has the potential to do for India's biogas sector what the Production Linked Incentive (PLI) Scheme did for solar manufacturing by transforming policy intent into bankable projects.

Ganjoo said India's challenge has never been feedstock availability, noting that the country generates nearly 500 million tonnes of agricultural residue annually, much of which is still burned in fields, contributing to severe air pollution. He said the real bottlenecks have been assured offtake, stable pricing, evacuation infrastructure and efficient feedstock aggregation.

He pointed out that only about 216 Compressed Biogas (CBG) plants have been commissioned against the country's ambitious CBG blending targets, with project viability constrained by inadequate synchronization between CBG production and City Gas Distribution (CGD) networks.

According to him, by supporting both production and distribution infrastructure, the government has addressed the sector's most critical challenges.

Ganjoo said assured offtake and pipeline connectivity would improve project bankability, enhance investor confidence and provide lenders with the long-term revenue visibility required to finance projects.

He added that organized procurement of paddy straw, press mud and other biomass would strengthen farmer participation and create reliable rural value chains. He further said beyond clean energy, every CBG plant would stimulate local economic activity through feedstock collection, transportation, plant operations and organic manure management, generating sustainable employment and additional income for rural communities.

Combined with reduced dependence on imported natural gas and enhanced energy security, the GOBARdhan Scheme represents the long-awaited inflection point for India's Compressed Biogas sector, he added. MPOST

PhonePe launches FD marketplace, daily recurring deposit with Shivalik SFB

'Daily RD allows users to invest between Rs 100-1K/day via UPI Autopay'

BENGALURU: PhonePe has entered the fixed deposit distribution business, partnering with banks and non-banking financial companies (NBFCs) to enable users to compare and book deposits through its app.

The company has also launched a digital Daily Recurring Deposit (RD) product in partnership with Shivalik Small Finance Bank, allowing users to invest Rs 100-1,000 daily through UPI Autopay, it said.

PhonePe's FD marketplace enables users to discover, compare and book deposits from partner institutions through a fully digital, paperless process. Users can invest across multiple banks and NBFCs and manage their deposits on a single platform. Deposits booked with partner banks are insured up to Rs 5 lakh by the Deposit Insurance and Credit Guarantee Corporation (DICGC), as per RBI norms. The Daily RD product aims to promote small-ticket automated savings through daily contributions. Users can withdraw funds after seven days or stop the UPI Autopay mandate anytime, while a 15-day grace period is provided for missed payments.

"At PhonePe, our vision is to empower every Indian to accelerate their financial progress by unlocking seamless access to financial services. The launch of our Fixed Deposit distribution, along with the Daily RD product, marks a significant milestone in that direction. Fixed Deposits remain a cornerstone of Indian household savings, offering guaranteed returns. By turning a traditionally offline process into a seamless, 100 per cent digital journey, with the ability to interoperably invest using any bank account on the UPI rails, we are making these savings instruments accessible to the heart of Bharat with absolute confidence, capital safety, and convenience," said Deep Agrawal, Vice President & Head of Payments at PhonePe. MPOST

'India & South Africa discuss early conclusion of trade pacts, deepen critical minerals co-op'

NEW DELHI: Union Commerce and Industry Minister Piyush Goyal held bilateral discussions with South Africa's Minister of Trade, Industry and Competition, Parks Tau to enhance economic ties.

Posting on his social media platform X on Thursday, Goyal noted that the meeting focused on deepening trade relations and identifying collaborative ventures in manufacturing, pharmaceuticals, and critical minerals. The meeting was held on the sidelines of the BRICS Trade Ministers' Meeting, with both sides discussing the signing of the Terms of Reference (ToRs) for the India-Southern African Customs Union (SACU) Preferential Trade Agreement (PTA) and the early conclusion of negotiations.

"Met with Mr. Parks Tau, Minister of Trade, Industry and Competition of South Africa, on the sidelines of the #BRICS2026 Trade Ministers' Meeting. We discussed the signing of ToRs for India-SACU PTA and early conclusion of negotiations, strengthening the India-South Africa trade engagement and explored opportunities for cooperation in the critical minerals, pharmaceuticals & manufacturing sectors," Goyal said.

The meeting comes as India hosts the BRICS Trade Ministers' Meeting in Jaipur under its BRICS India 2026 Presidency. According to the Department of Commerce, the meeting brings together BRICS nations to strengthen trade and economic cooperation, foster innovation, build resilient value chains and promote sustainable industrial growth.

A previous brief by the Ministry of External Affairs mentioned that India and South Africa maintain a strategic partnership spanning trade, investment, defence, science and technology, education and cooperation through multilateral forums such as BRICS and IBSA. The brief also noted that the SACU Secretariat in Namibia had shared the Terms of Reference with the Department of Commerce. ANI

Union Commerce and Industry Minister Piyush Goyal

'TATA SONS PENDING DEREGISTRATION PLEA UNAFFECTED'

RBI includes Tata Sons, 16 others in large NBFC list

OUR CORRESPONDENT

'Inclusion of Tata Sons in the list is without prejudice to the outcome of its application for deregistration'

HIGHLIGHTS

» Tata Sons, the holding company of the $400-billion Tata Group, was first classified as an upper-layer NBFC in 2022

» Unlike traditional NBFCs, Tata Sons operates as a CIC, with its primary business being the investment holder in Tata group companies

MUMBAI: The RBI on Thursday retained Tata Sons on its list of upper-layer non-banking financial companies (NBFCs), saying the holding company's inclusion would not affect its pending application to surrender its NBFC registration.

The RBI published its latest list of 17 upper-layer NBFCs under its Scale-Based Regulation framework, which subjects systemically important non-bank lenders and core investment companies to enhanced regulatory oversight. "Inclusion of Tata Sons Pvt Ltd in the list is without prejudice to the outcome of its application for deregistration, which is under examination," the RBI said.

Tata Sons, the holding company of the $400-billion Tata Group, was first classified as an upper-layer NBFC in 2022.

The designation meant Tata Sons would have had to comply with stricter regulations, including eventually listing on stock exchanges and meeting tighter governance, capital and disclosure requirements, unless it restructured. In response, Tata Sons took steps to reduce its exposure to financial businesses and reorganise parts of the group. It also sought exemption from the RBI classification. It has also took steps to reduce borrowings and reorganise parts of its financial services business, including separating financial operations from its core investment activities.

Unlike traditional NBFCs, Tata Sons operates as a Core Investment Company (CIC), with its primary business being the holding of investments in Tata group companies rather than lending. It owns significant stakes in listed companies, including Tata Consultancy Services, Tata Motors, Titan Company andIndian Hotels Company Ltd (IHCL), and derives a substantial portion of its income from dividends paid by those businesses.

The RBI's upper-layer category comprises non-bank financial companies and core investment companies considered systemically important because of their size, complexity and interconnectedness with the financial system. Entities in the category are subject to tighter governance, capital and disclosure requirements than other NBFCs.

The RBI did not provide a timeline for deciding on Tata Sons' application to surrender its NBFC registration. Besides Tata Sons, the other firms on the list include infrastructure finance companies REC, Power Finance Corporation, Indian Railway Finance Corporation and Housing and Urban Development Corporation, deposit-taking NBFCs Bajaj Finance and Shriram Finance company LIC Housing Finance.

Non-deposit taking NBFCs Tata Capital & Cholamandalam Investment and Finance are also on the list, and so is Muthoot Finance, Aditiya Birla Capital, L&T Finance, Bajaj Housing Finance, HBD Financial Services Ltd & Piramal Finance Ltd.

The RBI classifies NBFCs into four layers based on their size, activity and potential risk to the financial system. Base Layer (NBFC-BL) comprises smaller NBFCs with simpler operations. Middle Layer (NBFC-ML) has larger NBFCs such as investment and credit companies, housing finance companies, infrastructure finance companies and microfinance institutions.

Upper Layer (NBFC-UL) consists of systemically important NBFCs that are subject to stricter regulatory oversight, similar in many respects to banks. Top Layer (NBFC-TL) is a largely empty category reserved for NBFCs that the RBI believes pose exceptionally high systemic risk and therefore require even tighter regulation.

Parl panel pushes for greater accountability in petroleum sector amid declining crude output

SIMONTINI BHATTACHARJEE

'It was pointed out that the Centre accepted 27 out of 28 recommendations made by the committee'

NEW DELHI: The Committee on Public Undertakings (COPU) has sought enhanced coordination between major public investments in the petroleum sector and progress in domestic energy generation, and has urged the government to fast-track the country's shift to more environmentally friendly energy sources.

The Thirty-Sixth Report of the committee placed before Parliament on Thursday assessed the measures taken by the Ministry of Petroleum & Natural Gas (MoPNG) regarding the action taken on its previous recommendations relating to the working and performance of central public sector undertakings (CPSUs) in the petroleum and natural gas sector.

Headed by BJP Member of Parliament Baijayant Panda, the committee evaluated the performance of major public sector enterprises, including Indian Oil Corporation Ltd (IOC), Bharat Petroleum Corporation Limited (BPCL), Hindustan Petroleum Corporation Limited (HPCL), Oil and Natural Gas Corporation (ONGC), Oil India Limited (OIL), GAIL, Engineers India Limited (EIL) and Balmer Lawrie. It was pointed out that the government at the centre accepted 27 out of 28 recommendations made by the committee, while one of the recommendations was still pending for final approval.

The main focus of the committee's concerns is the apparent disconnect between increasing capital expenditure and falling domestic crude oil output.

According to the report, capital expenditure in the sector rose steadily from Rs 1.33 lakh crore in 2020-21 to a projected Rs 1.70 lakh crore in 2024-25. However, crude oil production declined from 34.20 million metric tonnes (MMT) in 2018-19 to an estimated 28.70 MMT in 2024-25.

The committee further attributed the trend to several factors, including ageing oil fields, lengthy exploration cycles, the natural depletion of reserves and disruptions caused by the Covid-19 pandemic. Nevertheless, members stressed that measurable performance benchmarks, stronger accountability mechanisms and a greater emphasis on enhanced oil recovery technologies and accelerated field development must accompany substantial investments.

It was further stressed that these enterprises continue to play a crucial role in India's effort to secure its energy requirements while fulfilling its international commitments on the environment front. The report highlighted many of the geopolitical risks faced by the energy sector. It was pointed out that India imports about 89 per cent of its crude oil requirements and thus is exposed to disturbances due to any conflict, sanctions and political instability of major oil producers.

The Russia-Ukraine War, instability in West Asia, and disturbances in the maritime route are considered threats to the Indian energy security framework.

The ministry also referred to various reforms which have taken place in recent times like the Hydrocarbon Exploration and Licensing Policy (HELP), Open Acreage Licensing Policy (OALP), almost one million square kilometres of offshore "No-Go" area releases and more seismic surveys for attracting new investments in the exploration sector. Besides, the committee examined the progress of large-scale infrastructure projects and emphasised the need to enhance monitoring systems so as to avoid any kind of delay and increase in the cost of the project.

The ministry informed the committee that an inter-ministerial committee has been set up to monitor these projects and that these monitoring mechanisms have been incorporated into Pragati, PM Gati Shakti and Pariyojana digital platforms.

In addition, the expansion of the National Gas Grid was an issue of focus in the report. The committee pointed out that over 3,851 kilometres of gas pipelines had already been completed whereas another 3,189 kilometres were being developed. Though it recognised the measures taken to solve land acquisition and regulatory issues, the panel focused on the necessity of better coordination between the centre, states, and local authorities to ensure timely completion of important energy projects.

Nonetheless, the committee praised the government for its decision to diversify its sources of imports and highlighted how India now sources its crude oil from over 41 nations worldwide. In addition to this, the committee welcomed the creation of strategic petroleum reserves with an oil storage capacity of 5.33 million metric tonnes in Visakhapatnam, Mangaluru, and Padur. Besides this, the Indian public sector companies have acquired interests in 45 foreign oil and gas assets in 21 countries.

Coal India emerges preferred bidder for Gadadharpur iron ore block in Odisha

NEW DELHI: State-owned CIL on Thursday said it has emerged as the preferred bidder for the Gadadharpur iron ore block in Odisha, marking the country's largest coal miner's foray into iron ore mining.

Coal India Ltd (CIL) is mainly engaged in mining and production of coal and accounts for over 80 per cent of domestic output of the dry fuel.

The move further signals the company's broader diversification plan amid a long-term energy transition.

The mining lease has been awarded on an auction premium of 114.05 per cent of the value of mineral dispatched.

CIL's entry into iron ore mining aligns with the government's push to boost domestic production of critical minerals and secure raw material supply chains for the steel sector, which is central to the country's infrastructure and manufacturing ambitions.

The block is at the G3 exploration stage with a total resource estimated at 288 million tonnes, CIL said in a filing to the BSE. A G3 exploration stage block is a mineral mining area undergoing preliminary exploration. PTI

LIC posts 23% rise in net profit to ₹13,492 cr in June qtr

NEW DELHI: Life Insurance Corporation of India (LIC) on Thursday posted a 23 per cent rise in net profit to Rs 13,492 crore in the first quarter of the ongoing financial year, helped by an increase in new business.

The country's biggest insurer had earned a profit of Rs 10,987 crore in the corresponding quarter a year earlier.

The total income of the insurer during the reporting quarter improved to Rs 2,37,848 crore from Rs 2,22,864 crore in the same period of the preceding fiscal year, LIC said in a regulatory filing.

Commenting on quarterly numbers, CEO & MD R Doraiswamy said the total premium income in the June quarter was Rs 1,27,250 crore as compared to Rs 1,19,200 crore in the corresponding quarter of the previous year, registering a growth of 6.75 per cent.

"What gives us even more happiness is that our Value of New Business (VNB) has grown by 61 per cent plus and our VNB margin has expanded by 7.5 per cent to 22.90 per cent this year. This is a direct outcome of our product diversification and distribution strategy," he said.

Just very recently, the Government of India sold an additional 6.5 per cent of shares through an offer for sale (OFS), which has been well received by the markets, he said.

"I want to welcome the new shareholders through the OFS into the LIC shareholder family and also thank the existing shareholders who have participated in the OFS for their continued faith in LIC," he said.

Asked about further stake dilution by the government to meet 25 per cent public float, Doraiswamy said, "What we are hearing, the government is unlikely to go in for a public offer in the next 18-24 months as LIC has time till 2032 for meeting the Minimum Public Shareholding (MPS) norm of Sebi." PTI

THIS IS A PUBLIC ANNOUNCEMENT FOR INFORMATION PURPOSES ONLY. THIS IS NOT A PROSPECTUS ANNOUNCEMENT AND DOES NOT CONSTITUTE AN INVITATION OR OFFER TO ACQUIRE, PURCHASE OR SUBSCRIBE TO SECURITIES. NOT FOR RELEASE, PUBLICATION OR DISTRIBUTION, DIRECTLY OR INDIRECTLY, OUTSIDE INDIA. THE EQUITY SHARES OF THE COMPANY WILL GET LISTED ON MAIN BOARD PLATFORM OF BSE LIMITED ("BSE") AND NATIONAL STOCK EXCHANGE OF INDIA LIMITED ("NSE, AND TOGETHER WITH BSE, THE "STOCK EXCHANGES") IN COMPLIANCE WITH CHAPTER II OF THE SECURTIES AND EXCHANGE BOARD OF INDIA (ISSUE OF CAPITAL AND DISCLOSURE REQUIREMENTS) REGULATIONS, 2018, AS AMENDED ("SEBI ICDR REGULATIONS")

TECHNOCRAFT VENTURES LIMITED

TECHNOCRAFT VENTURES LIMITED

(To be listed on the main board of BSE and NSE)

Our Company was originally incorporated as a private limited company under the name "Technocraft Construction Private Limited" under the Companies Act, 1956, pursuant to a certificate of incorporation dated October 21, 1998, issued by the Registrar of Companies, NCT of Delhi and Haryana. Thereafter, the name of our Company was changed from 'Technocraft Construction Private Limited' to 'Technocraft Ventures Private Limited' pursuant to a board resolution dated January 08, 2024, and a special resolution passed by our shareholders dated January 10, 2024, and a fresh certificate of incorporation dated February 09, 2024, was issued pursuant to change of name, by the Registrar of Companies, Delhi. Subsequently, our Company was converted into a public limited company pursuant to a resolution passed by our Board of Directors dated February 16, 2024, and a special resolution passed by our shareholders on March 13, 2024. Consequently, the name of our Company was changed to 'Technocraft Ventures Limited', and a fresh certificate of incorporation was issued to our company by the Registrar of Companies, Central Processing Centre, on June 11, 2024. For further details, kindly refer "Our History and Certain Corporate Matters - Brief History of our Company" beginning on page 328 of the Red Herring Prospectus ("RHP").

(Please scan this QR Code to view the Red Herring Prospectus)

CIN : U70101DL1998PLC096763 **Registered Office:** S 553/54, Ground Floor, School Block, Shakarpur, New Delhi-110092, India; **Corporate Office:** B-137, Sector-2 Noida, Gautam Buddha Nagar, Uttar Pradesh-201301, India;
Contact Person: Shefali Kesarwani, Company Secretary and Compliance Officer; **Tel.:** +91 9211252228; **E-mail:** compliance@technocraftventures.com; **Website:** www.technocraftventures.com

PROMOTERS OF OUR COMPANY: SANJAY TYAGI, REKHA TYAGI, KARTIKEY TYAGI, KARTIKEY CONSTRUCTIONS (PARTNERSHIP FIRM) AND SANJAY TYAGI HUF

INITIAL PUBLIC OFFERING OF UP TO 11,881,000 EQUITY SHARES OF FACE VALUE OF ₹ 10 EACH ("EQUITY SHARES") OF TECHNOCRAFT VENTURES LIMITED ("OUR COMPANY" OR THE "ISSUER") FOR CASH AT A PRICE OF ₹ [●] PER EQUITY SHARE ("OFFER PRICE") (INCLUDING A PREMIUM OF ₹ [●] PER EQUITY SHARE) AGGREGATING UP TO ₹ [●] MILLION (THE "OFFER"). THE OFFER COMPRISES OF A FRESH ISSUE OF UP TO 9,505,000 EQUITY SHARES OF FACE VALUE OF ₹ 10 EACH AGGREGATING UP TO ₹ [●] MILLION BY OUR COMPANY (THE "FRESH ISSUE") AND AN OFFER FOR SALE OF UP TO 2,376,000 EQUITY SHARES BY KARTIKEY CONSTRUCTIONS (PARTNERSHIP FIRM) (THE "PROMOTER SELLING SHAREHOLDER") AND REFERRED TO AS, THE "SELLING SHAREHOLDER" (THE "OFFER FOR SALE"). THE OFFER WOULD CONSTITUTE [●]% OF OUR POST-OFFER PAID-UP EQUITY SHARE CAPITAL.

DETAILS OF THE OFFER FOR SALE

NAME OF THE PROMOTER SELLING SHAREHOLDER	TYPE	NUMBER OF EQUITY SHARES OFFERED/AMOUNT	WEIGHTED AVERAGE COST OF ACQUISITION PER EQUITY SHARE OF FACE VALUE OF ₹ 10 EACH (IN ₹)*
Kartikey Constructions (Partnership Firm)	Promoter Selling Shareholder	Up to 2,376,000 Equity Shares of face value of ₹ 10 each aggregating up to ₹ [●] million	2.50

*As certified by Rishi Kapoor & Company, Chartered Accountants, pursuant to their certificate dated July 10, 2026 vide UDIN: 26455362QBCRCF4855.
For further details, kindly refer "The Offer" beginning on page 87 of the RHP.

PRICE BAND: ₹ 200 TO ₹ 212 PER EQUITY SHARE OF FACE VALUE OF ₹ 10 EACH.
THE FLOOR PRICE IS 20 TIMES OF THE FACE VALUE OF THE EQUITY SHARES AND
THE CAP PRICE IS 21.20 TIMES OF THE FACE VALUE OF THE EQUITY SHARES.
BIDS CAN BE MADE FOR A MINIMUM QUANTITY OF 70 EQUITY SHARES OF FACE VALUE OF ₹ 10 EACH AND
IN MULTIPLES OF 70 EQUITY SHARES OF FACE VALUE OF ₹ 10 EACH THEREAFTER.

THE PRICE TO EARNINGS RATIO ("P/E"), BASED ON DILUTED EPS FOR FINANCIAL YEAR ENDED 2026
FOR OUR COMPANY AT THE LOWER END OF PRICE BAND IS 13.90 TIMES AND AT THE UPPER END OF PRICE BAND IS 14.73 TIMES.
WEIGHTED AVERAGE RETURN ON NET WORTH FOR LAST THREE FINANCIAL YEARS IS 24.55%.

The details of the Fresh Issue, Offer for Sale, Total Offer Size and Post-Offer Market Capitalization of our Company, each at the Floor Price and Cap Price, are given below:

Particulars	At Floor Price of ₹ 200 per Equity Share		At Cap Price of ₹ 212 per Equity Share	
	Up to No. of Equity Shares of face value of ₹10 each	Up to Amount (₹ in million)	Up to No. of Equity Shares of face value of ₹ 10 each	Up to Amount (₹ in million)
Fresh Issue	9,505,000	1,901.00	9,505,000	2,015.06
Offer For Sale	2,376,000	475.20	2,376,000	503.71
Total Offer Size	11,881,000	2,376.20	11,881,000	2,518.77
Post-Offer Market Capitalization of our Company	39,606,200	7,921.24	39,606,200	8,396.51

BID / OFFER PROGRAMME	BID / OFFER OPENS TODAY
	BID / OFFER CLOSES ON TUESDAY, AUGUST 11, 2026^

^ The UPI mandate end time and date shall be at 5:00 pm on Bid/ Offer Closing Date.

Our Company is a multidisciplinary public infrastructure development company engaged in the execution of turnkey Engineering, Procurement and Construction ("EPC") contracts.

THE OFFER IS BEING MADE THROUGH THE BOOK BUILDING PROCESS IN ACCORDANCE WITH REGULATION 6(1) OF THE SEBI (ISSUE OF CAPITAL AND DISCLOSURE REQUIREMENTS) REGULATIONS, 2018 AS AMENDED.
THE EQUITY SHARES OF THE COMPANY WILL GET LISTED ON THE MAIN BOARD OF BSE & NSE. BSE LIMITED SHALL BE THE DESIGNATED STOCK EXCHANGE.

QIB PORTION: NOT MORE THAN 50% OF THE OFFER
NON-INSTITUTIONAL PORTION: NOT LESS THAN 15% OF THE OFFER
RETAIL PORTION: NOT LESS THAN 35% OF THE OFFER

IN MAKING INVESTMENT DECISION, POTENTIAL INVESTORS MUST ONLY RELY ON THE INFORMATION INCLUDED IN THE RHP AND THE TERMS OF THE OFFER, INCLUDING THE RISKS INVOLVED AND NOT RELY ON ANY OTHER EXTERNAL SOURCES OF INFORMATION ABOUT THE OFFER AVAILABLE IN ANY MANNER. IN RELATION TO PRICE BAND, POTENTIAL INVESTORS SHOULD ONLY REFER TO THIS PRICE BAND ADVERTISEMENT FOR THE OFFER AND SHOULD NOT RELY ON ANY MEDIA ARTICLES/ REPORTS IN RELATION TO THE VALUATION OF THE COMPANY AS THESE ARE NOT ENDORSED, PUBLISHED OR CONFIRMED BY EITHER THE COMPANY OR THE BOOK RUNNING LEAD MANAGER TO THE OFFER ("BRLM").

In accordance with the recommendation of a committee of Independent Directors of our Company, pursuant to their resolution dated August 01, 2026, the above provided price band is justified based on quantitative factors/key performance indicators ("KPIs") disclosed in the "Basis for Offer Price" section beginning on page 150 of the RHP vis-a-vis the weighted average cost of acquisition ("WACA") of primary and secondary transaction(s), as applicable, as disclosed in the "Basis for Offer Price" section beginning on page 150 of the RHP and provided below in this advertisement.

RISK TO INVESTORS

For details, kindly refer to the section titled "Risk Factors" beginning on page 33 of the RHP.

1. **Business Concentration Risk:** We have generated 85.44%, 80.22% and 90.91% of our revenue from operations for the financial year ended on March 31, 2026, March 31, 2025 and March 31, 2024 , respectively, from Water & Wastewater Infrastructure work. We are a multidisciplinary public infrastructure development company engaged in the execution of turnkey Engineering, Procurement and Construction (**"EPC"**) contracts. We operate across various infrastructure segments, including Water & Wastewater Infrastructure such as Water Supply Scheme Projects (**"WSSPs"**), Sewerage Networks, Sewerage Treatment Plants (**"STPs"**), Wastewater Treatment Plants (**"WWTPs"**), Transmission mains, Reservoirs, Trenchless & Micro tunnelling Works, Roads and Highways work, Electrical Transmission work, Urban Infrastructure which includes sector-level planning and execution of residential building projects and Operation and Maintenance (**"O&M"**) of public utilities.
   The business segment wise bifurcation of revenue for the financial year ended March 31, 2026, March 31, 2025 and March 31, 2024 are as below:

(₹ in million)

Particulars	For the Financial Year ended					
	March 31, 2026		March 31, 2025		March 31, 2024	
	Amount	% of revenue from operations	Amount	% of revenue from operations	Amount	% of revenue from operations
Sale of Services						
Water & Wastewater Infrastructure work	2,947.64	85.44	2,242.61	80.22	2,055.48	90.91
Roads and Highways work	444.04	12.87	20.38	0.73	-	0.00
Urban Infrastructure work	-	-	248.38	8.88	-	0.00
Electrical Transmission work	-	-	210.30	7.52	-	0.00
Operation & Maintenance work	57.71	1.67	24.50	0.88	13.79	0.61
Other Operating Revenues						
Sale of Material	0.57	0.02	49.47	1.77	191.75	8.48
Total	**3,449.96**	**100.00**	**2,795.64**	**100.00**	**2,261.02**	**100.00**

As certified by Rishi Kapoor & Company, Chartered Accountants pursuant to their certificate dated July 10, 2026 vide UDIN: 26455362TEEDWY3049.

2. **Revenue Concentration Risk:** A substantial portion of our revenues is derived from contracts awarded by Central and State Governments, local authorities under Government-led schemes such as the Atal Mission for Rejuvenation and Urban Transformation ("AMRUT"), Jal Jeevan Mission ("JJM"), Namami Gange and Pradhan Mantri Gram Sadak Yojana ("PMGSY"). Our order book is therefore highly dependent on Government budgetary allocations and policy priorities. Any reduction or reallocation in public spending, delay in issuance of tenders, change in pre-qualification norms, or cancellation of awarded projects could materially reduce our pipeline of opportunities.
   The table below sets forth our revenue from Government & Government authorities and from Private clients for the financial years ended March 31, 2026, March 31, 2025 and March 31, 2024 indicated:

(₹ in million)

Particulars	For the financial year ended		
	March 31, 2026	March 31, 2025	March 31, 2024
Revenue from Government	3,449.39	2,274.52	1,741.50
% of Revenue from Operations	99.98	81.36	77.02
Revenue from Private Sector	0.57	521.12	519.52
% of Revenue from Operations	0.02	18.64	22.98
Total	**3,449.96**	**2,795.64**	**2,261.02**

As certified by Rishi Kapoor & Company, Chartered Accountants pursuant to their certificate dated July 10, 2026 vide UDIN: 26455362MFNQNB9135.

Our Company may face execution risks, including delays in approvals, resource mobilisation, site challenges, adverse weather, land acquisition issues, labour shortages, and supply chain disruptions in future. Our Company may not be able to successfully bid for and/or procure government orders in the future. Any inability to secure such orders, or a reduction in the number or value of government contracts awarded to our Company, could adversely affect our revenue, financial condition and results of operations.

3. **Geographical Concentration Risk:** Our Company's project portfolio is geographically concentrated, with a significant presence in Uttar Pradesh and Rajasthan. Our Company's geographic concentration in Uttar Pradesh and Rajasthan exposes it to risks such as regional slowdowns in infrastructure spending, changes in state policies or political conditions, limited geographic diversification, challenges in competing for large national projects due to a regional market perception, and constraints on efficiently expanding and clustering projects across other states.
   Following are the state wise bifurcation of revenue for the financial year ended March 31, 2026, March 31, 2025 and March 31, 2024:

(₹ in million)

Sr. No.	Name of the States	For the Financial Year ended March 31,					
		2026		2025		2024	
		Revenue from Operations	% of Revenue from Operations	Revenue from Operations	% of Revenue from Operations	Revenue from Operations	% of Revenue from Operations
1.	Uttar Pradesh	881.00	25.53	756.39	27.06	1,382.72	61.15
2.	Rajasthan	2,175.25	63.05	1,665.42	59.58	730.64	32.31
3.	Delhi	355.21	10.30	163.53	5.85	147.66	6.54
4.	Uttarakhand	-	-	210.30	7.52	-	-
5.	Madhya Pradesh	38.50	1.12	-	-	-	-
	Total	**3,449.96**	**100.00**	**2,795.64**	**100.00**	**2,261.02**	**100.00**

As certified by Rishi Kapoor & Company, Chartered Accountants pursuant to their certificate dated July 10, 2026 vide UDIN: 26455362LGVDOP3135.

4. **Ability to qualify and bid for Government tenders:** Our Company relies on competitive government tenders to secure infrastructure projects across sectors such as water, wastewater, power, roads, microtunneling and urban infrastructure. Its ability to win contracts depends on meeting technical and financial eligibility criteria, which may change over time. Delays, cancellations, or unsuccessful bids can result in wasted bid preparation costs and reduced business opportunities. Our success ratio, in case of solo bids submitted by our Company, is 36.11% for the period ended on July 15, 2026 and last three financial years. Even after winning a contract, delays in project awards or commencement can lead to underutilized labour and equipment, increasing costs and reducing profitability.
   The table below sets forth details of the cumulative bids submitted by us and the corresponding conversion metrics for the period ended July 15, 2026 and for the financial years ended March 31, 2026, March 31, 2025 and March 31, 2024 indicated:

Particulars	Solo bid by the Company	Bid as a Lead Partner	Bid as a Joint Venture Partner
Bids submitted	56	9	6
Less: Cancelled/ Awaited/ Pending Result	20	1	3
Net bids submitted	36	8	3
Awarded	13	6	0
Successful Conversion of Bids (in %)	36.11	75.00	0.00

Continued on next page...

...continued from previous page.

5. **Financial Risks:**
A substantial portion of our revenues is derived from contracts awarded by Central and State Governments. The execution of large infrastructure projects involves high working capital requirements, and any shortfall or delay in the availability of working capital may adversely affect our project execution, business and financial condition, cash flows and results of operations. Further, our business requires significant working capital investment, which constitutes trade receivables and inventories together form a substantial part of our non-cash current assets, constituting 79.50%, 72.93% and 74.59% of total non-cash current assets as of March 31, 2026, March 31, 2025 and March 31, 2024, respectively.
Risk related to Working Capital Requirement Risk
Our operations across infrastructure segments, including water and wastewater projects, roads, electrical networks, and civil construction are inherently working capital intensive due to significant upfront expenses in procurement, mobilization, and project execution. As per our restated consolidated financial Information, our working capital requirements for the financial year ended March 31, 2026, March 31, 2025 and March 31, 2024 amounted to ₹ 1,338.16 million, ₹1,400.09 million and ₹ 1,280.66 million, respectively. Further, our working capital requirements for Financial Year 2027 are estimated at ₹ 2,909.29 million out of which an amount of ₹1,500.00 million will be funded out of the Net Proceeds from issue of fresh equity shares in financial year 2027, whereas the balance, if any, would be arranged from our internal accruals and/or borrowings. For details of our working capital requirements and estimation, kindly refer "Objects of the Offer" beginning on page 136 of the RHP.
Risk related to Trade Receivables & Trade Payables
As majority of our revenue is generated through the government tenders so our Company's trade receivables constitute only receivables from Governments:

(₹ in million)

Particulars	For the financial year ended		
	March 31, 2026	March 31, 2025	March 31, 2024
Trade Receivables	1,179.76	581.84	1,001.83
Revenue from operations	3,449.96	2,795.64	2,261.02
Trade Receivables as % of revenue from operations	34.20	0.81	44.31

The increase in our trade receivables as at March 31, 2026 was primarily attributable to the timing of billing during Fiscal 2026, with approximately 40% of our revenue from operations of ₹ 3,449.96 million being billed during the fourth quarter while approximately 56% was billed during the third and fourth quarters combined. Consequently, a substantial portion of the invoices remained outstanding as at the fiscal year-end, resulting in trade receivables of ₹ 1,179.76 million, of which ₹ 1,131.08 million were outstanding for less than six months.
Risk related to Contingent Liabilities:
Our contingent liabilities and commitments (as per Ind AS 37), derived from the Restated Consolidated Financial Information is ₹99.79 million and the following bank guarantees have been provided against the works:

(₹ in million)

GUARANTEES			
Particulars	As at		
	March 31, 2026	March 31, 2025	March 31, 2024
A) Bank Guarantees	1,680.33	1,113.16	792.27
Total	**1,680.33**	**1,113.16**	**792.27**

For further details, kindly refer "Restated Consolidated Financial Information - Annexure 46 - Contingent Liabilities and Commitments" beginning on page 438 of the RHP.

If a significant portion of these liabilities materialize, it could have an effect on our results of operations and financial condition. Further, there can be no assurance that we will not incur similar or increased levels of contingent liabilities in the future.

6. **Risk of seasonality of operations of the Company**
Our business operations may be affected by seasonal factors which may restrict our ability to carry on activities related to our construction projects, laying of water pipes and fully utilize our resources.
The following factors may restrict our ability:
➢ Heavy or sustained rainfalls
➢ Flood
➢ Cyclones or
➢ Other extreme weather conditions
The above could result in delays or disruptions to our operations during the critical periods of our projects and cause severe damages to our premises and equipment's. In particular, the monsoon season may adversely affect our ability to carry on activities related to our projects and efficiently utilize our resources, resulting in a slowdown in construction projects. This may lead to delays in project execution and consequently defer the recognition of revenue and profits to subsequent quarters. Adverse seasonal developments may also necessitate the evacuation of personnel, suspension or curtailment of operations, damage to construction sites or delays in the delivery of materials. Such fluctuations may adversely affect our revenues, cash flows, results of operations and financial conditions.

7. **Orders in our order book may be delayed, truncated, modified, or cancelled, and may not translate into confirmed orders**
As on July 15, 2026, our Order Book includes 14 EPC projects across water & wastewater treatment infrastructure work and roads and highways work with an aggregate unexecuted contract value of ₹ 13,054.45 million and 5 Operations and Maintenance (O&M) projects aggregating ₹ 152.87 million. Our Order Book represents the unexecuted value of ongoing and newly awarded contracts. It is compiled based on internal estimates and is unaudited. The methodology used by our Company may differ from industry practices and should not be construed as a guaranteed measure of future revenue or profitability. The realization of income from our Order Book is subject to various factors including but not limited to project approvals, site conditions, contractual timelines and changes in project scope or specifications by the client.

(₹ in million)

Sr. No.	Particulars	FY 2025-26	FY 2024-25	FY 2023-24
1.	Opening balance of Order Book	7,688.20	7,528.80	3,243.20
2.	Add: New orders awarded during the year	8,156.60	2,752.00	5,729.10
3.	Less: Sales booked*	3,449.96	2,798.40	2,262.10
4.	Add/less: Variation/Reduction	35.87	205.80	818.60
5.	Closing Order Book	12,358.97	7,688.20	7,528.80

**Revenue from operations as per audited standalone statement of profit & loss.*

8. **Outstanding Legal Proceeding:** There are proceedings pending at different levels of adjudication before various courts, enquiry officers and appellate forums involving our Company, Directors, Promoters and Senior Managerial Personnel (SMPs). Such proceedings could divert management's time, attention and consume financial resources in their defense. Further, an adverse judgment in some of these proceedings could have an adverse impact on our business, financial condition, and result of operations
9. **Regulatory Risk:** The company is unable to trace certain historical corporate records and RoC filings, and some statutory filings contain incomplete or inaccurate disclosures that have not been revised. Under the circumstances elaborated above, our Company cannot assure you that the filings were made in a timely manner, or the information gathered through other available documents of our Company are correct. Also, our Company may not be in a position to attend to and / or respond appropriately to any legal matters pertaining to such period and relating to such documents which have been lost and to that extent the same may adversely affect our business operations.
10. The average cost of acquisition of Equity Shares for the Promoter Selling Shareholder is ₹2.50 and offer price at upper end of the price band is ₹212.
11. Weighted average cost of acquisition (WACA) of Equity Shares by our Promoters (including the Promoter Selling Shareholder):

Particulars	Number of Equity Shares of face value of ₹ 10 each	WACA of Equity Shares of face value of ₹ 10 per Equity Share acquired in last 18 months (in ₹)	WACA of Equity Shares of face value of ₹10 per Equity Share acquired in last 1 year (in ₹)	WACA of Equity Shares of face value of ₹ 10 per Equity Share acquired in last 3 years (in ₹)
Sanjay Tyagi	1,212,000	0.10	Nil	0.10
Rekha Tyagi	395,200	Nil	Nil	Nil
Kartikey Tyagi	600,000	Nil	Nil	Nil
Sanjay Tyagi HUF	2,114,200	Nil	Nil	Nil
Kartikey Constructions^	24,990,000	Nil	Nil	Nil

As certified by the Rishi Kapoor & Company, Chartered Accountant pursuant to their certificate dated July 10, 2026.
^Also the Promoter Selling Shareholder.
Note: Weighted average cost of acquisition of all equity shares during last one year, 18 months and three years has been calculated after considering the shares allotted by way of bonus issue and gift.

12. Weighted average cost of acquisition of all Equity Shares transacted by our Promoters (including Promoter Selling Shareholder) and members of the Promoter Group in last 1 year, 18 months and 3 years immediately preceding from the date of RHP is as follows:

Period	Weighted Average Cost of Acquisition of Equity Shares (in ₹)	Cap price is 1.74 times the Weighted Average Cost of Acquisition	Range of acquisition price: Lowest Price-Highest Price (in ₹)
Last 1 year	Nil	Nil	Nil
Last 18 months	121.76	1.74	121.76-121.76
Last 3 years	121.76	1.74	121.76-121.76

As certified by the Rishi Kapoor & Company, Chartered Accountant pursuant to their certificate dated July 10, 2026.
Note: Weighted average cost of acquisition of all equity shares during last one year, 18 months and three years has been calculated without considering the shares allotted by way of bonus issue and gift.

13. Weighted Average Return on Net Worth for last three financial years is 24.55%.
14. Weighted average cost of acquisition for all the shares transacted in the last one year, 18 months and 3 years preceding the date of the Red Herring Prospectus is given in point 11 above.
15. The Price/Earnings ratio based on diluted EPS for Fiscal 2026 for our Company at the upper end of the Price band is 14.73 times as compared to the average industry peer group PE ratio of 24.73 times.
16. The BRLM associated with the Offer i.e., Khambatta Securities Limited has handled 11 public issues (2 main board IPOs & 9 SME IPOs) in the past three years preceding the date of RHP, out of which 3 SME IPOs closed below issue price on listing date.
Investors are advised to read the risk factors carefully before taking an investment decision in the Offer. For detail kindly refer "Risk Factors" beginning on page 33 of the RHP.

Investors are advised to read the risk factors carefully before taking an investment decision in the Offer. For detail kindly refer "Risk Factors" beginning on page 33 of the RHP.

ADDITIONAL INFORMATION FOR INVESTORS

1. The Company has not undertaken a pre-IPO placement.
2. The Promoter Selling Shareholder or members of the Promoter Group have not undertaken any transaction of Equity Shares aggregating up to 1% or more of the Paid-up Equity Share Capital of the Company from the date of Draft Red Herring Prospectus till date.
3. The aggregate Pre-offer and Post-offer shareholding of the Promoters, members of the Promoter Group and the additional top 10 Shareholders of the Company is set out below:

Sr. No.	Name of the Shareholders	Pre-Offer shareholding as on the date of the Red Herring Prospectus		Post-Offer shareholding as on the date of Allotment(1)			
				At the lower end of the price band (₹ 200)		At the upper end of the price band (₹ 212)	
		Number of Equity Shares of face value of ₹ 10 each held	Shareholding (in %)	Number of Equity Shares of face value of ₹ 10 each held	Share-holding (in %)	Number of Equity Shares of face value of ₹ 10 each held	Shareholding (in %)
Promoters							
1	Sanjay Tyagi	1,212,000	4.03	1,212,000	3.06	1,212,000	3.06
2	Rekha Tyagi	395,200	1.31	395,200	1.00	395,200	1.00
3	Kartikey Tyagi	600,000	1.99	600,000	1.51	600,000	1.51
4	Kartikey Constructions (Partnership Firm)*	24,990,000	83.02	22,614,000	57.10	22,614,000	57.10
5	Sanjay Tyagi HUF	2,114,200	7.02	2,114,200	5.34	2,114,200	5.34
Promoter Group *(who hold shares)*							
1.	Vartika Tyagi	429,800	1.43	429,800	1.09	429,800	1.09
2.	Technocraft Developers Private Limited	360,000	1.20	360,000	0.91	360,000	0.91
Additional top 10 Public Shareholders							
Nil							
Other Public Shareholders							
Nil							
Total (aggregate)		**30,101,200**	**100.00**	**27,725,200**	**70.00**	**27,725,200**	**70.00**

** Also Promoter Selling Shareholder*
Notes:
1) Assuming full subscription in the Offer (fresh issue and offer for sale). The post-Offer shareholding details, as at allotment, will be based on the actual subscription and the final Offer Price and updated in the Prospectus, subject to finalization of the basis of allotment. Also, this table assumes there is no transfer of shares by these shareholders between the date of the advertisement and allotment (if any such transfers occur prior to the date of Prospectus, it will be updated in the shareholding pattern in the Prospectus).
2) Based on the Offer price of ₹ [●] and subject to finalization of the basis of allotment.

BASIS FOR OFFER PRICE

The *"Basis for Offer Price"* beginning on page 150 of the RHP has been updated with the above. Please refer to the websites of the BRLM: www.khambattasecurities.com for the "Basis for Offer Price" updated with the above price band.
You may scan the QR code for accessing the website of Khambatta Securities Limited.

The Price Band has been determined by our Company in consultation with the BRLM, and the Offer Price shall also be determined by our Company in consultation with the BRLM, on the basis of assessment of market demand for the Equity Shares offered through the Book Building Process and quantitative and qualitative factors as described below. The face value of the Equity Shares is ₹10 each and the Floor Price is 20 times the face value and the cap price is 21.20 times the face value.

Bidders should read the below mentioned information along with *"Risk Factors", "Our Business", "Restated Consolidated Financial Information"* and *"Management's Discussion and Analysis of Financial Conditions and Results of Operations"* beginning on pages 33, 249, 364 and 486, respectively, of the RHP, to have an informed view before making an investment decision.

Qualitative Factors
Some of the qualitative factors and our strengths which form the basis for computing the Offer Price are on page 289 of the RHP.

Quantitative Factors
Certain information presented below relating to our Company is derived from the Restated Consolidated Financial Information. For details, please refer to the chapter titled "Restated Consolidated Financial Information" beginning on page 364 of the RHP.
Some of the quantitative factors which may form the basis for calculating the Offer Price are as follows:

1. **Basic and diluted earnings per Equity Share ("EPS"):**

For the Financial Year ended	Basic (in ₹)	Diluted (in ₹)	Weight
March 31, 2026	14.39	14.39	3
March 31, 2025	9.37	9.37	2
March 31, 2024	6.33	6.33	1
Weighted Average	11.37		

Notes:
i) Weighted average = Aggregate of financial year-wise weighted EPS divided by the aggregate of weights i.e. (EPS x Weight) for each financial year/Total of weights The face value of equity shares of the Company is ₹10 each.
ii) Basic Earnings per Equity Share (₹) = In accordance with the Ind AS 33, Basis earnings per share is calculated by dividing the restated profit or loss for the financial year by the weighted average number of Equity Shares outstanding during the financial year after considering the adjustment of bonus shares issued subsequent to financial year end.
iii) Diluted Earnings per Equity Share (₹) = In accordance with the Ind AS 33, Diluted earnings per share is calculated by dividing the restated profit or loss for the financial year by the weighted average number of Equity Shares outstanding during the financial year after considering the adjustment of bonus shares issued subsequent to financial year end and as adjusted for the effects of all dilutive potential Equity Shares during the financial year. The above statement should be read with significant accounting policies and notes on Restated Consolidated Financial Information.

2. **Price/Earning ("P/E") ratio in relation to the Price Band of ₹ 200 to ₹ 212 per Equity Share:**

Particulars	P/E at the Floor Price (no. of times)	P/E at the Cap Price (no. of times)
Based on Basic EPS for the Financial Year ended March 31, 2026	13.90	14.73
Based on Diluted EPS for the Financial Year ended March 31, 2026	13.90	14.73

3. **Industry Peer Group P/E ratio**
Based on the peer group information (excluding our Company), details of the highest, lowest and industry average P/E ratio are set forth below:

Particulars	P/E Ratio
Highest	31.96
Lowest	14.81
Average	22.96

Note:
i. The highest and lowest industry P/E shown above is based on the peers set out in item no. 6 of this section.
ii. The industry average has been calculated as the arithmetic average P/E of the industry peers disclosed under item no. 6 of this section.
iii. P/E Ratio has been computed based on the closing market price of equity shares as at July 21, 2026 / Diluted EPS as on March 31, 2026.

4. **Return on Net worth ("RoNW")**

For the Financial Year ended	RoNW* (%)	Weight
March 31, 2026	26.51	3
March 31, 2025	23.51	2
March 31, 2024	20.76	1
Weighted Average**	24.55	

Notes:
**Return on net worth is calculated as restated profit/(loss) for the financial year divided by net worth. Net Worth is aggregate value of the paid up share capital and all reserves created out of the profits and securities premium account and debit or credit balance of profit and loss account, after deducting the aggregate value of the accumulated losses, deferred expenditure and miscellaneous expenditure not written off, but does not include reserves created out of revaluation of assets/fair value gain, write back of depreciation and amalgamation, in accordance with Regulation 2(1)(hh) of the SEBI ICDR Regulations.*
***Weighted Average: Aggregate of financial year wise weighted RoNW, divided by the aggregate of weights, i.e. (RoNW*Weights) for each financial year/Total of weights.*

5. **Net Asset Value per Equity Share ("NAV")**

As at	Consolidated (in ₹)
March 31, 2026	54.28
March 31, 2025	39.86
March 31, 2024	30.49
After the completion of the Offer	
- At the Floor Price	89.25
- At the Cap Price	92.13
Offer Price*	[●]

** Offer Price per Equity Share will be determined on conclusion of the Book Building Process.*
Notes:
i) NAV means Net asset value (NAV) per share is computed as the closing net worth divided by number of equity shares outstanding at the end of the financial year, as adjusted for bonus issue of Equity Shares.
ii) Net Worth is aggregate value of the paid up share capital and all reserves created out of the profits and securities premium account and debit or credit balance of profit and loss account, after deducting the aggregate value of the accumulated losses, deferred expenditure and miscellaneous expenditure not written off, but does not include reserves created out of revaluation of assets/fair value gain, write back of depreciation and amalgamation, in accordance with Regulation 2(1)(hh) of the SEBI ICDR Regulations.

6. **Comparison of Accounting Ratios with listed industry peers**
Set forth below is a comparison of our accounting ratios with our listed peer companies listed in India, for Fiscal 2026:

Name of the Company	Face Value (₹ per share)	Revenue from Operations for Fiscal 2026 (₹ in million)	EPS for Fiscal 2026 (₹per share)		NAV (₹ per share)	P/E Ratio	RoNW (%) Fiscal 2026
			Basic	Diluted			
Technocraft Ventures Limited*	10	3,449.96	14.39	14.39	54.28	[●]**	26.51
Peer Group							
EMS Limited	10	7,327.47	16.30	16.30	190.57	24.30	8.62
VA Tech Wabag Limited	2	39,442.00	59.51	58.72	415.11	31.96	14.37
Enviro Infra Engineers Limited	10	11,455.96	10.42	10.41	7.05	20.76	15.22
Denta Water and Infra Solutions Limited	10	2,503.79	22.81	22.81	171.91	14.81	13.27

Continued on next page...

...continued from previous page.

**The financial information for our Company is based on the Restated Consolidated Financial Information.*
***To be included in respect of our Company in the Prospectus, based on the Offer Price.*
Source: All the financial information for listed industry peers mentioned above is on a Consolidated basis and is sourced from the annual results submitted to stock exchanges and posted on their websites.
(1) Basic EPS and Diluted EPS refer to the Basic EPS and Diluted EPS sourced from the financial statements of the respective company.
(2) P/E Ratio has been computed based on closing price as at July 29, 2026 / Diluted EPS as on March 31, 2026.
(3) Net asset value (NAV) per share is computed as the closing net worth divided by number of equity shares outstanding at the end of financial year, as adjusted for bonus issue of Equity Shares.
(4) Return on Net Worth calculated as restated profit for the financial year divided by Net Worth.
(5) "Net worth" means the aggregate value of the paid-up share capital and all reserves created out of the profits and securities premium account and debit or credit balance of profit and loss account, after deducting the aggregate value of the accumulated losses, deferred expenditure and miscellaneous expenditure not written off, as per the restated consolidated financial information, but does not include reserves created out of revaluation of assets, write- back of depreciation and amalgamation, capital reserve on consolidation and foreign currency translation reserve.

7. Comparison of Key Performance Indicators with listed industry peers

Set forth below is a comparison of our KPIs with our peer companies listed in India:

For the Financial Year ended March 31, 2026

(₹ in million, unless otherwise indicated)

Key Financial Indicators	Technocraft Ventures Limited	EMS Limited	VA Tech Wabag Limited	Enviro Infra Engineers Limited	Denta Water and Infra Solutions Limited
Revenue from Operations	3,449.96	7,327.47	39,442.00	11,455.96	2,503.79
Total Income	3,469.98	7,450.01	40,385.00	11,879.70	2,595.73
EBITDA (₹)	721.75	1,526.77	5,677.00	3,104.32	834.87
EBITDA Margin (%)	20.92	20.84	14.39	27.10	33.34
PAT	433.15	911.94	3,698.00	1,883.85	609.00
PAT Margin (%)	12.56	12.45	9.38	16.44	24.32
Operating Cash Flows	286.95	(149.04)	2,067.00	(630.92)	(344.95)
Net Worth	1,633.76	10,582.77	25,737.00	12,374.28	4,589.91
Net Debt	766.64	1,370.02	(5,567.00)	3,703.33	(144.78)
Debt- Equity Ratio (times)	0.55	0.15	0.09	0.34	0.03
Return on Equity (%)	26.51	8.62	14.37	15.22	13.27
Return on Capital Employed (%)	27.72	11.75	20.04	17.21	17.61

As certified by Rishi Kapoor & Company, Chartered Accountants pursuant to their certificate dated July 10, 2026 vide UDIN: 26455362NHPDQM8185.
Notes:
(1) Revenue from operation means revenue from sales and other operating revenues.
(2) Total Income represents the total turnover of our business i.e. Revenue from Operations and Other Income, if any.
(3) EBITDA is calculated as restated profit/(loss) before tax plus finance costs, depreciation and amortization expenses.
(4) EBITDA Margin is calculated as EBITDA divided by Revenue from Operations.
(5) PAT Margin is calculated as restated profit/(loss) for the financial year divided by Revenue from Operations.
(6) Net Worth is aggregate value of the paid up share capital and all reserves created out of the profits and securities premium account and debit or credit balance of profit and loss account, after deducting the aggregate value of the accumulated losses, deferred expenditure and miscellaneous expenditure not written off, but does not include reserves created out of revaluation of assets/fair value gain, write back of depreciation and amalgamation, in accordance with Regulation 2(1)(hh) of the SEBI ICDR Regulations.
(7) Net debt = non-current borrowing (including lease liability) + current borrowing (including lease liability) – Cash and Cash Equivalent.
(8) Debt equity ratio means ratio of total debt (long term plus short-term including current maturity of long-term debt) and Equity Share capital plus other equity (including minority interest).
(9) ROE is calculated as Profit for the financial year, divided by total shareholder's equity (including minority interest).
(10) ROCE is calculated as EBIT (i.e. restated profit/(loss) before tax plus finance costs) divided by capital employed (i.e. sum of:(i) Total shareholder's Equity (including minority interest); (ii) Long-Term Borrowings (including Lease Liabilities, if any); (iii) Short-Term Borrowings (including Lease Liability, if any).

8. Details of our Operational KPIs

(₹ in million, unless otherwise indicated)

KPI	For the Financial Year ended*		
	March 31, 2026	March 31, 2025	March 31, 2024
No. of Sewage Treatment Plant (STP) Projects Completed**1	Nil	1	Nil
No. of Govt. Projects Completed	6	2	2
Order Book (in numbers)	18	19	11
Order Book (in value)	12,358.97	7,688.20	7,528.80
Tender Participation and Success Ratio[2]	36.36%	41.67%	54.55%
EPC Volume under Government Schemes	12,358.97	7,688.20	7,528.80

**The Operational KPIs have been certified by Y.P.& Associates, Chartered Engineer vide certificate dated July 21, 2026, bearing certificate no. YP004/OPERATIONAL KPI'S/TECHNOCRAFT.*
***Since our inception, we completed and commissioned Wastewater Treatment projects, including high capacity STPs of capacity 56 MLD and 40 MLD based on SBR technology and a 3 MLD STP based on UASB technology.*
[1] STP Projects take 2-3 years for completion ,3 projects are undergoing.
*[2] Successful Conversion of Bids (in %) = (Bids awarded / Net Bids Submitted) *100.*

9. Weighted average cost of acquisition ("WACA").
Weighted average cost of acquisition based on Primary Issuances and Secondary Transactions

a) Price per share of the Company (as adjusted for bonus issuance) based on primary issuances of Equity Shares or convertible securities (excluding Equity Shares issued under ESOP Plan and issuance of Equity Shares pursuant to a bonus issue) during the 18 months preceding the date of the Red Herring Prospectus, where such issuances is equal to or more than 5% of the fully diluted paid-up share capital of the Company in a single transaction or multiple transactions combined together over a span of rolling 30 days ("Primary Issuances")

There have been no primary/new offer of shares (Equity Shares/convertible securities), excluding grants of any options and issuance of bonus shares, equal to or more than 5% of the fully diluted paid-up share capital of our Company (calculated on the pre-issue capital before such transactions and excluding employee stock options granted but not vested), in a single transaction or multiple transactions (combined together over a span of rolling 30 days) during 18 months preceding the date of the Red Herring Prospectus.

b) Price per share of the Company (as adjusted for bonus issuance) based on secondary sales or acquisitions of Equity Shares or convertible securities (excluding gifts) where Promoters or members of the Promoter group or other shareholders with rights to nominate directors are a party to the transaction during the 18 months preceding the date of the Red Herring Prospectus, where the acquisitions or sale is equal to or more than 5% of the fully diluted paid-up share capital of the Company (calculated on the pre-issue capital before such transactions and excluding employee stock options granted but not vested), in a single transaction or multiple transactions combined together over a span of rolling 30 days ("Secondary Transactions").

There have been no Secondary Transactions, where Promoters or members of the Promoter group or other shareholders with rights to nominate directors are a party to the transaction (excluding gifts), during the 18 months preceding the date of the Red Herring Prospectus, where either acquisition or sale is equal to or more than 5% of the fully diluted paid-up share capital of the Company (calculated on the pre-issue capital before such transactions and excluding employee stock options granted but not vested), in a single transaction or multiple transactions combined together over a span of rolling 30 days.

c) Since there are no such transactions to report under (a) and (b) above, the details basis the last five primary and secondary transactions (secondary transactions where Promoters or members of the Promoter group or other shareholders with rights to nominate directors are a party to the transaction) during the three years preceding the date of the Red Herring Prospectus, irrespective of the size of transactions, is as below:

Primary Transactions:

Sr. No.	Date of Allotment	Nature of Specified Securities	No. of Specified Security Allocated	Face Value per Share (in ₹)	Adjusted no. of shares Allotted at Face Value of ₹ 10 each	Issue per share (in ₹)	Nature of Allotment	Nature of Consideration	Total Consideration (₹ in million)
1	May 29, 2025	Equity	22,575,900	10	Nil	Nil	Bonus Issue in the ratio of 3:1	Other than cash	Nil

As certified by Rishi Kapoor & Company, Chartered Accountants pursuant to their certificate dated July 10, 2026 vide UDIN: 26455362QBCRCF4855.
 # The Primary Transactions includes Bonus Issue.

Secondary Transactions

Sr. No	Date of Allotment	Name of Transferee	Name of Transferor	Name of Transaction	Number of Equity Shares Transferred	Face Value per Share (in ₹)	Adjusted no. of Shares allotted of Face Value ₹10 each	Transfer Price per share (in ₹)	Total consideration in (₹ in million)
1.	March 24, 2025	Sanjay Tyagi	M/S Neeraj Tyagi HUF	Cash	750	10	Nil	121.76	0.09

As certified by Rishi Kapoor & Company, Chartered Accountants pursuant to their certificate dated July 10, 2026 vide UDIN: 26455362QBCRCF4855.

d) Weighted average cost of acquisition ("WACA"), floor price and cap price

Based on the disclosures in (a), (b) and (c) above, the weighted average cost of acquisition of the securities with the Floor Price and the Cap rice is set forth below:

Past transactions	Weighted average cost of acquisition after Bonus shares adjustments (₹ per Equity Share)	Floor Price (i.e., ₹ 200)	Cap Price (i.e., ₹212)
Weighted average cost of acquisition of Primary Issuances as per paragraph (a) above.	N/A	N/A	N/A
Weighted average cost of acquisition of Secondary Transactions as per paragraph (b) above.	N/A	N/A	N/A
Weighted average cost of acquisition of Primary Issuances/ Secondary transactions as per paragraph (c) above.	–	–	–
-Based on Primary issuances	Nil	Nil	Nil
-Based on secondary transactions	121.76	1.64	1.74

As certified by Rishi Kapoor & Company, Chartered Accountants pursuant to their certificate dated July 10, 2026 vide UDIN: 26455362QBCRCF4855.

10. Justification for Basis for the Offer Price

Explanation for Cap Price along with our Company's key performance indicators and financial ratios Fiscals 2026, 2025 and 2024 and in view of the external factors which may have influenced the pricing of the Offer:

i. Diversified EPC Capabilities across Core Infrastructure Sectors.
ii. Execution of High Value Government and Multilateral Funded Projects.
iii. Regulatory Approved Electrical EPC Capabilities with Statewide Licenses.
iv. Strong order book of ₹ 13,207.32 Million as on July 15, 2026.
v. Promoter - Led Business with Strong Execution Capabilities
vi. Consistent Revenue Growth and Strengthening Profitability

11. The Offer Price is [●] times of the face value of the Equity Shares

The Offer Price of ₹ [●] has been determined by our Company in consultation with the BRLM, on the basis of the demand from investors for the Equity Shares through the Book Building Process. Our Company, in consultation with the BRLM, are justified of the Offer Price in view of the above qualitative and quantitative parameters.

Investors should read the above-mentioned information along with *"Risk Factors", "Our Business", "Restated Consolidated Financial Information"* and *"Management Discussion and Analysis of Financial Conditions and Results of Operations"* beginning on pages 33, 249, 364 and 486, respectively, of the RHP to have a more informed view. The trading price of the Equity Shares could decline due to the factors mentioned in the section *"Risk Factors"* beginning on page 33 of the RHP and any other factors that may arise in the future and you may lose all or part of your investment.

INDICATIVE TIMELINE IN RESPECT OF THE OFFER IS SET OUT BELOW:

Bid/Offer Programme

Event	Indicative Date
ANCHOR INVESTOR BIDDING DATE	Thursday, August 06, 2026
BID/OFFER OPENS ON	Friday, August 07, 2026
BID/OFFER CLOSES ON*^	Tuesday, August 11, 2026
Finalisation of Basis of Allotment with the Designated Stock Exchange	On or about Wednesday, August 12, 2026
Initiation of refunds (if any, for Anchor Investors) /unblocking of funds from ASBA Account*	On or about Thursday, August 13, 2026
Credit of Equity Shares to demat accounts of Allottees	On or about Thursday, August 13, 2026
Commencement of trading of the Equity Shares on the Stock Exchanges	On or about Friday, August 14, 2026

** Our Company in consultation with the BRLM, may consider closing the Bid/ Offer Period for QIBs one Working Day prior to the Bid/ Offer Closing Date in accordance with the SEBI ICDR Regulations.*
^ UPI mandate end time and date shall be at 5:00 pm on Bid/ Offer Closing Date
** In case of any delay in unblocking of amounts in the ASBA Accounts (including amounts blocked through the UPI Mechanism) exceeding 2 Working Days from the Bid/ Offer Closing Date, the Bidder shall be compensated at a uniform rate of ₹100 per day or 15% per annum of the Bid Amount, whichever is higher, for the entire duration of delay exceeding two Working Days from the Bid/Offer Closing Date by the intermediary responsible for causing such delay in unblocking in accordance with applicable law. The BRLM shall, in their sole discretion, identify and fix the liability on such intermediary or entity responsible for such delay in unblocking. Further, investors shall be entitled to compensation in the manner specified in the SEBI Master Circular no. SEBI/HO/MIRSD/POD-1/P/CIR/2024/37 dated May 07, 2024 in case of delays in resolving investor grievances in relation to blocking/unblocking of fund and the provisions shall also be deemed to be incorporated in the deemed agreement of the Company with the SCSBs to the extent applicable. The BRLM shall, in their sole discretion, identify and fix the liability on such intermediary or entity responsible for such delay in unblocking. For the avoidance of doubt, the provisions of the SEBI Master Circular no. SEBI/HO/MIRSD/POD-1/P/CIR/2024/37 dated May 07, 2024 shall be deemed to be incorporated in the agreements to be entered into by and between the Company and the relevant intermediaries, to the extent applicable.*
The processing fees for applications made by UPI Bidders using the UPI Mechanism may be released to the remitter banks (SCSBs) only after such banks provide a written confirmation on compliance with the SEBI master circular (SEBI/HO/CFD/PoD-1/P/CIR/2024/0154 2023) dated November 11, 2024.

Submission of Bids:

Bid/ Offer Period (except the Bid/Offer Closing Date)	
Submission and Revision in Bids	Only between 10.00 a.m. and 5.00 p.m. IST
Bid/Offer Closing Date*	
Submission of electronic applications (Online ASBA through 3-in-1 accounts) - For Retail Individual Bidders	Only between 10.00 a.m. and up to 5.00 p.m. IST
Submission of electronic applications (Bank ASBA through Online channels like internet banking, mobile banking and Syndicate UPI ASBA applications where Bid Amount is up to ₹0.50 million)	Only between 10.00 a.m. and up to 4.00 p.m. IST
Submission of electronic applications (Syndicate non-retail, non-individual applications)	Only between 10.00 a.m. and up to 3.00 p.m. IST
Submission of physical applications (Bank ASBA)	Only between 10.00 a.m. and up to 1.00 p.m. IST
Submission of physical applications (Syndicate non-retail, non-individual applications where Bid Amount is more than ₹0.50 million)	Only between 10.00 a.m. and up to 12.00 p.m. IST
Modification/ revision/cancellation of Bids	
Upward revision of Bids by QIBs and Non-Institutional Bidders categories#	Only between 10.00 a.m. and up to 5.00 p.m. IST on Bid/ Offer Closing Date
Upward or downward Revision of Bids or cancellation of Bids by	Only between 10.00 a.m. and up to 5.00 p.m. IST on

** UPI mandate end time and date shall be at 5:00 pm on Bid/ Offer Closing Date.*
 # QIBs and Non-Institutional Bidders can neither revise their bids downwards nor cancel/withdraw their bids.

On the Bid/Offer Closing Date, the Bids shall be uploaded until:

a) 4.00 p.m. IST in case of Bids by QIBs and Non-Institutional Bidders, and

b) Until 5.00 p.m. IST or such extended time as permitted by the Stock Exchanges, in case of Bids by Retail Individual Bidders.

On Bid/Offer Closing Date, extension of time may be granted by Stock Exchanges only for uploading Bids received by Retail Individual Bidders after taking into account the total number of Bids received up to closure of timings for acceptance of Bid cum Application Forms as stated herein and as reported by the BRLM to the Stock Exchanges.

ASBA*	Simple, Safe, Smart way of Application – Make use of it!!!	*Applications Supported by Blocked Amount (ASBA) is a better way of applying to Offers by simply blocking the fund in the bank account, investors can avail the same. For details, check section on ASBA below. **Mandatory in Public Issues. No cheque will be accepted.**

UPI – Now available in ASBA for Retail Individual Investors and Non-Institutional Investors applying in public issues where the application amount is up to ₹ 0.50 million, applying through Registered Broker, Syndicate, CDPs & RTAs. UPI Bidders also have the option to submit the application directly to the ASBA Bank (SCSBs) or to use the facility of linked online trading, demat and bank account. Bidders are required to ensure that the bank account used for bidding is linked to their PAN. Bidders must ensure that their PAN is linked with Aadhar and are in compliance with CBDT notification dated February 13, 2020 issued by Central Board of Direct Taxes and the subsequent press releases, including press release dated June 25, 2021 read with press release dated September 17, 2021, and CBDT circular no. 7 of 2022 dated March 30, 2022, read with press release dated March 28, 2023 and any subsequent press release in this regard.

ASBA has to be availed by all the investors except Anchor Investors. UPI may be availed by (i) Retail Individual Investors; and (ii) Non-Institutional Investors applying in public issue where the application amount is up to ₹ 0.50 million in the Non-Institutional Portion. For details on the ASBA and UPI process, please refer to the details given in the Bid Cum Application Forms and Abridged Prospectus and also please refer to the section "Offer Procedure" beginning on page 576 of the RHP. The process is also available on the website of Association of Investment Bankers of India ("AIBI") and Stock Exchanges in the General Information Document. The Bid Cum Application Forms and the Abridged Prospectus can be downloaded from the websites of Stock Exchanges and can be obtained from the list of banks that is displaying on website of SEBI at www.sebi.gov.in/sebiweb/other/OtherAction.do?doRecognisedFpi=yes&intmId=35 and https://www.sebi.gov.in/sebiweb/other/OtherAction.do? doRecognisedFpi=yes&intmId=43, respectively as updated form time to time. For the list of UPI Apps and Banks live on IPO, please refer to the link: www.sebi.gov.in. UPI Bidders Bidding using the UPI Mechanism may apply through SCSBs and mobile applications whose names appear on the website of SEBI, as updated from time to time. HDFC Bank Limited and Axis Bank Limited have been appointed as Sponsor Bank for the Offer in accordance with the requirements of the SEBI Circular dated November 01, 2018, as amended. For Offer related queries, please contact the BRLM on its email ID as mentioned below. For UPI related queries, investors can contact NPCI at the toll free number: 18001201740 and mail ID: ipo.upi@npci.org.in

THE EQUITY SHARES OF OUR COMPANY WILL GET LISTED ON THE MAIN BOARD PLATFORMS OF BSE AND NSE

In case of any revision in the Price Band, the Bid/Offer Period shall be extended by at least three additional Working Days following such revision of the Price Band, subject to the Bid/Offer Period not exceeding 10 Working Days. In cases of *force majeure,* banking strike or similar circumstances, our Company in consultation with the BRLM, may, for reasons to be recorded in writing, extend the Bid/Offer Period for a minimum of one Working Day, subject to the Bid/Offer Period not exceeding 10 Working Days. Any revision in Price Band, and the revised Bid/Offer Period, if applicable, shall be widely disseminated by notification to the Stock Exchanges, by issuing a public notice, and also by indicating the change on the website of the BRLM and at the terminals of the Syndicate Member and by intimation to the Designated Intermediaries and the Sponsor Banks, as applicable.

The Offer is being made in terms of Rule 19(2)(b) of the SCRR, read with Regulation 31 of the SEBI ICDR Regulations. The Offer is being made through the Book Building Process, in compliance with Regulation 6(1) of the SEBI ICDR Regulations wherein not more than 50% of the Offer shall be available for allocation on a proportionate basis to Qualified Institutional Buyers ("QIBs") (such portion referred to as "QIB Portion") provided that our Company, in consultation with the BRLM, may allocate up to 60% of the QIB Portion to Anchor Investors and the basis of such allocation will be on a discretionary basis in accordance with the SEBI ICDR Regulations (the "Anchor Investor Portion"), of which 40% of the Anchor Investor Portion will be reserved for allocation in the following manner: (i) 33.33% to domestic Mutual Funds, and (ii) 6.67% to life insurance companies and pension funds in accordance with the SEBI ICDR Regulations. In the event of under-subscription or non-allocation in the Anchor Investor Portion, the balance Equity Shares shall be added to the Net QIB Portion. (other than the Anchor Investor Portion). Further, 5% of the QIB Portion shall be available for allocation on a proportionate basis only to Mutual Funds subject to valid Bids being received at or above the Offer Price, and the remainder of the QIB Portion shall be available for allocation on a proportionate basis to all QIBs, including Mutual Funds, subject to valid Bids being received at or above the Offer Price. However, if the aggregate demand from Mutual Funds is less than 5% of the QIB Portion, the balance Equity Shares available for allocation in Mutual Fund Portion will be added to the remaining QIB Portion for proportionate allocation to QIBs. Further, not less than 15% of the Offer shall be available for allocation to NIIs (out of which: (a) one-third of the portion available to NIIs will be for allocation to Bidders with a Bid size of more than ₹ 0.20 million and up to ₹ 1.00 million ; and two-thirds of the Non-Institutional Category will be available for allocation to Bidders with Bid size of more than ₹ 1.00 million and under-subscription in either of these two sub- categories of Non-Institutional Category may be allocated to Bidders in the other sub-category of Non-Institutional Category). Further, not less than 35% of the Offer shall be available for allocation to RIIs, in accordance with the SEBI ICDR Regulations, subject to valid Bids being received from them at or above the Offer Price. In case of revision of Price Band, the Bid Lot shall remain the same. All potential Bidders (except Anchor Investors) are required to mandatorily utilize the Application Supported by Blocked Amount ("ASBA") process by providing details of their respective ASBA Accounts and UPI ID (in case of UPI bidders using the UPI Mechanism (as defined hereinafter)), in which case the corresponding Bid Amounts will be blocked by the SCSBs or under the UPI Mechanism, as applicable to participate in the Offer. Anchor Investors are not permitted to participate in the Anchor Investor Portion of the Offer through ASBA process. For details, kindly refer *"Offer Procedure"* beginning on page 576 of the RHP.

Bidders/Applicants should ensure that DP ID, PAN and the Client ID (for UPI Bidders bidding through UPI Mechanism) are correctly file in the Bid Cum Application Form. The DP ID, PAN and Client ID provided in the Bid cum Application Form should match with the DP ID, PAN, Client ID and UPI ID (for UPI Bidders bidding through the UPI Mechanism) in the Depository database, otherwise, the Bid cum Application Form is liable to be rejected. Bidders/Applicants should note that on the basis of the PAN, DP ID, Client ID and UPI ID (for UPI Bidders bidding through UPI mechanism) as provided in the Bid cum Application Form, the Bidder/Applicant may be deemed to have authorized the Depositories to provide to the Registrar to the Offer, any requested Demographic Details of the Bidder/Applicant as available on the records of the depositories. These Demographic details may be used, among other things, for giving Allotment Advice or unblocking of ASBA Account or for other correspondence(s) related to the Offer. Bidders/Applicants are advised to update any changes to their Demographic Details as available in the records of the Depository Participant to ensure accuracy of records. Any delay resulting from failure to update the Demographic Details would be at the Bidders/Applicants sole risk.

CONTENTS OF THE MEMORANDUM OF ASSOCIATION OF OUR COMPANY AS REGARDS ITS OBJECTS: For information on the main objects and other objects of our Company, kindly refer *"Our History and Certain Corporate Matters"* beginning on page 328 of the RHP. The Memorandum of Association of our Company is a material document for inspection in relation to the Offer. For further details, kindly refer *"Material Contracts and Documents for Inspection"* beginning on page 618 of the RHP.

LIABILITY OF MEMBERS OF THE COMPANY: Limited by shares.

AMOUNT OF SHARE CAPITAL OF THE COMPANY AND CAPITAL STRUCTURE: As on date of RHP, the authorized share capital of the Company is ₹ 400,000,000 divided into 40,000,000 Equity Shares of face value of ₹ 10 each. The issued, subscribed and paid-up share capital of the Company before the Offer is ₹ 301,012,000 divided into 30,101,200 Equity Shares of face value of ₹ 10 each. For details of the Capital Structure, kindly refer *"Capital Structure"* beginning on page 113 of the RHP.

Continued on next page...

millenniumpost
FRIDAY, 7 AUGUST, 2026 | NEW DELHI

Turning the tide

Indian batters aim to ace spin test in warm-up before Test series against SL

COLOMBO: The Indian batters will be keen to fine-tune their skills against spin during a three-day warm-up match against a local Sri Lanka XI at the Nondescripts Cricket Club here on Friday as they gear up for a two-match Test series against the Islanders next week.

Quality spin proved to be India's Achilles Heel against New Zealand and South Africa at home recently, and the challenge will not be any different against Sri Lanka.

The Islanders have a capable unit of tweakers, particularly in home conditions, and thus this warm-up match assumes massive importance for Indian batters ahead of the first Test at Galle on August 15.

Some frontline batters like skipper Shubman Gill, KL Rahul and Yashasvi Jaiswal had started preparations against spin individually at their home facilities before boarding the flight to Colombo, but that cannot really supplant an outing on a Sri Lankan pitch.

Shubman Gill and Company arrive in Galle ahead of their two-match Test series PTI

The three-day match will give them valuable first-hand idea about local conditions, and it is important because many of them are playing the red-ball format for the first time on these shores.

India's last Test series in Sri Lanka was in 2017, and the team composition has undergone vast changes in the last decade.

In fact, only Rahul, Kuldeep Yadav and Ravindra Jadeja in this squad have appeared in Test matches in Sri Lanka.

In the absence of an injured Jasprit Bumrah, pacer Mohammed Siraj will be India's bowling lead with support coming from Prasidh Krishna, Gurnoor Brar, Manav Suthar and Saransh Jain.

This largely inexperienced bowling lineup, except Siraj and Kuldeep, will be eager to bowl on a Lankan pitch once again.

Both Brar and Jain had very good outings for India A against Sri Lanka A last month at Galle, and they will be raring to have another round of practice under their belt.

> Quality spin proved to be India's Achilles Heel against New Zealand and South Africa at home recently, and the challenge will not be any different against Sri Lanka

Head Coach Gautam Gambhir emphasised on this point. "We know what is in front of us. We can do volume, we can push our limits, we can tick all the boxes and come 15th morning whether we are batting first or bowling first we will be absolutely ready with every answer to every question thrown at us.

"So make sure to tick all the boxes from now on," Gambhir exhorted his wards in a video posted by BCCI.

However, intermittent rain is predicted to lash the city from Friday and that may jeopardise India's designs.

Meanwhile, Sri Lanka also announced a strong SLC XI that contained some front-runners to make it to the Test squad. Led by Sonal Dinusha, who has played three Tests for SL, the squad features pacers Vishwa Fernando, Lahiru Kumara and spinners Isitha Wijesundara and Ramesh Mendis. AGENCIES

'WE'LL BE READY WITH ALL ANSWERS'

Amid Test gloom, Gambhir assures of 'answers' by Aug 15

COLOMBO: Their home Test run in recent past may not have been particularly impressive but India head coach Gautam Gambhir has asserted that his team will be ready with all the answers when the two-Test series against Sri Lanka gets underway here from August 15.

In a short address to the team before a practice session here, Gambhir also welcomed the new entrants -- spin-bowling all-rounder Saransh Jain and pacer Auqib Nabi.

"We know what's in front of us, we know what we are playing for. We can do the volume, we can push our limits, we can tick all the boxes," Gambhir said in the video shared by BCCI on social media. "Come 15th morning (August 15), whether we are batting first, whether we are bowling first, we're absolutely ready with every answer, every question that's thrown at us, and every answer we are ready to give. So make sure we tick all the boxes from now on," he added.

Gautam Gambhir ahead of the team's departure PTI

The first match of the series will be played in Galle from August 15 while the second game will be held here from August 23. It would be India's first ICC World Test Championship assignment since the disastrous 0-2 home defeat to South Africa in December last year. Saransh has been picked in the squad on the basis of his consistently fine run for Madhya Pradesh in the domestic circuit. Nabi is in to replace an injured Jasprit Bumrah. He played a stellar role in J&K's maiden title-winning run in Ranji Trophy last season.

> We know what's in front of us, we know what we are playing for. We can do the volume, we can push our limits, we can tick all the boxes
> — Gautam Gambhir

"We've got a couple of new guys in. To start with, Saransh, congratulations. You've worked extremely hard to be here," Gambhir said welcoming the 33-year-old late bloomer.

"Make sure that you make your family and your country proud, whenever you get that opportunity. Secondly, I want to congratulate Auqib. You had a phenomenal last season, made J&K win the Ranji Trophy, which is a great achievement. Congratulations once again," he added. AGENCIES

'Please reconsider JFC's withdrawal': AIFF chief appeals to Tata group

NEW DELHI: All India Football Federation (AIFF) President Kalyan Chaubey has urged the Tata group to reconsider its "shocking" decision of withdrawing Jamshedpur FC from the embattled Indian Super League (ISL).

The Tata group has made it clear that JFC's exit from the ISL was a long-planned strategic decision to ensure that the company returns to its core ideal of grassroots football development. Tata Steel vice President (Corporate Services) D B Sundara Ramam has also insisted that the move has "nothing to do" with the uncertainty surrounding the ISL's commercial future and would not be reconsidered.

However, Chaubey said the AIFF would still hope for a rethink by the legacy corporate house.

"AIFF would be happy if Tata remains in football, especially in senior top tier football. If an AIFF request or application can change their mind... the AIFF would like to appeal that for the interest of the players and football, Tata should remain in the senior football league," Chaubey told PTI in an interview.

"The AIFF welcomes any suggestion (from them) and is ready to incorporate the suggestions to ensure the best outcome," he said.

Tata Steel has assured that Jamshedpur FC will honour all existing player contracts and help footballers find new clubs.

The AIFF president said he has faith in Tata group and its decisions cannot be driven by commercial interests.

"It's all about, I think, some decision in the boardroom. And I'm sure there are reasons, but it cannot be for Rs 1.1 crore participation fee or management fee. It is not that. When the board decided to withdraw the senior team from the top-tier league, I am sure they had a reason for taking this harsh decision. They are aware of the football fans' reaction, but I assume this cannot be only a financial decision because Tata has many enterprises and businesses," he observed.

The former India goalkeeper said he has immense respect for the group's contribution to the sport's growth through the Tata Football Academy that has been in operation since 1987. Chaubey too has trained in that facility during his playing days.

"We have seen many corporates become very prominent over the last few decades, but we have also seen many corporates go bankrupt thereafter. But Tata is different. It has gained that respect, earned that respect among Indians," he noted. "Tata will never consider sports merely as a medium for business, revenue generation, profit, or loss. They have done so much for Indian sport."

They have invested in archery and several other areas, and in football, I think most of the youth development system has come through the Tata Football Academy," the former India player added.

Chaubey recalled how the academy survived a financial crisis in the '90s.

"...it was rumoured that TFA would be closed down, the Archery Academy would start, the Engineer Hostel would start, and the Cricket Academy would start. Many rumours were there." AGENCIES

'Pakistan can hold India to a draw in hockey WC'

LAHORE: Chief selector Samiullah Khan on Thursday said that Pakistan can hold arch-rivals India to a draw in their hockey World Cup clash on August 19, which will be the key for them to get past the first round pool stage in the showpiece in Belgium and the Netherlands.

Pakistan on Wednesday announced a 20-member squad for the World Cup (August 15-30) in which the national team is taking part after eight years.

"Look, realistically the key is holding India at least to a draw and we have the capacity to beat Wales but our toughest opponent is England who are ranked high while we are placed 12th right now in the FIH rankings," Samiullah, a former Pakistan captain, said on Thursday. Samiullah said that team director and chief coach Herman Kruis will join the squad directly in the Netherlands where he is presently on a pre tournament assignment. Pakistan Hockey Federation (PHF) has also brought in two foreign coaches, Bob Johan Veldhof and Christopher Bowen to assist Kruis. AGENCIES

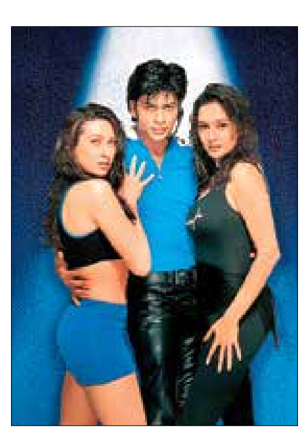
Leisure

'Dance made me more expressive as an actor'

Karisma returned as a judge on TV dance reality show 'India's Best Dancer' S5

Dance not only made her one of Hindi cinema's most popular performers but also helped shape her as an actor, said Bollywood star Karisma Kapoor. The 51-year-old actress, who has returned as a judge on the television dance reality show 'India's Best Dancer Season 5', made a mark in the 1990s with her energetic and expressive dance style in hit songs such as 'Le Gayi', 'Sona Kitna Sona Hai', 'Main Toh Raste Se Ja Raha Tha' and 'Husn Hai Suhana'.

"As a dancer, you have to be very expressive.



And only if you are very expressive will you be considered a good dancer. Dancing is not just a robotic thing, so you have to be very expressive in any sort of dance form. So, it helped me in my career, especially for expressions and in songs and in acting," she told PTI in an interview.

While dancing brought her popularity, Karisma credits its films such as 'Fiza' and 'Zubeidaa' for proving her acting range. "Films like 'Fiza', 'Zubeidaa', 'Shakti' and 'Biwi No. 1' also have been an integral part of my journey. It proved I could do both. They're all pieces of my heart," Kapoor said.

> While dancing brought her popularity, she credited films 'Fiza' and 'Zubeidaa' for proving her acting range

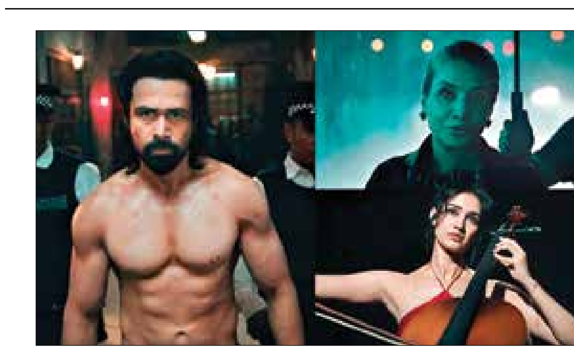
The actress said her passion for dance began in her childhood through formal training in Bharatanatyam, Kathak and later used to go for the classes. I just loved acting, loved dance and anything artistic and creative," she said.

Karisma also credited the late legendary choreographer Saroj Khan for shaping her Bollywood dance vocabulary. "Saroj Khan ji has been my guru. I've been to her dance classes and she would train me. In fact, she would train me in Bollywood dance on 'Tamma Tamma' of Madhuri Dixit and Sanjay Dutt. At that time, she was choreographing that song and she would tell her team, 'This is my new song and teach her song," she recalled.

Talking about her dance face-off with Madhuri Dixit Nene in the 1997 movie 'Dil Toh Pagal Hai', Karisma said it was among the toughest song sequences of her career. PTI

'AWARAPAN 2' TRAILER

Emraan returns as Shivam Pandit



Disha Patani, Shabana Azmi and others also star in the film

Nineteen years after 'Awarapan', Emraan Hashmi is back as the brooding Shivam Pandit in 'Awarapan 2' with the sequel's trailer promising a high-stakes tale of vengeance, redemption and unfinished business.

The trailer, unveiled by 'Vishesh Films', sees Shivam returning older and scarred as he embarks on a mission driven by revenge while confronting the consequences of his past. Hashmi returns in the lead role alongside Disha Patani, who joins the franchise as Zara. Veteran actress Shabana Azmi also features in the film as Nafisa. The cast also includes Puran Gabbi as Zorawar, Anirudh Rawal as Sikandar, Surendar Vicky as Jaideep, Vijayant Kohli as Mehmood and Atul Kumar as Samarth.

> The trailer promises a high-stakes tale of vengeance, redemption and unfinished business

The sequel's music has been composed by Mithoon, Jeet Gannguli, Amaal Malik, Ankit Sachdev and Wasif Ahmad, with lyrics by Sayeed Quadri, Rashmi Virag, Akhil Sachdeva and Sachin Singh Chandel.

Songs such as 'Ve Junoon', 'Yeh Awarapan' and 'Toh Phir Aao' have already been released ahead of the film. 'Tera Mera Rishta', composed by Mithoon and sung by Saaj Bhatt and Subodhh Sharma, features prominently in the trailer. PTI

Netflix renews 'Musafir Café' for a second season

Streaming giant 'Netflix' announced that Vikrant Massey, Vedika Pinto and Mahima Makwana-starrer romantic drama 'Musafir Café' has been renewed for a second season. The series, which gained popularity soon after its release last month, revolves around the characters of Chander, Sudha and Preeti as they navigate love and life through a series of choices.

The next chapter, the streamer said, will answer some of the questions audiences have been living with after they watched the story.

"'Musafir Café' has captured the hearts of audiences all over. The conversations about the show have hijacked the Internet with debates about the ending and what lies ahead, the dialogues, the characters and the music. Romance as a genre, when done right, captures hearts and conversations as no other genre does. We are bullish about building this genre, like we built comedy for our members. And I'm happy to announce 'Musafir Café' S02 will be an integral part of that slate. We can't wait to take this tale of love and longing into its next exciting phase," Tanya Bami, Series Head, 'Netflix India' said. PTI